

Acceptance & Commitment Therapy Toolbox

90 Worksheets & Exercises

To Help Overcome
Depression, Addiction,
OCD, & Reduce Anxiety

Calvin Caufield

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90 Exercises and Worksheets to
Help Overcome Depression, Addiction,
OCD, and Reduce Anxiety

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How to Use This Book With an Ebook Device

Throughout this book you'll be prompted to write answers to questions, fill in tables, and interact with the content in various ways. If you're reading on a touch-screen device, you can leave notes and even highlight text as you would in a physical book.

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Having a separate journal to write answers in may be preferable. If you choose this method, each tool is numbered systematically for your reference.

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PART 1 – INTRODUCTION

More than 50% of all people will be diagnosed with a mental illness or disorder at some point in their lifetime.¹ Taking into account unreported cases, numbers are likely to be higher. The diseases of the brain are to be taken just as seriously as any health conditions of the rest of the body. We are lucky to be living in a time when classical and alternative treatment options, as well as worldwide acceptance of mental disorders, are on the rise. Still, much stigma exists from society around mental disorders. Even affected persons often shy away from seeking professional treatment and direction early on. Many mental illnesses, if left untreated, get worse, accelerate aging, or raise the risk of overall poor health later in life.² And even if we are not struggling with a mental disorder, all of us have certain patterns and behaviors that keep us from living our life to the fullest potential. We tend to know what these patterns and behaviors are. Even if we don't like to admit it, we know. Once we admit and see, it becomes harder to look away and more painful to actually be with these limiting patterns and behaviors. The healing journey can begin exactly in this moment. Once we allow ourselves to see problematic thinking, behavior, and patterns, we are one step closer to living the life we truly aspire to live. And this is exactly what this book can and will support you with.

Since you picked up this book, it is likely that you or someone you know or are working with is struggling with a mental disorder right as you are reading these lines. Admitting to and overcoming mental illnesses such as anxiety, addiction, OCD, eating disorders, depression, burnout, and chronic stress (just to name the most predominant), often is a journey of many months, years, or sometimes even a lifetime, depending on the person, the illness, and available support. Luckily, psychotherapeutic support in person or online is becoming more and more available and affordable. And so are resources in the form of books, workbooks, even apps. Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) has long been proven to be very effective when treating psychological illnesses, especially anxiety and depression.³ A newer type of therapy integrating a more mindful and accepting healing approach, Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT, pronounced as the word

ACT), is becoming widely recognized as an effective way to treat a variety of mental health problems.⁴ The founder of ACT, Steven Hayes, originally named it “comprehensive distancing” and founded it in 1982. While research of ACT is still limited, integrating an Eastern mindfulness and acceptance approach into the therapeutic work, seems more than promising. While CBT looks to work by altering how people think and behave, ACT works through a more gentle and direct approach, working with accepting and altering the relationship with our thinking and behavior. Presence and acceptance of what is, whilst also becoming more intimate with thoughts and emotions, seeing them as phenomena that come and go. Eastern mindfulness principles together with behavioral therapy, ACT to me is one of the most promising therapeutic models out there today. Let’s explore the six different principles of ACT briefly:

- Acceptance: Willingness to experience difficult thoughts, emotions, and sensations; Awareness of our limitations
- Defusion: Observe thoughts, emotions, and sensations without being controlled by them. Being able to alter the relationship to any of these
- Being Present: Focus on the here and now.
- Self-as-Context: Connection with something “bigger”, unchanging; Stepping into the role of the observer
- Values: Discover what is truly important to you.
- Committed Action: Take action to pursue living the value-based life you aspire to live. Make the necessary changes in your life.

These six principles all aim to increase psychological flexibility or how a person adapts to fluctuating situations and demands, shift perspectives, and reconfigure mental resources.⁵ ACT helps people to stay focused on the present moment and accept thoughts, feelings, and emotions without judgment. It helps you move through difficult thoughts and feelings so you can put your energy into healing and improving your life toward valued behavior. Instead of avoiding situations in which unpleasant feelings or behavior are evoked, ACT teaches people to be with and open up to these feelings and thoughts instead, not just contemplating and dwelling on these,

but looking for ways to move forward in committed action. In this approach ACT is unique and an increasing number of studies, especially over the last years, are showing that this approach is working for all kinds of conditions such as anxiety, depression, substance abuse, and in treating chronic pain.⁶ Of course, treatment with ACT and finding relief also takes time, just like any other psychotherapeutic approach. Yet the gentle and comprehensive approach ACT suggests has proven to and will continue to really make a positive impact on people's mental health.

As a coach, and passionate meditator, who has also happened to overcome an array of mental health struggles myself, ACT is the only method known to me that brings such a mindful yet effective therapeutic approach. Humans aren't like robots; we can't just delete or change certain thoughts and feelings by pressing a button. We all know that the more we fight and suppress certain thoughts and feelings, it usually makes our experience of these worse. Learning to just be with difficult, painful, obsessive, irrational thoughts and emotions, is one of the most difficult, yet important things we can ever learn in life. We see and learn how everything that arises also passes again, even if it seems to take forever. And ACT doesn't stop there, it continues helping people define what makes their lives valuable and meaningful, and sets them up to take action exactly in this direction. ACT breaks through treating people just at the level of the personality and works towards healing the being as a whole.

In this book you will find 90 practical, everyday tools and exercises following the ACT model that you or clients can do to help overcome whatever struggles. These tools are intended to be used by people suffering from mental illnesses, but also people longing to bring about a change towards a more fulfilling and value-based life. If you are struggling from a mental disorder at this time, ideally you can work through these tools with the supervision of a licensed therapist.

How to Use:

In this book you will find the 6 principles of the ACT model separated into different chapters. Each chapter begins with a brief explanation of the principle and then introduces 15 powerful and effective tools for this ACT component. The tools can be worked through in order or done individually

depending on you or your clients' needs. There is a logical buildup of depth of the tools, meaning that later tools often require a bit more self-understanding and self-reflection. Yet every tool is effective and powerful on its own. We recommend that rather than working through this toolkit from beginning to end (if you have the time and persistence, of course, please do), you pick 2 or 3 principles where you or your clients/patients are currently struggling. If you are newly supporting a client or patient, it can be wise to start with the principle of acceptance, being present, and self-as-context, as you get to know their specific reality. Use your intuition and/or professional training on what you feel is right for you or someone you are currently working with. There isn't really a wrong way to go about this, and you will notice what types of tools work best for you or your client.

Most of the tools are deep self-reflections in the form of questions, tables, or charts to fill in. You will also find practical tools that invite you to try or do something, are set up like quizzes, or have a more creative (even artistic) approach. All tools aim to bring more clarity, understanding, and facilitate the path towards a meaningful, value-based life, free of limitations and suffering. At this point, no other ACT book is known to us that encompasses a total of 90 tools. These tools are practical and hands-on and can be used by individuals or in therapeutic sessions. Note that some of these tools may be more or less available to you at this moment, depending on the severity of your current symptoms. None of these tools are meant to downplay how you are feeling at the moment. If you are currently suffering from severe symptoms and have thoughts of hurting yourself or someone else, please seek the help of a trained, licensed therapist. Do not use any of these without professional guidance and support, unless you feel stable and grounded and are able to hold space for any arising intense emotions, sensations, thoughts, or even painful or traumatic memories.

Who This Book Is For:

- Mental health professionals working as therapists, psychologists, or other related professions who are looking for helpful resources for their clients
- Clients working with a therapist or other mental health professional who are looking for or have been recommended reading material to supplement their work with said professional
- People interested in improving their mental health by learning more about acceptance and commitment therapy, and not necessarily working with a professional
- People looking to have a general understanding of ACT, as well as deepen your understanding of how ACT can be applied in therapy as well as for self-growth
- People looking for hands-on tools and practices to each of the 6 ACT principles
- People who love the ACT method, but have never found enough tools they can use for themselves or their clients
- People who want to deepen their understanding of the importance and meaning of each ACT principle by studying different tools for reflection and growth to each topic
- People who love the effectiveness of behavioral therapy but are longing for a gentler, more compassionate therapeutic approach

This book can and will help patients and clients, as well as individuals looking to improve their lives. Life is too short to continue living in and with our limitations of the mind. As Mae West said, “You only live once, but if you do it right, one time is enough”. What are you waiting for? Take charge of your mental health and live the meaningful and purpose driven life you've always aspired to live.

I hope you enjoy the book.

May it bring you as many insights and show you a clear way forward, just like it has for me personally, as well as my clients.

PART 2 – THE TOOLS

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1. ACT TOOLS FOR ACCEPTANCE

We start with the tools for acceptance. Remember that acceptance means to be in active and direct contact with the psychological experience, without avoiding, ignoring, or suppressing. Acceptance is about acknowledging and embracing what is happening on the inside. While we may not be able to immediately change the thoughts, emotions, or sensations we are having, we can influence our relationship with these experiences. Of course, many of these internal experiences are happening because of external events. If we are suffering from general anxiety, then we are likely to worry, be restless, and may even have trouble sleeping. We might have a big upcoming meeting at work, or one of our kids may be struggling in school. Mostly, we cannot influence these external events, and therefore need to focus on how our mind and body is reacting to them. Reinhold Niebuhr describes this well in his version of the Serenity Prayer as he states “grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, courage to change the things I can, and the wisdom to know the difference”. Acceptance in ACT means to accept the experiences that are within your sphere of influence, meaning those experiences happening on the inside.⁷

Surely you have had the experience that if you avoid or fight with certain thoughts or emotions, it actually enhances and exacerbates the way you experience them.⁸ For example, if you are struggling from OCD and are trying to suppress an intrusive, unwanted thought, it rebounds and reoccurs. The initial thought occurred automatically, naturally, and with no mental effort. For someone not struggling with OCD, these thoughts may also occur, they just won't be given much attention. As soon as we suppress something, this becomes a controlled and conscious process, usually reinforcing whatever it is we are experiencing. So, once we learn to be with our thoughts, emotions, and sensations without fighting them, we automatically send less energy towards them, making them become less and less intrusive or threatening over time.⁹ Eventually we might no longer need to avoid certain people, situations, or experiences in order to stay emotionally, mentally, and physically balanced. We can go about life, our purpose. Life becomes freer in this way.

A core aspect of acceptance is awareness, the awareness of what is actually happening in our being.¹⁰ Someone who does not know that sweaty palms, heart racing, shortness of breath, trembling, or shaking can be the symptoms of an impending panic attack, might call an ambulance or drive to the nearest hospital. More awareness of these symptoms and how they are linked to an underlying psychological condition brings more clarity and potentially even calmness when they do arise. It's like the mind is able to better sort things that are happening in this way, thoughts, emotions, or like in this case, sensations. The tools in this chapter will focus on acceptance, BUT also allow you to become more aware of what is happening. Often it is helpful to look at the different aspects of our being (emotions, sensations, and thoughts) separately at first, knowing that they are all connected.

So, let's dive into the tools supporting acceptance.

1.1 What in the World Is Happening

To accept what is happening, we need to understand what is happening, clearly pinpointing if it is a thought, an emotion, a sensation, or a combination that is bothering us at the moment.¹⁰ Becoming intimate with each of these aspects is a crucial piece of acceptance. How can we accept what we cannot pinpoint or name, what in the world is going on? We might not understand exactly where it is coming from, or what the reason is (at least not yet), but we need to understand what it is we are trying to accept.

For starters, it can be extremely helpful to just slow down. Maybe you realize something does not quite feel right. It might be at the level of the body, or it might be a thought or a sudden arising of emotions. Whatever it is, and whatever the reason, the invitation is to stop for a moment and turn all the attention inward. You might need to find a space where you can safely and privately practice this. Have you noticed how your boss is always going to the bathroom every time things get intense in a meeting? Or you might find that certain people regularly disappear for a few minutes at family gatherings? It could just be that they are taking space to sort out something that is happening internally. To tune inward, we need to turn off what is happening on the outside, so it is best to find a space where we can be with ourselves.

This might not be easy, as we have been conditioned to stay in certain situations, even if we feel uncomfortable. Yet, with practice, we can learn to smoothly “remove ourselves” from these situations that are triggering something within. This helps us gain clarity over our inner movements.

This first tool invites you to do exactly this: Next time you find yourself in a situation where you feel something is up, find a space where you can be undisturbed with yourself. You do not need to understand exactly what is on, in order to find yourself that space. You will notice simply an inner movement of discomfort, irritation, or confusion, like something is up.

When you notice this, find a space where you can be by yourself. This can be a public bathroom, your closet, or even just sitting at your work desk and closing your eyes. The goal is to turn off the outside. The less you hear and see, the more this can help you explore processes inside. Make sure you are in a safe place to do this.

Then, answer the following questions to gain clarity of what is happening on the inside:

What exactly am I experiencing at this moment?

- _____
- _____

What bodily sensations can I perceive?

- _____
- _____

What thoughts am I having?

- _____
- _____

What emotions are present?

- _____
- _____

Sometimes it is not easy to answer each of these questions. This may take practice and as we become more attuned with our inner processes, we will get better at this. Also remember, there is no wrong or right. Your experiences are your experiences, and they are simply the way they are.

1.2 Thought Distortions

For people that are struggling with psychological illnesses such as addiction, depression, anxiety, OCD, post-traumatic stress, eating disorders, any kind of illness really, it is likely that many things are happening simultaneously without conscious awareness. For someone struggling with alcohol addiction, the mere sight or thought of a glass of wine will trigger a chain of events within the body, resulting in sensations of sweaty palms and heart racing, then causing a chain of emotions such as excitement, longing, and desire. The order of the chain of events and link between thoughts, sensations, and emotions is different for every person and every situation.

The key to more acceptance of what is happening internally is to create more understanding of the distinct nature of each of these three aspects. Thoughts, sensations, and emotions are distinct phenomena that are happening within. We can see these with more clarity once we pick them apart. It's like we become a scientist and researcher of our own psychology. This approach is not intended to downplay obsessive, intrusive, painful, or sometimes even seemingly life-threatening events that are going on inside. The idea is to show a way out. When we get to a point where we are suffering so much that it fully consumes us from the inside, taking all of life's joy and purpose, we need to try to do things to bring back meaning and purpose in our life. Understanding what in the world is going on helps with this.

While every psychological illness has its challenges at the level of the body, emotions, and mind, worldwide people today seem to be struggling more than ever from intrusive, worrying, doubting, or obsessive thoughts. We have around 12,000 to 60,000 thoughts per day, and around 80% are

negative.¹¹ Newer studies suggest this number to be lower, still the number of thoughts per day and hour are plenty.¹² And you might see how this can be challenging for keeping a positive, good-spirited approach to life, especially if we believe most of what the mind produces.

So, when looking at our thoughts, we can differentiate between helpful and unhelpful thoughts. Helpful thoughts support us in living the life we aspire to live. They help us grow and improve, and be supportive for ourselves and the people around us. Unhelpful thoughts are thoughts that do not support us in life. They hinder us. They limit us in being who we aspire to be and have negative influences on our connections. Psychology usually differentiates between positive and negative thoughts. The phrase “negative thoughts” often implies that something should not happen or is not good. So, for the purpose of facilitating change, the phrase “unhelpful thoughts” will be used in this book.

Here are examples of unhelpful thoughts:

Mark down which types specifically apply to you, and write the unhelpful thoughts that you frequently have below:

Type of Thought	Example	What is Your Version?
Overgeneralization	“All family gatherings are stressful.”	
Labeling	“I am a bad person.”	
Jumping to Conclusions	“My boss hates me.”	
Dichotomous Thinking	“Either I am going to eat nothing, or I might as well go all out.”	
Catastrophizing	“I know this event is going to cause another panic attack.”	
Mind Reading	“The way the waiter looked at me right now, he must know that I am addicted to alcohol.”	
Fortune Telling	“I am going to fail this test, as I have failed other tests in the past.”	
Emotional Reasoning	“I am anxious about going to work; therefore something is going to happen.”	

Self-Blame	“I am responsible for my partners' depression.”	
Imperatives	“I should be able to hold this speech without feeling nervous.”	
Minimizing	“Oh, how lucky am I that I got my dream job.”	

1.3 Is the Thought Really True

We cannot change that we have thousands of thoughts every day, many of which are not helpful. It seems, though, that over time and with practice, we can influence the types and quality of the thoughts we have. Here, a simple concept describes how this works: the more attention and energy we are giving to a specific thought, the more we reinforce that thought. So, putting our attention and energy on the thousands of positive thoughts we have per day can be very supportive, especially in the long run. If you are reading this toolkit, it is likely that you are not in a place where you can just think positively. You might not even remember when the last time you had a positive thought was. While it would be helpful to increase the number of and focus on positive thoughts, it's not that simple if we are in a place of despair, frustration, and helplessness. Someone telling us to just think positively is going to result in us being able to do nothing but the opposite.

What we can do, though, is learn to *be* with the thoughts. We learn to be with all the thoughts that arise, even the negative ones. Some thoughts are so intense, real, and painful, appearing repeatedly, that this is hard, and may even seem impossible. This practice is to help you see more clearly and learn to be with the thoughts that give you the most pain and struggles.

This may not be easy, but the invitation for you is to try. You have negative thoughts anyhow. Some are probably really bothering you. This practice is about simply learning to *be* with thoughts, even when they are extremely hard to be with.

For this exercise, make sure you find yourself a space where you can be undisturbed and alone for at least 5 minutes.

If you do not feel comfortable to do this practice alone, find someone that can support you, ideally a professional.

Sit or lay down, somewhere where you can comfortably rest for a few minutes. You do not need to be in your home to do this. Take a couple of deep breaths through the nose, filling your lungs and chest with plenty of air, then take a deep exhale.

Now let's look at some thoughts that are bothering you. Pick the first one that comes to mind:

The recurring thought that I have that really bothers me is:

Now ask yourself the following four questions:

1. Is this thought really true?
2. Is this thought always true?
3. What happens when I believe the thought? How do I react?
4. Who would I be without the thought?

You might have found that this specific thought is not really true, or at least is not always true. You might have also found it difficult to answer question 4. It might have created a state of mental void, no thoughts, when contemplating this question.

These four questions can be used for any restricting and limiting thoughts or ideas you have about yourself or others, and help you get out of a negative headspace.

These questions are the four key questions of Byron Katie's "The Work".¹³

What are your main takeaways of this practice?

1.4 Exploring Bodily Sensations

Many of us are somehow disconnected from the body. We learn early on to turn off signs and signals from the body. And then through recurring actions where we exceed our limits and do not listen to our specific needs, we reinforce that disconnection. We keep going when we actually need rest or keep eating long after the body has signaled that we are full. Throughout life we tend to believe our thoughts much more than the signals of the body. Yet the body is actually very wise. As Nietzsche said “There is more wisdom in your body than in your deepest philosophy.” When we are young, we know very clearly when we have had enough and when we have certain needs. We cry when we need something, and sleep when we are tired. Depending on how well our needs were met as children and how well we nourished ourselves throughout life, we all have different connections to our bodies and bodily sensations. Often athletes, or children who begin practicing or playing a sport early, have a stronger connection with their body.

What often happens in the case of anxiety, depression, addiction, and other psychological illnesses, is that bodily sensations are somehow off from the “norm”. We feel fear and anxiety because of a random work meeting or social event to meet our good friends. We feel a lack of energy and tiredness, in our entire being for weeks, even months. Or we feel specific urges in different parts of our body to do certain things or consume a substance we are addicted to. Signals from the mind and the body are so mixed and intertwined that we can no longer say what came first, or even understand the reason for having these bodily sensations.

This can become frustrating, causing intense emotions, even despair. For some reason though, the body is communicating in this way, and is sending this signal. And whether you like the signal or not, whether it drives you crazy or makes you do the things that you do not want to do, ultimately it is just a bodily sensation. The interpretation of a bodily sensation is happening in your mind. Your mind is linking the sensation with certain thoughts, causing certain emotions. At this level, simply looking at the bodily sensation, there is no problem, no drama, no pain. The difficulties arise when the mind gets involved.

So let us practice understanding and accepting bodily sensations and seeing them for what they are: simply sensations.

What are bodily sensations that you are often experiencing? Try to note all the sensations you can think of. (“positive” and “negative” ones)	Where do you feel these bodily sensations? Write down the respective body part, where you feel the sensations.	What do the sensations feel like? Describe the quality of the different sensations.

1.5 Meditation for Difficult or Painful Sensations

If you are experiencing chronic pain, fatigue, burn-out, or any other symptoms at the level of the physical body, this tool introduces a short meditation to learn to access, feel, and accept these sensations. Note that not everyone feels bodily sensations. Sometimes the sensations are very shallow, and oftentimes people describe themselves as feeling “nothing” or feeling “numb”. This applies to experiencing sensations and emotions, and can happen as a bodily response to trauma, stress, addictive patterns, or coping mechanisms. Note that even if you feel disconnected from your body or you feel numb, you can begin to feel again over time¹⁴ Numbness is also a form of sensation. The more you are disconnected from your body, the more practices and exercises for the body you should do. Dancing, sports, massages, even somatic therapies can be extremely effective.¹⁵

The short meditation that follows can work if you are experiencing any kind of bodily sensations. If you are doing this meditation alone it is best to start with this kind of work when experiencing light to medium sensations. If

you are experiencing intense sensations, such as heart racing, extreme sweating, and feeling less centered or even like you might be on the verge of your next panic attack, do not do this practice without professional guidance.

This exercise will require you to trust in yourself and in the wisdom of your body.

Sit somewhere quiet, where you will be undisturbed. Know that you can trust yourself, your bodily wisdom and that you will be OK and that sensations will come, and then pass again. If you do not feel comfortable doing this practice alone, please do it under the guidance of a trained professional.

Take a deep breath through the nose, filling your lungs and chest with air. Exhale deeply through the mouth. Try to let go of tensions, expectations, and worries.

Now take a moment to simply feel any sensations in the body. You can actually scan the entire body moving from down to up and from up to down, and observe if the attention wanders somewhere specifically. Or maybe your attention wanders directly to a specific place.

Examine what the sensations feel like.

Where do you feel the sensations?

What words would you use to describe the sensations?

Bring all your attention to the area where you feel the sensation(s). Accept the sensation(s) and whatever you feel.

What is happening when you do this?

Do the sensations get stronger, weaker?

Simply observe, breathe, and trust that you are going to be OK. Continue feeling, observing, accepting. Accept what you observe, allow it to be. Even embrace the sensations(s) if you can.

See if there is a message behind the sensation(s). Do not get lost in interpretations or too much mental activity, just see if anything comes

naturally.

Take some more moments to continue feeling. See what else arises (thoughts, emotions, memories). Simply allow the sensation(s) and whatever comes with them to be there.

Very good. You are doing very well.

Slowly we will begin to bring the attention away from the area and stop feeling into the bodily sensations.

We are still feeling the body but having less focus on that specific area.

We can feel our feet and body, how they are touching the ground.

We feel how the body is safe, how we are safe. Know that even if there were intense sensations, emotions, thoughts, or memories, you are safe in this very moment.

Please repeat these words: At this very moment, I am safe.

Repeat them as many times as you need.

And come back at your own pace.

1.6 A Range of Emotions

Emotions, emotions, emotions...

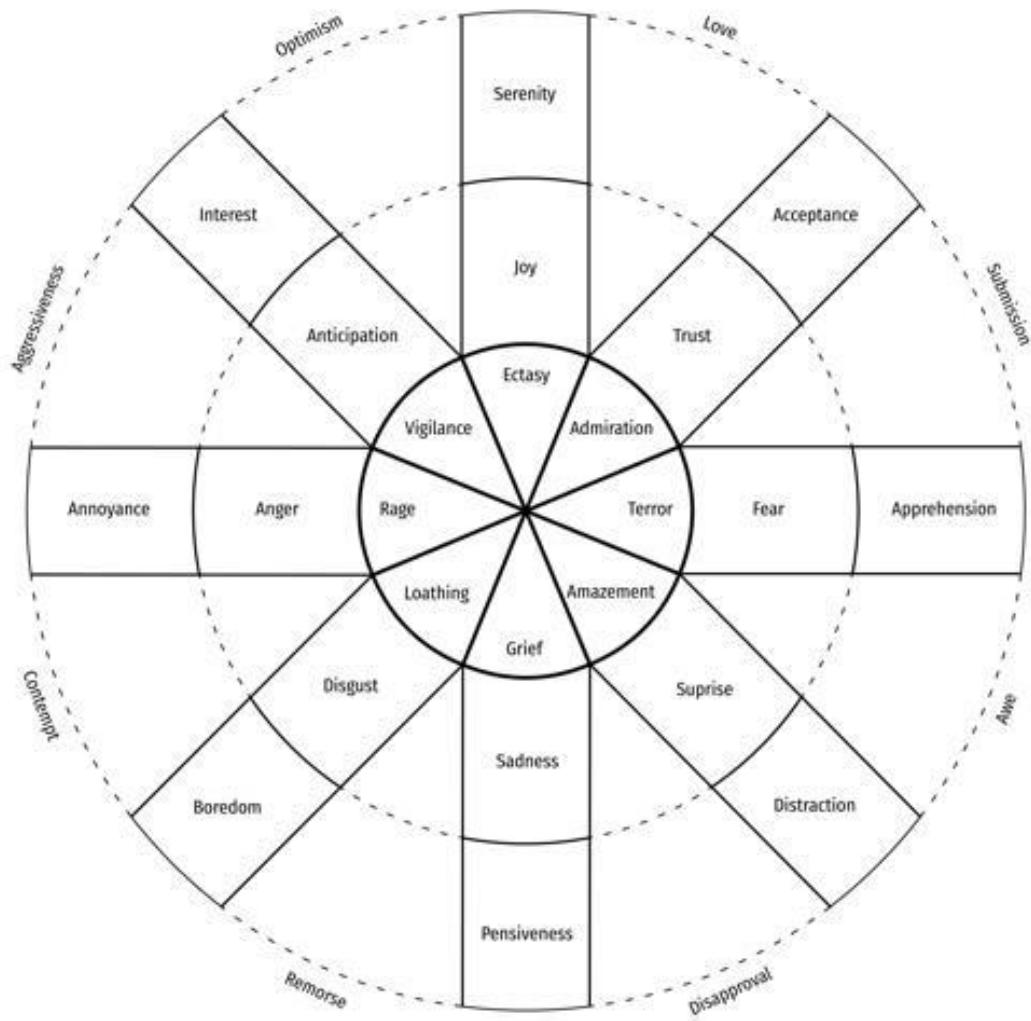
The word emotion stems from the Latin word *emotere*, literally meaning energy in motion. In itself, emotional energy is neutral. It is feeling sensation and the physiological reactions that make us feel a specific emotion in a certain way. We humans then label these emotions in a specific way according to the way they make us feel, and often put them into the categories of “positive” or “negative” emotions.

Newer studies show a wide array of emotions – actually 27 of them.¹⁶ Older studies are referring to 12 basic emotions: interest, joy, surprise, sadness, anger, disgust, contempt, self-hostility, fear, shame, shyness, and guilt.¹⁷ If you are like most people, you might only have two emotions: good and bad emotions. Most of us are pretty illiterate when it comes to our emotions. We

might be feeling something, but oftentimes we cannot put into words what that something is. Some people feel their emotions so strongly that they regularly “blow up” in private and public settings, others do not find themselves feeling much of anything at all.

This practice is about becoming more emotionally literate.

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Explore the graphic in the book. See what emotions your attention naturally goes to. If you are a clinical professional and using this tool in your session, ask the client to elaborate on their “favorite” emotions. Ask them where they hang out the most.

In the graphic you can see the main 8 emotions presented in the second circle from the inside. As you move to smaller circles, the emotions become more intense.

Just look at the diagram, the emotions, and see what happens on the inside.

Now take some time and reflect on the following questions:

- What is your favorite emotion?
- What emotion do you experience most frequently?
- What causes you to experience this emotion?
- What do you do when you experience this emotion?

Take some time to write down your answers. Also, if you have the space, you can reflect on the last time you got really emotional. See if you can hold this emotion in the same way you have held your thoughts and bodily sensations. If you need support with this, go back to tool 1.4 and 1.5 and look at the practices in these two sections.

1.7 Personal Serenity Prayer

Remember the version of the serenity prayer from Reinhold Niebuhr: “Grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, courage to change the things I can, and the wisdom to know the difference”.

This tool invites you to practice wisdom in your specific life situation. We are all capable of walking a different path than we are walking today.

Get a big white piece of paper and colored pens, even markers if you have some.

Draw a big line in the middle of the paper to make two columns, leaving some space at the bottom.

Label the column on the left “Things I Cannot Change” and the column on the right “Things I Can Change”.

At the bottom left write “I accept...”

At the bottom right write “I commit to change....”

Either use this template or make your own. Make it as creative and colorful as you like. Getting back in touch with our creativity is sometimes very healing and supportive.

THINGS I CANNOT CHANGE • ... • ... • ...	THINGS I CAN CHANGE • ... • ... • ...
I ACCEPT • ... • ... • ...	I COMMIT TO CHANGE • ... • ... • ...

Looking at your specific circumstances, whatever it is you are facing right now that made you pick up this book, think about this challenge as you begin to fill the sheet.

Be really honest and open with yourself. You are doing this for you. Be specifically honest when it comes to stating what it is that you decide to accept AND what it is that you decide to commit to. Rather than committing and accepting a lot of things, see which things would matter the most in your specific situation. We often struggle when making too many commitments with ourselves. We also cannot easily accept too many things outside of our sphere of influence at once, as this overwhelms the mind and our system. If we overwhelm ourselves, the words just become random statements with no meaning.

1.8 Saying “YES”

Let’s practice saying “yes” with this tool. How many times in life have you said “yes” but actually wanted to say “no”. We do not struggle to say “yes”

in life. On the contrary, many of us struggling with burnout, depression, addiction, eating disorders, or anxiety have a tendency to overcommit and say “yes” to too many things. We overwhelm ourselves, our entire system of body, mind, and emotions, and in this way lose focus and priorities in life. Why not say “yes” to our thoughts, emotions, and sensations in the same way. Why try to fight them or push them away? Why not try to fully accept and embrace them as they are, and give them a full body “YES”, so to say.

Let us practice this:

What thoughts, sensations, or emotions do you find yourself struggling and fighting with?

If you are having difficulty answering this question, think of all the times that you go into a behavior or pattern you actually want to stop (like overeating, drinking alcohol, smoking, not getting out of bed, last minute cancellation of a party, etc.).

Now see if you can determine what precedes this behavior or pattern.

What came before you found yourself going back into that pattern?

There is no right or wrong answer. Simply see if you can detect if there is a thought, a sensation, or an emotion preceding this action. Maybe it is a combination of 2, or all 3?

Now take that thought, that sensation or that emotion, see it, hear it, feel it, observe it fully with your entire being. This may be uncomfortable, and you may want to go into more of those patterns and behaviors. Try to simply *be* with what it is you are observing.

Hold that thought, that sensation, or that emotion and see if you can embrace it, like you would a child.

See if you can fully say “yes” to whatever it is that proceeds the patterns and behaviors.

See if you can accept it fully and just let it be.

This might not work the first time, and that is OK.

If you tried and it worked, good job!

If you tried and it did not work, also good job! We have to remember that trying any of these exercises or in general trying new things can be challenging. It is very supportive for our personal growth and healing to celebrate ourselves, even if something doesn't work right away. Acceptance means accepting life and our experiences exactly as they are, even if things do not go as planned.

1.9 Come with Compassion

According to the Oxford English Dictionary, the word “compassion” stems from the Latin “compati”, literally meaning “to suffer with”. So while different sources mention different elements of compassion, there seems to be a broad consensus that compassion involves feeling for a person who is suffering and being motivated to help them.¹⁸ So it's a form of being moved by another's suffering and wanting to help. Surely most of us have experienced this. We humans are pack animals, so a behavior like this is very natural.

What for many seems to be trickier is being compassionate with oneself. As Friedrich Nietzsche said, “you yourself will always be the worst enemy you can encounter...”. There is much truth to this statement. Often, we accept and tolerate many behaviors and patterns in others, but would never allow ourselves to do the same. Practicing being compassionate with ourselves can be one of the easiest and most direct ways towards more self-acceptance and self-love. It is something that needs to be practiced and cultivated. Yet once the awareness of the importance of practicing compassion (especially self-compassion) is there, it becomes easier and more natural.

So let's take a look at some of the patterns and behaviors you have, and see how compassionate you are with yourself and with others. This practice can be pretty insightful and maybe even a bit irritating, especially should you find yourself being much more compassionate with others than with yourself. Exactly in these moments, can you practice self-compassion and

acceptance, and try to the best of your ability to not go into further judging, blaming, or being in any way upset with yourself.

Name three behaviors or patterns that you have, that are bothering you:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Now reflect on your friends, your family, colleagues, etc. Who else has patterns similar to the ones you mentioned above?

Now think even further and see how you feel about others having these patterns. Have you ever commented on their pattern or habit? Have you ever supported them in difficult moments? Have you ever told them that they are OK just the way they are, pattern/habit or not? Be honest with yourself. Even if the people around you have different patterns, have you ever in any way supported or “held them”, as they told you that they are struggling with something? If there is a specific situation that comes to mind as you are reflecting, try to remember and recall any situations.

You may find that you were able to support and “hold” someone else in a very compassionate and loving way.

Write down the things that you said and did in this situation.

- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____

If you like, take a picture of this list and keep it with you. Next time you find yourself falling back into a habit or pattern you are wanting to change, you can use these words and ideas to be more compassionate with yourself. Maybe you could keep count on how many times you use each of these behaviors or phrases for yourself and how they supported you.

1.10 What if You Only Had Two Choices

Imagine you only had the following two choices:

- A. The choice to feel and experience all emotions or
- B. The choice to never feel any emotions again

If you choose option A you will keep your capacity to feel emotions such as love, care, and compassion but also emotions such as anger, jealousy, sadness, or anxiety (just to name a few). If you choose B, you will lose your capacity to feel and express any kind of emotion in life.

Which one would you choose?

This may seem a bit extreme, maybe even unrealistic, yet the so-called flat affect (not being able to feel or express any kind of emotions) is a common symptom of severe trauma, psychosis, or severe depression. As people receive treatments and slowly recover, this symptom can decrease but imagine if you were to permanently never feel again. It is natural that humans strive for pleasurable and “nice” emotions and try to avoid the more painful or uncomfortable ones. Yet this is not how life works. Life for most people comes in cycles and phases. Some days we are doing better than other days. Some years we really struggle mentally, physically, or emotionally, and will remember this phase for the rest of our lives. In other years we might be thriving, and love, work, and family all seem to fall into place. Hopefully we have had phases like this in our lives. There is a whole spectrum of emotions and it is not possible to feel one side without feeling the other. No matter how far you are on the difficult or negative side of the emotional spectrum, you know there is another side. You have experienced this other side at some point in your life.

When asked to choose, most people will choose option A.

Which one would you choose?

If you choose option B because your pain is so unbearable right now, then this is the way you feel right now. Please take a moment to reflect on how all the methods you might be using to suppress feeling pain and emotions are and have been helping you. Are these methods really reducing feelings

of shame, guilt, anger, sadness, or anxiety in the long run? Or do these feelings just come back once whatever you are currently using to suppress the emotions subsides?

For many, being in so much emotional pain is harder than being in physical pain. It's not easy. Still when left with a choice, most do choose to feel the emotions rather than losing their capacity to experience their emotions for good.

1.11 One Minute of Acceptance

Let's do a very simple practice. All that is needed from you is one minute of your time and an openness to simply try something new. Nothing more, nothing less.

Read the instructions and set yourself a timer once you begin.

Pick one behavior or pattern that you have been struggling with. The first time you do this practice, you are invited to pick something that you feel has medium to light importance in your life. Think of something that is definitely bothering you, but maybe not something you have been struggling with for several years or decades. If you are struggling with anxiety, depression, addiction, OCD, or another psychological illness, see if you can find a behavior or an emotional experience that is part of the illness but is not the most complex or difficult aspect of your struggles. Maybe you can find a specific situation or moment where you were struggling, without looking at the complex illness.

For example, if you are battling depression, you could choose the last time when you really struggled to get out of bed. Or if you are struggling with addiction, you could choose the last time you relapsed and went back to using the substance in a mild or medium way.

Once you have picked the behavior, pattern, or even a specific situation, you are invited to take one minute of fully accepting what happened. Picture yourself holding this situation, this behavior, this pattern like a little baby in your arms, and you will simply look at and embrace it. Allow any thoughts and emotions to arise and to be there, but try not to react to these. Simply come back to accepting whatever happened, holding the experience

in your arms lovingly and compassionately. This may be quite intense, and emotions, thoughts, or sensations can arise. You're invited to practice only one minute of acceptance. Of course, if you like, you can practice more, and you might find that emotions and thoughts about this situation subside after some time.

If you do not feel ready to do this practice by yourself, do it in the presence of a trained professional.

If you are ready, set your timer now, and begin. Hold the pattern, the experience, or the situation. Hold it like you would hold and look at a new born baby.

What did you experience during this practice?

1.12 Exploring Childhood Programming

A big part of being able to accept life and what we struggle with is to actually become more aware of how we were programmed through our parents, our environment, and other people that were around when we grew up. Early childhood programming happens unconsciously for the most part. Things we frequently heard, or behaviors we regularly saw, somehow went into our systems and are likely still influencing us today.¹⁹

Let's look at what you may have been programmed by. Childhood programming can usually still be detected today in certain beliefs and ideas we have about ourselves or the world. Often they are reflected in simple short statements we believe and consciously or unconsciously often say to ourselves. These statements may or may not have been something that our parents or caretakers said. They could also be something similar we picked up and then formed a respective statement in our heads. Today, when we hear this statement, we feel some kind of reaction inside. Often this reaction is emotional, such as sadness or anger. Sometimes we are annoyed by the statement or when someone else seems to be living according to the words. When we find ourselves triggered by the reactions and doings of others, it is often a good indicator that there is something we should be looking at inside ourselves. This is just a selection of statements, and the list could be

endless of course. Read the following statements and see if any of them apply. If they do, put a check mark next to them. You can also use color coding to mark the ones that apply the most.

- Get over it!
- Don't show your emotions!
- It's not OK to be different.
- It's selfish to express your needs.
- You can't rely on anyone but yourself.
- If you are going to do something, you better do it right.
- Stop feeling sorry for yourself. Just snap out of it!
- Don't be such a chicken.
- Just smile, be happy.
- You are better/prettier/smarter than everyone.
- If you don't look pretty/handsome, others won't like you.
- You never do things right/You are so clumsy.
- You always need to be nice to your friends.

How did you feel when reading these statements? Did you have any childhood memories? This practice can be challenging and can bring up emotions, maybe even traumatic childhood memories. If this is the case, be present, loving, and compassionate with yourself. The awareness of such childhood programming is a very important step into more acceptance, especially self-acceptance.

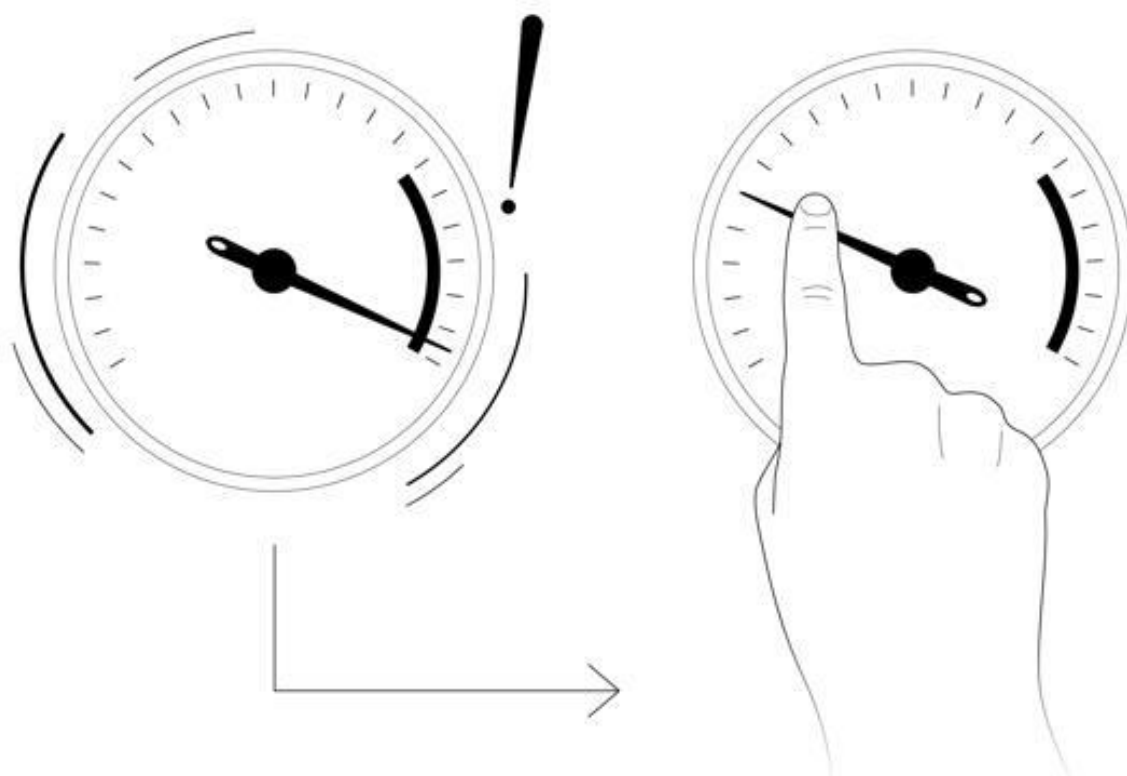
1.13 The Pressure Gauge

This practice is simple and creates more awareness and a feeling of being more in control. The next time you find yourself in a situation or experience where you are having difficulties either emotionally, physically, or mentally, try the following exercise:

Imagine that the challenging emotion, the thought or the sensation in your body, is also represented on a pressure gauge. Depending on the intensity of

the experience the little arrow will be more or less on the right side of the gauge. It is like you can see the gauge in front of you as you are having the experience. As soon as the pointer in the pressure gauges passes the middle, things get really intense. Imagine that next time you are struggling with this specific emotion, thought, or sensation, you could just remove the glass from the gauge, and manually move the pointer further to the left. As you move the pointer further to the left, you feel a sense of relief, more lightness, more self-control, and control over the situation. This doesn't mean that the sensation, the thought, or the emotion will completely disappear (you can try though), but that you invite whatever you are experiencing into less intensity by moving the pointer on the imaginary pressure gauge to the left.

If this seems silly, that's because it is. But you might find yourself surprised at how effective this method can be.



1.14 Metaphor for Acceptance

For some people it is helpful to use metaphors to describe the process of accepting difficult emotions, thoughts, and sensations. Here is one metaphor that you might find helpful:

Surfing the waves of the ocean

Life can be compared to the ocean. Sometimes it's calm, with little or no waves, other times the waves are many feet tall, crashing down right in front of or even on top of us. The intensity of the ocean and where the waves fall down is sometimes not so predictable. Still, even if there are giant sets of waves, there are also always smaller waves in between each set. And with a bit of practice, you can learn to choose which of the waves you attempt to surf. You can pay attention to how many giant sets come in after one another and how long the big sets usually last. Then you can learn how long the smaller sets come in and where they usually break. Why not make your way to finding the breaking point of the smaller sets as the bigger sets have finished? This does require a bit of practice, but it is definitely possible to learn. Why attempt to surf the giant sets, if there are smaller waves that are much easier to surf and stay on?

The same metaphor can come in handy when trying to change any pattern or behavior. Instead of trying to fix and heal the whole illness, like your depression, your addiction, or recovering fully from trauma, why not start with specific behaviors, thoughts, or emotions that are part of the bigger picture? Why not try to tackle the next smaller urge, feeling low on energy, or feeling anxious or worried about having forgotten something? This way helps you build up the muscles and skills you need to ride the bigger waves. It is really hard to attempt to surf a 6- foot wave with little practice. There is absolutely nothing wrong with playing around with the white wash before you go out further to catch your first green wave.

We all start small. With everything.

How is this metaphor helpful for your current situation? Can you think of a metaphor that better describes your current struggles and your reality?

1.15 “I Accept”

Here is a more playful approach toward acceptance. There is a German saying: “Das Leben ist kein Ponyhof” that is literally translated to “Life ain’t no pony farm”. So yes, life can be and often is hard. Most events that happen around us are outside of our control. It’s not always about being happy and content, especially if we are currently finding ourselves in a tricky, maybe even seemingly helpless situation. You might not be in a place to appreciate this right now, but in fact humor can actually help us improve our overall satisfaction in life .²⁰ So we end this chapter on tools for more acceptance of emotions, thoughts, sensations, experiences, and life in general with a little playful quiz.

Write down 5 of your behaviors, patterns, or things that you do not like/cannot accept about yourself. Write each one on a separate little piece of paper.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Then fold up the papers, so you can’t see what’s written on them. Shuffle them around in a hat or any kind of container and then take one.

Which one did you select?

Your assignment or homework for the next week will be to practice more acceptance for exactly this pattern, behavior or thing. Try using the tools 1.8, 1.9, 1.11 or any other tool you feel can support you practicing more acceptance.

If you have selected the one thing that you feel you can accept least out of the five you wrote, you can also be compassionate with yourself and pull another piece of paper instead. If you really need to, you can continue pulling pieces until you pull the one that you feel you can most easily work with. This is a playful approach for practicing acceptance where you can

also practice self-love and compassion. Plus you might notice that there is a difference in the perceived difficulty of being able to accept the different behaviors and patterns that you listed. Depending on where you are currently at emotionally and physically, you can adjust what you choose to work with.

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2. ACT TOOLS FOR DEFUSION

We will now explore tools to support defusion. Remember that defusion helps us separate thoughts and direct experiences and see things as what they are, not as what the brain necessarily says they are. We are creating space between thoughts and our reactions to these thoughts. In this way they have less hold over us. Often we cannot change what is happening on the inside, but we can change how we relate to and react to those inner experiences. This is not easy, especially as thoughts often happen automatically, even unconsciously. The ACT Model invites a deeper approach of not just fighting irrational or negative thoughts with rational or positive ones, but rather digging out the foundation of these thoughts, and weakening them from below.²¹ There is a close link to the ACT process of acceptance, which is why these tools are also logically following next in this book.

In order to defuse thoughts we need to learn to expand our attention to thinking and experiencing as an ongoing behavioral process. The most important aspect of being able to defuse thoughts, is to realize that thinking and experiencing our thoughts is always happening. The brain produces thoughts, as this is one of its many functions. There is nothing wrong with the private events that are happening in our subjective reality. Yet these can become problematic when everything is entangled, leading to automatized thinking and actions, especially when the thoughts and actions that follow are harmful to ourselves or others. The thinking mind can be an amazing tool, functioning like a machine entering a flow state, that can enable exceptional achievements. In the same way, the thinking mind turning against us can make us feel like we are crazy, and even to wanting to harm ourselves. Let's explore tools to help untangle thoughts, interpretation, mental concepts, and the actual direct experiences we tend to all fuse together. DJ Moran uses a very useful metaphor when he describes how defusion supports fighting irrational, negative, even destructive thinking at the root.²¹ He uses the example of no longer fighting face to face with something or trying to put out fire with fire, but rather putting down the weapons, finding strategic ways to go around, get to the origin of the

negative and irrational thinking, digging up its roots, and therefore slowly and persistently changing its nature.

Please remember to only practice the tools you feel comfortable with or practice in the presence of a licensed therapist or other clinical professional.

2.1 A Defusion Metaphor

A common way that can help us with defusion is using metaphors, where different processes that are happening on the inside are represented by different people or objects. It is like using external things to describe internal phenomena, and in this way creating more space between thoughts, emotions, actions, and the whole experience. One of the most common and insightful metaphors is “Passengers on the Bus”. This metaphor is also included in this toolkit, as it is one of the most powerful and supportive metaphors to support people in the defusion process.

It is simple and invites you to see your life as if driving a bus. You are invited to imagine the bus, and see yourself as the bus driver. There are different passengers, bus stops where some passengers get off and others get on, and a final destination that you are driving to.

How is this related to defusion? Think of the passengers on the bus as your thoughts, feelings, sensations, memories, ideas, fantasies, or all kinds of perceptions and experiences. Some of these passengers are kind and loving, like this beautiful old grandmother who is patting your back and telling you that “You are beautiful and OK just the way you are”. Others are not so nice. Like the two kids that are bullying and intimidating you as they are telling you that “You are stupid” and that “You can’t drive”.

The passengers on the bus speak freely and without a filter, even beginning to tell you how and where to drive. They tell you where to stop and pick up more passengers, some of which openly confront you. The more you listen to the different passengers and let them lead the way, the louder they become...

You could argue with the confronting passengers, you could even stop the bus and try to throw certain individuals out. Chances are they will resist, and maybe even team up with other confrontational passengers.

Whatever is happening with the passengers, you are the driver of the bus. You have a specific destination in mind, and certain places to stop. The more you find yourself distracted, the more delayed you will be arriving at your final destination. Maybe you will become so distracted and involved in arguing with the passengers, that you never arrive. So what can you do?

You keep the bus going, stay in the driver's seat and don't get distracted by single passengers that are triggering you. Let them be there, let them yell and complain, like a bus full of school kids. The less attention you give the noises and distractions, the more likely it is that they are going to calm down by themselves.

How does this metaphor resonate? Does it resemble the fights you are having with the mind? Apply this metaphor to your situation. If you like, you can even draw the bus, the passengers, and of course the bus driver (You!).

What kind of passengers are mainly on your bus?

When you pull up to a bus stop, what kind of passengers get on your bus?

How do you react to the different passengers? What do you say or do?

Technique #1 "I Notice..."

This involves adding the phrase "I notice I am having the thought..." to your recurring difficult thoughts. Adding this phrase frequently to your repetitive painful thoughts will begin to change your relationship with that thought.

Technique #2 Label Your Thoughts

This involves labeling the kind of thought you are having. There are two options or levels with this technique, both of which are effective.

(1) Label your thoughts as descriptive or evaluative (almost all thoughts fall into one of these two categories).

How can you pick up more passengers that are supporting you in getting to your final destination?

How can you be less distracted from reaching your final destination?

2.2 “Thank You Mind”

There is a lot going on inside. Some of us are more or less aware of all the things that are going on inside. Out of the tens of thousands of thoughts we have per day, about 90% are repetitive.¹¹ Most of these thoughts thankfully do not enter our conscious awareness. We are all equipped with our individual filter. This is good and keeps us healthy. But what to do with repetitive, negative, irrational, and unhealthy thoughts that continuously arise throughout the day? Defusion is about detangling the thought and the experience.

Say you have a thought such as “*I am worthless*”, “*I am craving alcohol*”, or “*I am getting another panic attack*”. These are not facts. They might seem like it, but they are actually just thoughts. They might even be so strong that they get you to act. They might result in you canceling a date with someone you have been wanting to meet for a while, or cause you to drive to the next liquor store. Originally there was only a thought. The resulting action is what *can* but does not *have to* follow. While it might not seem like this yet, there is a choice. The more thoughts, sensations, emotions, and actions are entangled, the harder it is going to be to see that choice. As Victor E. Frankl, a psychiatrist and Holocaust survivor, stated: “Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our power to choose our response. In our response lies our growth and our freedom.”

It might be really hard to perceive any space between thoughts, sensations, and emotions. All of it appears linked. You might find your heart rate beginning to increase, leading to the thought “*I am going to have a panic attack*”, and eventually to more sensations and emotions such as anxiety, fear, and worry. Or you might see someone having a drink after work at your favorite bar. Your body might respond with sensations in the belly,

sweaty palms, increased heart rate, and thoughts like *“What if I just sat down to have a quick drink”* or *“One drink won’t hurt anyone”*. Then the respective emotions such as excitement and joy might also join in. If you are struggling from any of these or something similar, you know firsthand how all of these are linked.

This tool invites you to work directly with the thinking mind. The thinking mind is what produces thoughts such as *“I can’t get out of bed”*, *“I am worthless”*, *“I want a drink”*, *“I need to go home to check if I turned off the stove”*, etc.

If you can notice these thoughts before acting, this is already a great achievement! This won’t always work, as the thinking mind likes functions such as the autopilot and bypassing. But when you can perceive what your mind is saying, here is the practice:

Simply thank your mind.

Whatever it throws at you, thank it.

Say *“Thank you mind”*. Or *“Thank you mind for sharing, I am going to continue with my day now”*.

It won’t stop ranting or commenting. Maybe one day, but let’s not count on that. It is the function of the mind to comment, to judge, to criticize, to find fault, to reason.

So whatever the mind throws at you the response is the same *“Thank you mind”*, or *“I appreciate you sharing”*.

If you feel comfortable, you can even practice this out loud. Let your friends and family know about the practice, so they are not worried. Maybe they even want to practice with you.

2.3 Evaluating Our Problem Solving

Let’s be very open when using this tool to analyze current thoughts and resulting behaviors. Your thinking mind is noticing something is up. Whether you have physical, emotional, or mental pain, your mind notices

this and tries to find solutions that it believes will work. What solutions does it pick? It's the ones that you have been practicing regularly and the ones that it sees others around you practicing. No matter what kind of pain you are experiencing, the mind would like to turn it off. It's simple problem solving for the mind. The thinking mind may or may not evaluate the effectiveness or the long-term consequences of the methods that you are choosing to solve the pain. You might not even be fully aware of the pain yet, especially if it is mental or emotional. Most of us are very good at naming and feeling physical pain, but have much more difficulty to experience and allow ourselves to feel the pain associated with emotions or thoughts. So it is common that we all develop different ways to cope and deal with this pain. Also, these different ways are more or less conscious to us. It can be extremely insightful for anyone to actually have a look at the coping strategies that we choose to deal with challenging situations, emotions, or sensations. Even the positive coping strategies can sometimes have two sides of a coin. Someone who is struggling with OCD for example might find that excessive physical activity, like training for a marathon, can actually enhance obsessive and compulsive thinking or behavior.

So for this tool, if you feel brave, let's take a look at your current problem solving and most relevant coping strategies, and honestly reflect whether they are supporting you in living a life full of meaning, acceptance, and self-love.

How does your thinking mind “solve” mental problems?	How does your thinking mind “solve” physical problems?	How does your thinking mind “solve” emotional problems?	Which one of these methods is most effective in giving you a rich and meaningful life?

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2.4 The Mind as a Tool

There is a popular Zen Proverb that states “Be a master of the mind, not mastered by the mind”. In some spiritual traditions the mind is even compared to a dog, that needs to be kept on a leash and not to be let run wild. Why? Because of the nature of our thoughts. Uncontrolled thoughts are like wild horses or stray dogs. They are unpredictable, hard to tame, and being around them can even become dangerous. To overcome a rebellious mind, we need to realize that it is exactly this, rebellious and untamed. Start to examine the nature and quality of your mind, especially your thoughts. Bring extra awareness to the thoughts that are not supportive for living a rich and meaningful life. Those thoughts are limiting, maybe even hindering you from living the life you want, a life without anxiety, compulsion, or addictions. Depending on the severity of your mental illness at this moment, this tool might not be accessible at all. None of these tools are intended to downplay the severity of your challenges and struggles, and how you are suffering from the thoughts, emotions, and sensations that you are having. So if your symptoms are currently more intense, maybe come back to this tool when there is more openness for this practice. Still, just becoming aware of the fact that it is the nature of the mind to not be very nice to us could bring some interesting insights.

What kind of animal is your mind currently representing?

What kind of animal would you like your mind to represent?

On a scale of 1 to 10 (1 meaning not at all, 10 meaning fully), how well tamed is your mind?

2.5. The Mind Radio

The human mind is a lot like radio doom and gloom. It tends to broadcast a lot of negative and painful things from the past, and likes to broadcast a lot of doom and gloom from the future, such as catastrophizing or negative thinking. And it likes to broadcast problematic and difficult things about the present, too. This is exactly the nature of the mind.

Now, you can just turn up the volume of positive thinking and try to focus on that. You will have two channels blasting different things out loud. What if you tried to just listen to the radio, while not paying too much attention to it, like you would notice the things around you when you are in a flow state? When we are in a flow state, we can blend everything that is not supportive for our task or activity out. We learn to let the radio play in the background and when things such as kind, living thoughts, ideas and strategies about goals, and solutions for problems come on, we learn to turn the radio up. We then listen in extra closely and take in constructive ideas and advice.

Then, while all the negative, dooming chatter goes on, we learn to turn the radio down again and just have it run in the background. If there is a lot of doom and gloom that you can't ignore, you can begin naming the songs and programs that the radio is playing. For example, you say to yourself: oh, there is the song "I can't do this" or the program "I am not good enough". Rather than trying not to pay too much attention to this, you hear and name what you observe, and then try to move on. The rest of the time, focus all your attention on the music that nourishes you and supports you in creating a more meaningful life.

Let's end this tool with a short reflection. If you'd like, capture your thoughts here or in a journal. As you are journeying along on this healing path, it could be supportive to have a journal just for this process.

What type of music is your favorite radio channel playing? Is it joyful, happy, sad, angry, upset, etc.? Remember we are talking about the thinking mind and what kind of "music" the thinking mind usually produces.

Do you like this channel?

How do you feel when listening to this channel?

What are ways to turn down or turn off this channel?

Are these ways helpful and supportive for you to live a more meaningful life?

If not, what are other ways you can think of to turn the channel down or off?

2.6 What Fires Together, Wires Together

One way to view the formation and upholding of thoughts is to see it from the perspective of what we give and what we get from that specific thought. Without going into the neuroscience behind thought formation, we can say that thoughts have a physical form and are represented and encoded by matter in our brain.²² For every thought there is a complex array of interactions between neurons. The more complex memories and experiences, the more complex the neural chains. In general we can say that the more we feed specific thoughts, ideas, and habits, the stronger their neural representation is going to get. As Hebb suggested, “Neurons that fire together, wire together”. This is why we can influence our life by incorporating mindfulness or gratitude practice, even positive thinking.

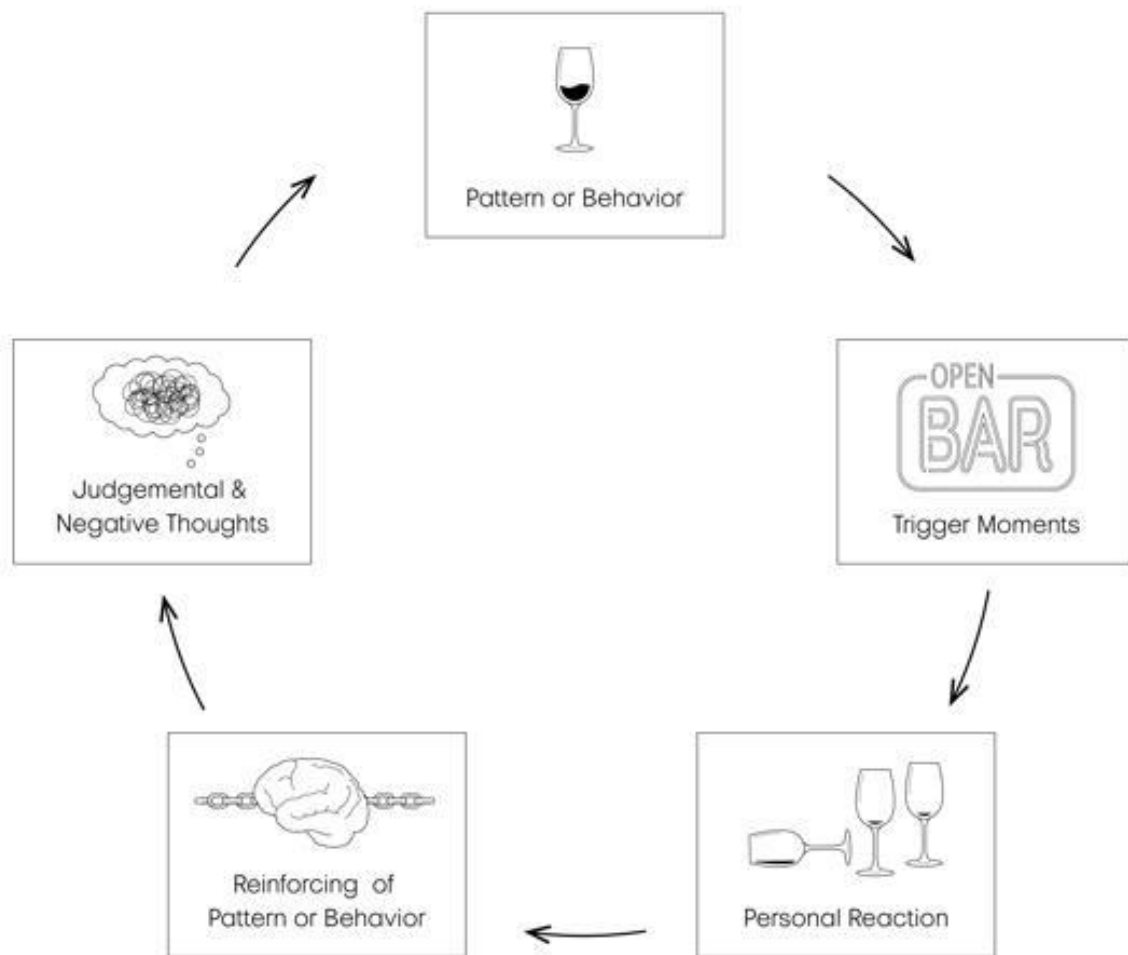
In the same way, having and feeding persistent negative, compulsive, or obsessive thoughts can actually lead to their strengthening.²³ It's not just that we will have these specific thoughts more often, but also that their actual physical representation and network of connected neurons increases. For anyone struggling with alcohol addiction, you might know exactly what this means. There was a point in your life, where you were not totally

consumed or controlled by the substance you are now addicted to. For anyone struggling with major depression, you might remember a time in your life where you did not feel completely helpless, sad, or frustrated, a time where you still had interest in some activities or people. Yet over time, through believing and usually acting upon the thoughts, sensations, and emotions associated with the illness, some of them got so big that they are now consuming your entire life.

When the thought or urge now comes to drink a glass of wine, no other thought or idea seems to be able to co-exist, not until you relieve yourself of the craving and urge and give your body and mind what it is asking for. The same goes for acting (or actually better yet, not acting) upon the symptoms of depression. Lying in bed all day, feeling helpless, sad, and hopeless. Changing these habits of acting, thinking, and feeling, and their potential vicious cycles, often requires an intense wake-up call or a desire for change coming from deep inside. Until this desire for real change is present, every time we act or don't act upon our thoughts, urges, sensations, or emotions, we are actually feeding the neural network that upholds them. If you are stuck in the cycle, then it is almost like you can't act in any other way. It is possible when the suffering becomes too intense, that bigger mental/consciousness shifts happen or the devotion and dedication to a specific life and life purpose take over.

What is a pattern or habit that has become strong and dominant in your life, due to acting or behaving in certain ways?

Take a look at the diagram below. There you can see the link between our patterns and behaviors, trigger moments, our reactions and how these reinforce the pattern and potential negative, judgmental thinking. You can imagine that this is the neural network representing your behavior or pattern. Every time you engage in one of the rectangles, the lines between the rectangles thicken. The neural network (and therefore the behavior) gets reinforced and strengthened. As you can see, by responding to trigger moments and engaging in the pattern, you stay in a vicious cycle of continuing with this pattern.



When looking at this diagram and your personal situation, where can you identify moments where you could break out of your pattern? Write them here below. To be specific.

You might have an easy time, identifying moments where you could break out, you might not. If it was easy, you would have already broken out of the pattern. You are doing a great job reflecting about this. Even if this practice seems a bit mental or is difficult for you, having this awareness of where you can intervene is your way out.

Write down 3 things that you can try next time you feel that the pattern or behavior is about to kick in:

1.

2.

3.

Write down 3 things you can try next time you find yourself already engaging in the pattern or the behavior:

1.

2.

3.

Good job. With this kind of work, you are moving towards freeing yourself from your patterns and behaviors. This doesn't happen overnight, but it is possible.

2.7 What Are the Secondary Gains?

Think of the statement from tool 2.6 “What fires together, wires together”. Think about the thoughts, emotions, sensations, even patterns that you are regularly “feeding” in this way. Surely there are thoughts, emotions, and sensations that are supporting you, and some that do not.

Still, even if some thoughts, emotions, or sensations do not support you in living the life that you imagine for yourself, for some reason, you might still

entertain these. You feed them regularly by believing them, repeating them mentally or out loud, and acting on them. The sensation of heart racing turns into different thoughts such as *“I am having another panic attack”* or *“There must be something wrong with me, I must immediately go to the hospital”*. Not to create any confusion by suggesting you should ignore your body, but if you are suffering from general anxiety and regular panic attacks, then it is likely that sensations of heart racing and sweaty palms are signs of another panic attack. If you struggle with depression, you will regularly experience thoughts such as, *“I can’t get out of bed”* or *“Everything is hopeless”*. Or for someone struggling with alcohol addiction there will always be this thought *“I could go to the bar for just one little drink”*. These sensations or thought patterns are part of the psychological condition. We cannot change these, at least not quickly. When we become aware that these patterns exist and understand the ways in which we are “feeding” them, we take a big step towards healing.

So many of the tools in this toolkit sharpen our awareness of what is going on at the different levels of the body in some way. You can go back to the previous tool 2.6 and fill in the cycle of how you are reinforcing specific patterns of behavior. In this tool, you are invited to write down more specifically how your specific pattern or behavior manifests itself at the level of the mind, emotions and sensations.

Please write down specifically what is happening on the different levels of thoughts, sensations and emotions as you are engaging in the problematic behavior (or even shortly before).

1. Naming the thought

2. Naming the sensation

3. Naming the emotion

4. Naming a combination of the two or all three

5. And finally understanding the chain of events and how they interplay.

In the process of defusion we are looking at all of these aspects. Plus, we are trying to dig up the roots of a specific thought or behavior and therefore need to look even deeper. Looking deeper and answering the following questions is likely to trigger the mind. Remember the mind sees no reason to change, and likes to hang out in negative, doom and gloom, and catastrophizing. To make real and lasting changes in our patterns, we must go deeper than just removing the first layer of dirt. We need to dig up the roots.

Are you ready to dig deeper? Please answer the questions below as honestly as you can. Do this practice in the presence of a licensed professional, if you feel you might need support.

1. Every behavior or action is likely to have some kind of short-term gain for us. In the long run something might not be good for us, yet still we engage in the behavior because the thought, behavior, or action is somehow supportive for us in the moment.

What are the short-term or secondary gains of the behavior(s) that we are most battling with?

2. If you are having trouble answering this, look back at when you first started having these thoughts or engaging in this behavior. What purpose did this thought or behavior serve then?

3. What purpose is this thought or behavior serving now? Is it still the same? If not, how has it changed?

It is not easy to see these secondary gains. Even if we do, they are called "secondary gains" because they serve a specific purpose. So we need to discover what purpose our patterns and behaviors serve.

2.8 The Seemingly “Perfect” Employee

The thinking mind does what it does because it learned all of this was necessary to keep you alive and be an accepted member of your clan back in the stone age. There isn't necessarily a bad intention in catastrophizing, overgeneralizing, personalizing, black and white thinking, and all the other mental tricks the mind likes to play on us. Why not actually compare the thinking mind to that seemingly “perfect” employee? One of those people who always goes all out. One who constantly reads, re-reads, and emphasizes the company rules and regulations to everyone. One of those employees who is always 100% present and motivated, never late, and always seems to have the answers.

Yet what this employee struggles with are any changes in plans or in the protocol. When something differs from the original plan, the employee tries to bring in a past way of dealing with such a situation, one that no longer applies. The employee is so convinced of themselves, that instead of waiting and checking back with the team, there is a tendency for solo decisions. Some of the decisions the employee makes are right, others are painfully wrong, maybe having massive negative impacts for the entire company. On top of that, this employee has little flexibility in personal human interaction. The focus of this employee is so much on the topic and success, that other employees actually avoid him or her. This leads to more separation and more solo decisions, making a seemingly “perfect” employee a liability.

In what ways does this seemingly “perfect” employee have to do with your thinking mind?

How does this story compare to how the thinking mind can support and also hinder you? Explain. Use examples from your life (thoughts, ideas, patterns that you have).

2.9 Titchener's Repetition

Here is a practice that has been used for over a century and is proven to decrease the meaning of a word or phrase within seconds. The method is quite simple:

- Pick a simple noun, such as “*kiwi*”. Say this word out loud a few times and see what thoughts, images, sensations and memories arise.
- Now repeat the word “*kiwi*” over and over again out loud for 30 seconds. Try this now before you move on. Make sure to say the word out loud, as this practice will not work otherwise.
- Now do this practice again, this time picking a harsh word that you tend to use when judging yourself, for example “*idiot*”, “*stupid*”, “*loser*”, “*weak*”, “*selfish*”, “*wimp*”, “*judgy*”, “*superficial*”. These are just examples, make sure you use a word that you frequently use when you judge yourself. If you need, you can also use a two-word phrase such as “*stupid idiot*”.

Now do this practice out loud for 30 seconds using the judgmental word or phrase you often say to yourself. Remember you need to do this out loud to really feel the effect. You might notice that this word or phrase seems to become meaningless, like it's just empty, without meaning. It's just a vibration of sounds. If then linked to a specific situation, like making a careless mistake on an exam, the same word has a completely different meaning and influences us in many ways.

2.10 Noticing Defusion

An important aspect of successful defusion is actually noticing when defusion is happening. When defusion happens there is an untangling of the different aspects of an experience. This can be relevant for yourself or if you are working with clients, and can manifest itself in many ways.

At the level of the mind, defusion might show itself in the ways that you are less disturbed or bothered by certain thoughts. You might start to observe and have the thoughts, without getting taken over or emotionally overwrought by them. You can have thoughts, ideas, and urges, but might

not have to act on them immediately or every time. Defusion means that the negativity or irrationality of the mind is generally getting less.

To help you understand your level of the defusion of thoughts, you can ask yourself the following question:

On a scale of one to ten, how hooked are you on that specific thought right now? 1 meaning you are not caught up in the story at all, 10 meaning you are completely caught up.

Also, you might begin to notice actual behavioral changes. As you begin to defuse thoughts, sensations, and emotions, all these different levels start to become clearer and exist more independently. With fusion, body posture, tone of voice, physical gestures, facial depression, patterns of fidgeting, content, and speed and volume of speech are all somehow happening together. So as you or a client start believing less in thoughts such as “I am unworthy”, the body's posture might change. It might begin standing taller, speaking louder, stopping fidgeting and generally having a stronger presence.

Fusion of thoughts and direct experiences may lead to disengagement, disinterest, avoidance, the inability to speak or concentrate, or on the other hand fixation of a certain topic. Defusion could potentially show itself in the exact opposite. Finding yourself or a client to be more engaged, open, resisting less, and sharing openly and honestly. Maybe you find that you are slowly defusing, as you can start to share memories of your childhood or a traumatic event without crying.

With defusion usually comes a greater acceptance and often even a willingness to let go of a specific topic or want to change something.

Now reflect for yourself.

1. Have you noticed any of the signs or characteristics of defusion lately?

2. On a scale of 1 to 10, how willing and open are you to make a desired change in your life (1 meaning not at all, 10 meaning fully)?

3. How can defusion support you in your healing process?

4. What can you do to support defusion, while limiting fusion?

2.11 Thought Bingo

Here is a fun tool for you in helping you understand and name your favorite thought distortions. Remember that thought distortions are common ways of thinking that are usually inaccurate or negatively biased. This chart does not include all possible thought distortions, only the most common ones. Your task is to match the category with the correct example, then add some colors to the graphic to represent your 3 favorite thought distortions. Your favorites are the ones you find yourself using the most! You will also find a field to add your personal favorite thought distortion.

magnification	"The way that person is looking at me, he must not like me."	fortune telling	"You either have what it takes, or you don't."	always being right
"All people are selfish."	all or nothing	"When I got stuck in traffic the morning of an important department meeting, I imagined my boss would fire me on the spot, as soon as I entered the meeting room."	'should' statements	"If I feel anxious about this meeting, it must go wrong."
"I remember exactly what happened and what he said. There is absolutely no	filtering	mind reading	"I might have received all A's in the past, but this D clearly shows I am stupid."	labeling

doubt or arguing about it.”				
“To make my partner happy, I should give them a gift on Valentine's Day.”	self-blame	personalization	“My current partner is going to cheat on me, I just know it.”	“Surely my friend ignored me in the supermarket because she doesn't like me.”
overgeneralization	Add your favorite thought distortion _____ —	“She is immature and lacking experience.”	“I am responsible for my partner's depression.”	emotional reasoning

2.12 Fusion in Everyday Language

It is so easy to just be taken over by our thoughts, emotions, and sensations. Even everyday language is often fusing these different aspects together. The more we repeat these fused words, the less we will notice that we are actually encouraged to be taken by the thinking mind.

Here are some examples.

“I am lost in my grief.”

“I am ruled by my obsessive tendencies.”

“I feel completely stuck.”

“I am getting swept away by my emotions.”

“My cravings are controlling me.”

“I am consumed by my depression.”

“I am in the grip of my parents.”

“I am dominated by anxious and irrational thoughts.”

When we are facing thoughts and feelings we do not want to experience, we use terms such as *“fighting”*, *“escaping”*, *“suppressing”*, *“zoning out”*, *“ignoring”*, or *“distracting”*.

These terms and the previous statements indirectly imply that there is something wrong with what we are experiencing. This is not to imply that those statements should never be used. Surely we all want to distract and

zone out sometimes. And there are more or less healthy ways to do so. Still it's good to pay attention to our everyday language and how the language that we use encourages the fusions of thoughts, emotions, and experiences.

What words or phrases do you frequently use, where you are fusing thoughts, emotions, and sensations together?

If you are having trouble coming up with specific phrases or words, what are your favorite ones from the list above?

What is the one word or phrase you want to delete out of your personal dictionary?

2.13 Defusion in Three Steps

Here is an exercise for those who like to follow step-by-step approaches. This approach is similar to those that are found in other therapeutic manuals, but includes a final, more creative step.

Step 1: Take note of what it is that you are observing. Write down these observations.

I am having the thought_____

I am having the feeling (emotions)_____

I am having feeling (sensations)_____

Write down what applies.

Step 2: Label your Observation as either repetitive or evaluative. Usually one of the two applies.

This may already be quite insightful when you realize what kind of thoughts you repetitively have or in which way the thoughts or emotions are

evaluative. Evaluative thoughts and emotions are subjective. That means that you are putting in your own interpretation or judgment, and often seeing things or situations as “truth”. Other people could see the situation completely differently.

Step 3: Create an image for the most repetitive and evaluative observation.

What do these thoughts, these emotions, or these sensations look like? What form or size do they have? How would you describe them? If you like, you can draw what you are imagining here. Are they dark heavy circles? Or maybe they're a light hazy cloud. Are they a face or perhaps an animal? What is the facial expression of the animal or the person? This requires a bit of creativity and openness from your end. But why not try?

Draw the image on separate piece of paper:

2.14 Silly Ways to Defuse

Here is a tool if you are open to more creative ways to defuse and untangle the intertwined experiences. Sometimes it can be very helpful to take the thinking mind especially a little less seriously. Same goes for viewing our emotions. If you are finding yourself in a female body, no matter how your mental health is at the moment, surely you know the ups and downs of your moods and emotions through hormonal changes during the month. Sometimes there is raging anger, frustration, or sadness on the inside, for absolutely no apparent reason. It is hard to deal with this as it is, and becomes even more tricky when paired with any psychological illnesses. So bringing more humor into our life is one of the healthiest ways to deal with stress, changing moods, and hormones and physical pain.²⁰ So here are some humorous ways to defuse:

Sing your thought, your emotion, or your sensation: Say you have been struggling with chronic pain for a while. There is a physical explanation for the pain, but you couldn't take as many painkillers as you would need to really eliminate it. You are stuck with the pain, at least for now. Or maybe you find yourself unable to get out of bed for the 5th day in a row.

Whatever you are doing and saying to yourself, it is not working. You have already made yourself fall out of the bed, now you are just lying around on the floor. Neither of these two situations is funny to you at the moment. In both cases you are suffering. There is no doubt about it. If you want, try to make a song about the situation you are currently in. If you like, you can make it rhyme and have it follow the melody of your choice. You can also rap about your pain or inability to get up.

If you are struggling to apply this tool when symptoms are very intense, try it when symptoms are a bit more moderate. Maybe try it when you find yourself functioning in life, but confronted with intense mood swings and negative feelings. You could write a song about how you feel, and then sing it at the top of your lungs. You can take inspiration from Taylor Swift, Bon Jovi, or Metallica, whatever works for you.

Similar to this is ridiculing a specific thought or emotion you are having. This is not pretending it's not there, but noticing how the nature of a thought or emotion changes as you give it a different meaning. Saying in a humorous or mocking tone *"I am so helpless"* or *"I am going to risk my life driving drunk to get more liquor"* might get you a whole new meaning. This can be very intense. If you feel ready for this, say the statement that applies to you several times in this mocking or humorous tone. Keep on saying it even if resistance arises. You might find yourself getting very emotional. You might laugh at yourself. You might also feel intense sadness coming up. Be with whatever emotions arise. Hold space for yourself. Be compassionate. This can be very powerful.

2.15 If the Thoughts Fully Controlled Us

To end this chapter on defusion let's finish with a few questions you can answer to yourself:

- What if the thoughts, the emotions, and the sensations fully controlled you?
- Where would you be?
- Would you even still be here?

Even if we are not struggling from psychological illnesses, we can have nasty and disturbing thoughts, hateful and irrational emotions, and inexplicable sensations. Even though we all get disturbed by these things, you will probably agree that we are not fully controlled by them. If you were fully controlled by the rage, the anger, the self-destruction, you probably wouldn't be here anymore, or you might potentially be in prison.

And even if we have limiting and disturbing thoughts like “*Everyone hates me*” or “*I am worthless*”, did you ever find yourself going to a family gathering or meeting with your best friend even while having these thoughts? Did you ever think you cannot go on any further, but somehow went on anyway, and things got better? Did you ever feel filled with raging anger, but somehow remained calm and in control? Did you ever feel sad but acted as if you were happy? Most likely the answer to some, if not all of these questions is “yes”. The thoughts, the emotions, or the sensations can be so strong, yet we do not always act upon them. So at least sometimes we have a choice.

Try a little little practice right now: Stand up with both feet firmly planted on the ground. Now close your eyes and tell yourself, “*I can't move*”, “*I can't move*”, “*I can't move*”. Tell yourself this over and over again for about 30 seconds. Then try to start walking. What do you notice? Of course you were able to eventually move, but you might have also noticed a moment of hesitation, right?

We tend to believe whatever our mind tells us! It doesn't matter if this is helpful to us at the moment or not. We need to learn to take the mind with a pinch of salt and begin to understand how and where it supports us, and where it doesn't. Look at the different aspects of our being (emotions, sensations, and thoughts) separately at first, knowing that they are all connected. This is where acceptance overlaps with being present, another ACT process. Some practices in this chapter can also be helpful for being more present. Also, to create the link to another ACT process, commitment, acceptance is not a requirement for committed actions, but it is surely supportive.

3. ACT TOOLS FOR BEING PRESENT

In this chapter we will be exploring different tools supporting us in being more present. Remember, being more present means being in the *here* and *now*. Somehow having a deeper, more intimate connection with this very moment, as this is the only moment where behavior actually occurs. Notice how you are reading these lines, how you read the word *now*, to remind you to become present in this moment. And again reading the word *now*, or *now*, or *now*. And noticing every time you finish reading the word *now*, the present moment already lies in the past again. So in this chapter we will be exploring a series of mindfulness techniques and tools. Jon Kabat-Zim defines mindfulness as the awareness that arises through paying attention, on purpose, in the present moment, non-judgmentally.²⁴ Some of these practices might seem very simple, almost too easy to be effective. Why? Because they are. Mindfulness and being present is natural and easy for us. We know how to do this. The only tricky part about being present is remembering to do so. The rest is easy. The tools are intended to help you spend more time in the present moment. So a lot of these tools are presenting ideas and inspirations of how you can be more present in everyday life.

This chapter and these tools are not meant to downplay any of the struggles you might be having at the moment. The battles in life are real. Often they seem hard, endless, even hopeless, and listening to someone (especially a therapist) tell you to come back to the present moment may actually be the straw that breaks the camel's back. So all of the tools that follow should be used with care and, ideally, with supervision of a licensed professional. Mindfulness works. These techniques work, yet there needs to be a tiny bit of openness and the right headspace to engage in such practices at the moment. These tools are not likely to be effective if you are finding yourself having a lot of resistance and little openness to change at the moment.

As mentioned, most of us can access the present moment. Many of us, though, cannot remain there for very long. If you are suffering from OCD, addiction, depression, anxiety, eating disorders, any kind of mental illness

really, you will know very well that remaining in the present moment can be very difficult. Still, it is something that can be practiced and regularly needs to be experienced. Depending on the quality of our mind, thoughts, emotions, and sensations, being present might seem impossible right now. But maybe you can ask your worries and doubts to step aside for some moments. And as you go through this chapter remember Nelson Mandela's words while you are reading: "It always seems impossible until it's done."

3.1 External Anchors

As mentioned in the introduction, using mindfulness techniques as a way to connect with the present moment is easy. Remembering to do so during a busy day of taking care of work, family, relationships etc., while potentially battling any mental, emotional, or physical fights, is another story. So a very effective approach to becoming more mindful in everyday life is using so-called anchors to remind us to come back to the present moment. These anchors serve as reminders to come back when you find yourself getting taken by thoughts, sensations, or emotions.

Anchors can be external, like a door or a specific object you carry with you, or they can be internal, like the breath, the body, the senses. The function of both is similar as both serve as reminders to become present again. To come back into the *here* and *now*, and to leave behind the past and future. We are all distracted or "get taken" many times throughout the day. What differentiates one person from another, is how long they get stuck in reminiscing about a happy/sad/traumatic memory of the past, or wishful thinking about the future. Picking an anchor that resonates with you can greatly help and remind you to be present. Say you pick the external anchor "Door". Every time you see, go through, or touch a door, this would become an invitation to become present. Or you could take a small object, like a keychain you received from your best friend years ago. This key chain becomes your "Being Present Anchor". Everytime you see, touch, or hold the key chain, there is the invitation to come back to *here* and *now*. No matter if you are just arguing with your partner or listening to your kids as you unlock your front door, touching the key chain invites you back into being present.

Note that this is likely to not work right away. Our brain needs to build the neural connection first, linking doors or key chains with becoming present. But if you stick with it, and continue practicing becoming present when walking through a door, you will start to have this moment of remembering to be present every time you see a door. Becoming more present will be like any other behavior or skill that we slowly built up.

In this tool you are invited to pick your own “Being Present Anchor”. This can be any object or thing. Ideally it is something that you regularly come across. We need to be reminded to be present many times a day, before this behavior becomes more natural. So pick an object or a thing that you feel could be a suitable anchor.

Please write the anchor here. On a separate piece of paper draw the anchor.

What connection do you have to this object or thing?

How do you feel this object can remind you to be more present?

So what do you actually do when you see the object? Good question. Just take a few seconds, and remind yourself to be present in the HERE and NOW. Notice where you are and what you are doing. If it helps, you can also say the words “I am present” three to five times to yourself. Or something similar that works for you. The invitation is to make this a moment where you pause and just are. So, to the best of your ability, turn off external and internal chatter.

Tip 1: If you pick an object with which you have an emotional connection, then it is easier for the brain to learn the importance and meaning of this anchor.

Tip 2: If you notice after a while that you are not at all connecting with your anchor and it is not reminding or helping you in becoming more present, feel free to pick another anchor.

3.2 Anchoring Yourself Through Your Breath

Picking an anchor that works for us can sometimes be tricky. We might not find an object we resonate with. For example, if it's something neutral like a door, we might have a hard time using the door to motivate and bring us back into being present. External objects, especially when they are “neutral”, *can*, but do not have to work. If you are having difficulties using external objects and things as an anchor into being present, here is a tool for you:

Why not use something that you have on or with you at all times? For many people anchors that really work are actually located on their physical bodies, or are physical processes that always happen. For example some people use their feet as their “Being Present Anchor”. Every time they look down and see their feet, this is an invitation into the *now*. Or the breath! Surely you have thought of this one. Maybe you have even tried a mindfulness meditation where you concentrate on breath. The breath is actually the anchor that can support us in moments of intensity, no matter if this is due to intense emotions, sensations, or overwhelming, disturbing, negative thoughts. The breath can not only anchor us in the present moment but it can actually calm us.

Let's try this here: In this practice you are invited to breathe in and out through the nose. You might not be used to this, but it is actually the healthiest way to breathe. If you need to you can also exhale through the mouth, especially if it helps you relax.

If it is possible, find yourself somewhere you can sit safely and close your eyes.

Just sit for a moment, trying to relax your body.

Ease any tension in your shoulders, tension in the jaw, or the forehead.

Sit in an upright, yet relaxed position.

Now simply begin watching your breath.

Notice how it flows in through the nostrils, a slight cooling sensation.

Notice how it fills your chest and your lungs with air.

Notice how it also lightly fills your belly with air.

Notice how the air flows out again through the nose or partially through the mouth.

Maybe you perceive a sense of relief, lightness, or rejuvenation.

You might notice, as you are paying attention to your breath, that it becomes deeper, maybe even slower.

Watch your breath in this manner for at least 90 seconds (longer if you can).

Stay with your breath for as long as you can. Allow your breath to remind you to be present in the *here* and *now*. If you find yourself getting distracted by thoughts, simply come back to watching your breath.

What happened at the level of the mind, the body, and the emotions in this practice?

Did this practice help you in calming down, coming back to the present moment?

If not, what else could you do?

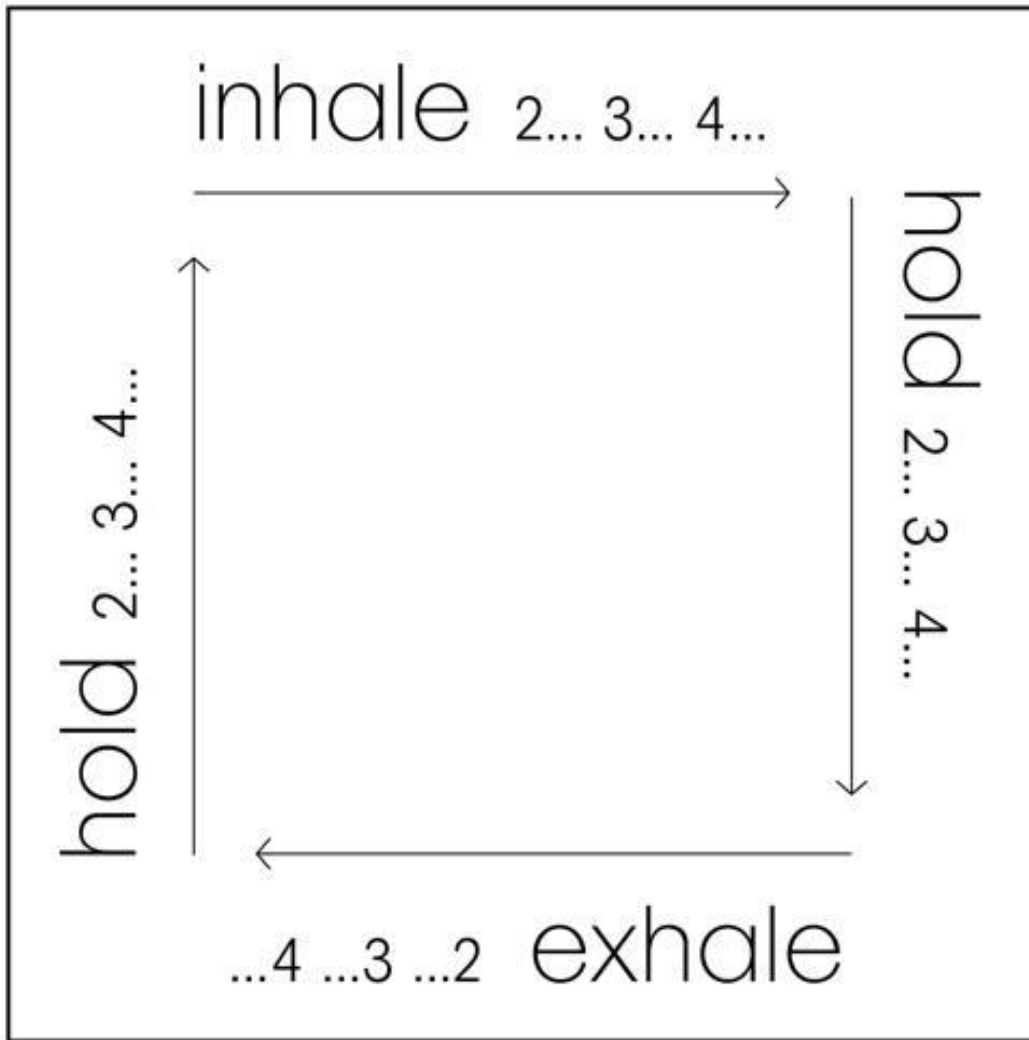
Once you have done this a few times, you will be able to practice anchoring yourself through your breath, no matter where you are: on an airplane, in a busy supermarket, at work, etc.

3.3 Square Breathing

Your breath is your secret super power into being present. Deep breathing increases the supply of oxygen to your brain and stimulates the parasympathetic nervous system. When this system is activated, it promotes a state of calmness. It is one of the most effective ways to reconnect yourself with your body. It can quiet the worries, doubts, and fears in your head, while leaving you feeling refreshed and calmer.²⁵ For Yogis there is a whole science to working with the breath called Pranayama. In this thousand-year-old tradition conscious and controlled breathing is used to support the functioning and health of the body, the emotions, and the mind. Modern Science is becoming more and more interested in researching the health benefits of yoga and Pranayama.²⁶

In this tool, one of the easiest yogic Pranayama techniques is introduced. This technique is called Sama Vritti, or square breathing. Square breathing simply means that there are equal parts to our breathing. Often when we don't pay attention to our breathing, it can become very shallow and that means we are actually not supplying our body AND brain with sufficient oxygen. Even when we focus on inhaling, we might just follow the inhale with a shallow exhale. So this tool invites you into practicing deeper, equalized breathing, and also introduces a gap in between breaths, which is called retention. If you try this practice and do not feel comfortable holding your breath, or if you have any kind of problems with your heart or lungs, have high blood pressure, or are pregnant, do not practice this without checking back with your physician.

Here is an image that explains how to practice Sama Vritti, the square breathing:



Find yourself a comfortable place in your home or wherever you are, where you can be undisturbed for 3 to 5 minutes.

You can sit on a chair, or if your body allows, on the floor. Just make sure your spine is straight and you can remain in this posture for a few minutes. Breathe regularly for about 30 seconds, simply watching your breath.

- Then begin counting your breath as you inhale to a count of 4.
- Hold your breath for 4 seconds.
- Exhale slowly, also taking around 4 seconds.
- Then again, hold your breath for 4 seconds. That's it.

That is one round of Sama Vritti. Repeat the practice of inhaling, holding, exhaling, and holding to a count of 4 for about 3-5 minutes, or longer if you can. If you find yourself getting distracted or losing count, don't worry, just come back to the practice. You will notice the more you practice this, the easier it will become. If you are having trouble counting in your head you can use your thumb to touch the other four fingers one after another, also lasting about 4 seconds. This is a simplified version of Sama Vritti.

3.4 Sensing the Chair

Being present is all about somehow being aware of the present moment. How often do we find ourselves on autopilot through the busy days, only to come back to "reality" after minutes or even hours of what feels like just having been taken away? Most of us have these moments. Even when you begin to practice becoming more mindful, you will continue to have these moments. It might even feel like you are having more of these "autopilot" moments as you begin to practice. It is like you are sharpening your perception to be more aware. The more we sharpen our perception for something, the more we also begin to notice when we are not doing the things we would like to. But with practice, being present becomes a way of living in which you then become more connected with each and every moment in life.

Here is another simple mindfulness practice that you can basically do everywhere. It is a bit like a mini-meditation with a bit of guidance.

This time you are invited to sit in a chair (if you are not already sitting in one). Make yourself comfortable in this chair. You can scoot around a bit to position the buttocks, maybe you could also sit on a comfortable pillow. See if you can sit in this chair in a way that feels relaxing, but also has a bit of firmness to your posture. You don't want to be falling asleep or slouching in

the chair. If there is someone around, ask them to guide you in this meditation by reading the following text and making pauses after each instruction.

You are sitting in your chair with your feet firmly planted on the ground.

Your back is upright and firm. At the same time, you can feel a sense of relaxation in the entire body.

If you like and it is safe, you can close your eyes. (When we close our eyes, we turn off the main sense of sight, helping us become more aware of what is going on inside.)

If it does not feel safe to close your eyes, or this brings anxiety or an influx of thoughts, feel free to just keep your eyes halfway open and look a few feet in front of you on the ground, not focusing on anything.

Now simply begin to feel the seat you are sitting on.

What does this seat feel like? No need to answer these questions out loud, simply explore on the inside.

Is it hard? Soft? Comfortable? Uncomfortable?

How does it feel to be sitting on this seat?

The mind might start to chatter at this point and say things such as “This is stupid, I have so much to do, and I am feeling the seat of my chair”. Or it might say things such as “Wow, I am just realizing how exhausted I am.” Whatever the mind says, let it talk and come back to feeling the quality of the seat.

Now begin to feel the back of the chair. Feel how the back of the chair supports and holds you.

If there is any chatter of the mind, just let it pass, while you come back into feeling the back of the chair.

Now feel the back of the chair together with the seat.

Feel the support of both parts of the chair and see how they hold and support your body.

Depending on the activity of your mind and how your body feels at the moment, this may be very difficult. Being present is about coming back

again and again into the present moment. In this tool we do this through the chair, the seat, and the back of the chair. We are feeling the connection of the body to these parts of the chair.

3.5 Where Are Your Problems?

When we look at our problems and challenges, there is something interesting about these. What are some of the challenges and problems you are currently facing? Maybe you are worried and anxious about an upcoming meeting at work. Maybe you feel a sense of tension and fear, when thinking about the next family reunion. Or you might be struggling with difficult emotional memories. When we specifically look at our problems in the form of thoughts, ideas, and memories, we might notice that most of these have either already happened (past) or we believe that they will happen (future). This doesn't make them less challenging or less disturbing, but the fact is the problem lies in the past or in the future.

There are painful memories from the past that are still affecting us emotionally today. There are worries and doubts about the future, for things we might or might not be able to influence. The point is, when the painful memories or the doubts arise, they have little or nothing to do with the present. This is why learning to become more present through mindfulness is so effective. Most of us spend little time consciously hanging out in the present. When we learn this though, we might notice that memories of the past and worries of the future become less.

Take a look at the present moment. What problems are there in this very moment?

Notice how when one moment has passed, it is not the present moment anymore. As soon as you look at the present moment, it is already in the past.

Note: This approach does not work the same for difficult emotions or physical sensations (like chronic pain) that are experienced in the moment. These phenomena are there, and you are fully experiencing them in the present moment. The anger, the jealousy, the sadness, the hopelessness and

physical sensations of pain are undeniably there. They might be linked to a memory or an experience, but caught up in these you are not very likely to see this. When you can safely be present with yourself when experiencing intense emotions or sensations, you will learn that at some point, these too will pass. And then in that moment there is no “problem” but maybe the memory of one.

3.6 Leaves, Streams & Clouds

What can you do to connect with the present moment, when emotions are running high or you are suffering from chronic pain? In these cases, someone who tells you to come back to the present moment and asks you what the problem *in this very moment is*, will likely trigger you even more. If you were experiencing anger before, you are likely to be experiencing rage after someone asks you that question. When others seem to deny our feelings or tell us to just feel in another way, the result is usually just the opposite. It is like someone is denying our reality, our perception, our emotions, our thoughts. Some therapists might purposefully use this method to create more awareness, but in general, when we don't feel heard or understood, we are likely to close down more. So no matter if you or someone you know is struggling with their mental health, the most important aspect is to always take them seriously. This means taking the emotions, the sensations, thoughts, and the overall situation seriously. You are not responsible for how anyone feels. You generally can't change how someone feels and what they are going through. But you can be present for them, if you feel comfortable with this. And if you do not feel comfortable or are even overwhelmed by something that someone is sharing with you, you can say this too.

Let's include a simple tool that you can use by yourself or with a client whose emotions are running high, or when there are physical sensations present in the moment.

The idea is to again come back into the present moment and gain a bit of distance from the intense emotions and/or sensations. As you are experiencing these emotions or sensations, imagine that you can literally see them in front of you passing as a leaf on a river or a cloud in the sky. You are seeing how the emotion is labeled, and how the sensations are

described. You can literally picture the clouds or the leaves with words on top of them, passing by in front of you. You can see the size, shape, and color of the clouds or leaves.

It is like every time you are having that emotion or that sensation, there is another cloud to visualize it.

Use the analogy that works best for you and just watch the clouds and leaves pass by for some time. It is likely that clouds with intense emotions like rage, sadness, or jealousy will pass multiple times. That is OK. Let them pass.

How was this practice for you?

3.7 Body Scan

As mentioned before, one of the best ways to come back and connect with the present moment is by coming back into the body. This can be done through the breath or by actually feeling into the body.

This tool describes a simple body scan that can be used for relaxation, but also in moments when there is an overabundance of thoughts, emotions, and sensations. If you have ever been to a yoga class, this might remind you of Shavasana, or the final relaxation. Some ancient Yogis will describe this practice as one of the most important practices in yoga, as it helps increase awareness and sensitivity of all the different body parts. Plus it calms the breath, it activates the mind, and increases the activity of the parasympathetic nervous system, which is responsible for rest-and-digest. If you have a stressful lifestyle, are constantly moving, or if you are sleep deprived, this tool is likely to put you to sleep. In this case, that is good too, as the body needs rest. Ideally you can have someone read this to you or you can use it in a therapy session.

Find yourself a comfortable and warm place where you can lie down. This can be on a yoga mat, a carpet, or on a bed. If it's cooler where you are, have a blanket ready to use in case you need it.

You are invited to simply lie down, resting the entire body on the floor. You can feel how every body part is touching the floor. You feel firmly grounded and held by the floor. At the same time your body feels light and relaxed.

We are going to begin scanning the different parts of our body. Scanning just means that we bring our awareness to different body parts. We simply scan by noticing the body part, making note of any sensations or feelings. Sometimes there may even be pictures, thoughts, and ideas as we bring our awareness to each body part. If we notice anything that somehow irritates us, we try to just let it pass and not focus on this.

We begin by simply bringing our attention to our toes and feet. Just scanning the toes and feet. Simply noticing any sensations.

We then continue with scanning the lower legs. We can move up slowly and steadily, scanning the ankles, shins, front and back of the lower legs, and scanning the knees. Simply noticing any sensations.

We then continue with scanning the upper legs. Again moving up slowly above the knees, scanning the front and back of the thighs, and scanning the hips.

We then continue with the pelvis and buttocks.

We scan the abdominal and sexual organs, simply noticing any sensations.

If we ever perceive any form of tension, we can try to relax that particular body part, and see if this eases up on the tension.

We scan our back, starting from the bottom and last vertebra and slowly moving up towards the middle back, and eventually the upper back, scanning vertebrae by vertebrae. Simply noticing any sensations.

Then we return to the front of the body, scanning again the belly and the area around the navel.

We scan the area of the chest and the heart, simply noticing any sensations.

We continue scanning the shoulders, clavicles, neck and throat. Simply noticing any sensations.

And finally we scan our head, our entire face, especially the area around the eyes and forehead. Simply noticing any sensations.

Once we have scanned the entire body, we can remain for a few more minutes in this relaxed state, bringing a release of any tension. We can also go back to any areas where we noted tension. We can try to relax these areas more, scanning them, simply noticing any sensations.

Eventually we can very slowly come back from this body scan, taking as much time as we need. Resting some more on the floor, for as long as we need, and eventually getting back up and taking care not to move too quickly, in case we feel a bit weak or dizzy.

What did you experience during this practice?

3.8 The Nature Walk

Research shows that one of the easiest and best ways to become more present and mindful is being in nature. When we are in nature, we are invited to leave the space of the mind and enter the world of the senses. We are invited into seeing, touching, smelling, hearing, and if it's safe, even tasting nature. Whenever we come out of the mind and into the senses, into the body, there is a deeper intimacy with the present moment and therefore with ourselves. Better than just being in nature is actually going for a walk in nature. Research shows that walking betters your mood, reduces negative thoughts, and energizes your whole being.²⁷ This tool is inviting you or someone you are working with into this very simple, yet powerful practice. It is combining being in nature with taking a walk. It invites you to spend 10 minutes in nature right now or later today. The options are endless: take a walk in the park, go into your backyard, drive into the forest, or if time is short spend 10 minutes on your balcony or in front of your house. Ideally, you can go somewhere that's green and quiet. Spend at least 10 minutes there, perceiving everything around you with all the senses. Try to be fully present and aware of what you observe, and spend more time in nature if you'd like.

This tool is simple. But just like with mindfulness in general, we have to remember to practice.

Where did you go and what did you observe (hear, see, smell, touch)?

How did you like it?

If you didn't like it, where can you go next time?

On a scale of 1 - 10 (1 not at all, 10 fully) how present were you before the walk? _____

On a scale of 1 - 10 (1 not at all, 10 fully) how present were you during the walk? _____

On a scale of 1 - 10 (1 not at all, 10 fully) how present were you after the walk? _____

3.9 Being Present and the Senses

To anchor ourselves in the present moment we can use our breath, an external anchor, or we can come back into our body through using our 5 senses. Learning to tune into the different senses is one of the most connecting experiences with ourselves and actually also with others. For this reason this toolkit will include inspirations to connect you with each of the five senses. If you did the nature walk practice (3.8), you were already invited into being present in nature with your entire being, especially through the sense of sight, really seeing and perceiving the world and your surroundings with curious and open eyes. Interesting insights come, when we really begin to tune into and focus on one of the five senses.

Let's explore your connection with your senses in this tool. It's a fun, easy way to approach your senses, your sensitivity, and your preferences.

SENSE	FAVORITE EXPERIENCE	LEAST FAVORITE EXPERIENCE	HOW CONNECTED DO YOU FEEL WITH THIS SENSE? On a scale of 1-10 (1 not at all, 10 fully)
Sight			
Sound			
Smell			
Taste			
Touch			

This chart is to help you reflect on your different senses and the meaning they have to you. We all have senses we feel deeply connected with. Others we connect with less. That is normal, but sometimes it can really enrich life, when we start to open up and practice experiencing more through the senses that seem less available to us.

3.10 Mindful Eating

One of the most important mindfulness practices you can learn and integrate into your daily life is mindful eating. Why? Because we do this several times a day, usually at specific times of the day. Eating gives us a regular routine. Since we all generally take time to rejuvenate and refresh through eating several times a day, why not use this time as a mindfulness

anchor. Mindful eating not only includes the process of eating the food, but also the process of sourcing and preparing.²⁸ Mindful sourcing would mean that we know where our food is coming from. We pay attention to the quality of the food by buying locally and seasonally. Then we also become more mindful of how we prepare the food, paying attention to what we throw away and how we feel while we cook, for example. Mindful eating is about all the choices you make in regard to food, from the moment you decide to buy something at the grocery store, to the moment that your digestive system gets rid of what can't be used. It includes everything.

In mindful eating we observe our eating patterns, and we might even decide to make changes. We start to pay attention to not only what we eat but also to why we eat, how much, and the way we eat.

Below are some steps/ideas to mindful eating during a meal.²⁸ Choose the order or the steps that feel most alive and relevant for you.

1. **Honoring the food:.** Taking a moment of gratitude and acknowledgement before beginning to eat. Looking at the food, smelling the food, and taking this moment to realize that receiving regular, tasty meals is not something to be taken for granted.
2. **Engage all your senses:.** Really lower your nose towards your food and smell it. You may notice that the saliva starts accumulating in your mouth in anticipation. We have the same reaction as animals, but most of the time do not allow this reflex to kick in as we are already shoveling things down. Digestion actually begins in the mouth, exactly through the help of this saliva.
3. Savor **small bites**, and **chew thoroughly**. This can help immensely with overeating and regulating your digestion. Sometimes we might be surprised by the size of the chunks of food we are just swallowing down and expecting our stomachs to handle.
4. **Eat slowly**. Many people, especially those with eating disorders, state that they do not feel satiety (or feeling full). Mindful eating can help with that. Your feeling of satiety might return after some time of practicing mindful eating or if you are

mindful about the portions you choose in the first place, as you know your body size and needs.

5. **Eat regular and smaller meals.** This recommendation works for most people, as long pauses in-between meals may lead to binge eating. Others, though, do very well following a rhythm that is more like intermittent fasting. Know yourself and know what happens in your body as you get hungry. Will you go for fatty fast food if you wait too long or can you enjoy a snack until you encounter what is good and healthy for you? Just notice how you feel after you eat certain things, and start to make choices to eat things that will make you feel good and nourished (physically).
6. There are many recommendations both for ourselves and the planet on eating a plant-based diet. The choice is yours, of course.
7. Last and most importantly, when you eat, why not **try to just eat**. Turn off the TV and your phone. You could have some moments of silence for the first 5 minutes at the dinner table and just be with the food, the taste, and any other sensations you might have.

There could be a separate book about eating and mindful eating, which is why this tool was a bit longer. Fact is, mindful eating helps reduce emotional and binge eating, and generally helps you become more aware of your relationship with food.

3.11 Mindful Listening

Another powerful mindful practice is linked to our sense of hearing. How often do we catch ourselves listening to someone as we already formulate our opinion, suggestion, or advice in our heads, only to shoot it out as soon as the other person stops speaking? If you find yourself realizing at this moment that this is you, you are not alone. This is common. We want to support and share our experiences, especially if we have gone through something similar. Even as a therapist, there may be impulses to do so, but if this is the case you may also know that sharing your own experiences or

struggles with a client is rarely supportive. People feel unheard or not seen when we pour our perception, or worse our advice, on them shortly after they finish sharing. And in a client-therapist relationship, it can bring confusion or uncertainties to the relationship. So here are the instructions for mindful listening. This can work anywhere, with anyone. If people around you are used to you speaking and sharing a lot, they may be a bit irritated at first when you begin to practice mindful listening. In this case you can share with them that you would like to practice sharing less, and listening more to fully understand what is being shared with you. Everyone likes to be listened to.

Again, a simple practice, but a powerful tool.

How to practice mindful listening in your next conversation?

1. Make sure you are really available to listen. If you have your head full, are hungry, worried about an important deadline, or are expecting a call, let the other person know you can't be fully available for them. Come back to have the conversation when you both are fully available.
2. Just listen to the words that are coming out of the mouth of the person you are speaking to. Try to just listen to the words, without interpretations or judgements. Forget about your own ideas and similar experiences, just listen. Ask questions when you really don't understand something, then let the other person finish sharing. When they are finished, ask if they are done sharing or if they would like to share something else. This is also called active listening and is an important skill in communication.
3. In order to do all the things in step 2, you need to be extra present and aware to notice all the things that are going on in the background (like advice that is being formulated in your head, starting to think of other things when you get bored, etc.). These things can and will happen, but how much attention will you give them? This is why step 1 is so important. If you are not available because you are hungry, emotional, tired, etc., you can't really listen to someone.

4. Recap what the other person said and ask if you fully understand them. If you feel up for the challenge, ask them what they feel they would need from you in this moment. “Would you like to hear my advice?” or “Would you care to hear of a similar experience I had?”

While this kind of communication can work with anyone, it is not always easy. Especially people that are suffering from intense psychological distress, might have a hard time following this model. Here the conversation might need to be kept shorter, more focused, and led with specific questions.

3.12 Mindful Speaking

Mindful speaking can be combined with mindful listening, the practice in 3.11. Both are very relevant in everyday life, mental struggles or not. Being mindful about how we speak and what we say doesn't only influence how we feel, but also how we live our life in the long run. So we should never underestimate the power of our words and choose them wisely. For many of us what we say is what we think, and eventually becomes what we do. There may be a certain filter, which is sometimes helpful especially if we are still struggling with a lot of negative, irrational, and even hateful thinking. In this case it is important to be even more mindful of what we say. Thoughts are just thoughts and don't get put out into the world until we choose to speak them. Mindful speaking invites that this unconscious process of selecting and speaking our words becomes more conscious.

How can we do this? Generally by slowing down. We slow down at least 30 if not 50 %, doing everything at half the pace. Ever notice how very wise and educated people speak in a very concise, selective, almost painfully slow way? Because there is a process happening we can't see. A process where there is a conscious decision to speak certain words out loud. These people are aware of the impact that they have with everything that they say. When you listen to the words of Dr. Martin Luther King in his “I Have a Dream” speech there is no question whether every single one of those words was chosen consciously or not. You feel the impact of his words with your entire being, and might even get goosebumps as you hear “I have a

dream that one day this nation will rise up and live out the true meaning of its creed: We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal."

This is conscious, mindful speaking by one of the most brilliant speakers and influential people of all time.

Remember a time where you were speaking consciously and mindfully. What did you speak about?

How did you feel while you were speaking?

How can you bring more mindful speaking into your everyday life?

3.13 Mindful Touch

Having explored all the other senses through mindfulness practice in previous tools, this tool concentrates on the sense of touch as a final exploration of being present and the senses. This practice can be extremely beautiful and connecting, especially for romantic partners. We have different receptors reacting to different types of touch. All of our body parts have a different sensitivity, and we each have personal preferences. Being touched, cuddling for example, releases oxytocin, the so-called bonding hormone that releases other hormones supporting our overall happiness.

Touch is something good. You might not like to be touched by everyone, that is very natural. Yet research shows that a lack of touch can make us stressed, anxious, or depressed.²⁹ For many people, COVID-19 had serious mental health implications exactly for this reason.³⁰

Here are some pointers for practicing mindful touch. You can do this with yourself or with someone you feel comfortable practicing with, like your romantic partner or your best friend. Only practice this with someone if you

feel comfortable and ask for consent. Otherwise, just practice on your own. Before you start, here some more pointers about what mindful touch is:

- Mindful touch is intentional (meaning you know where and how you are going to touch).
- Mindful touch comes from a place of love and connection, not expecting anything in return.
- Mindful touch is confident, yet coming from someone with a beginner's mind that is open to learn how their touch is being received.

If you are unsure how to practice this, here are a few examples of where you can practice mindful touch:

- Brushings or washing someone's (or your own) hair
- Giving someone a hug
- Back or neck massage

How was this experience for you?

If you practice with someone else, how was it being touched? What about touching your partner?

3.14 Finding a Practice Buddy

As this chapter on tools for being present is coming to an end, it is important to once again remember that the practice of being present or being mindful is easy per se. Remembering to do so is often the challenge.

Catching ourselves when we are running around on autopilot, stopping for a moment when we feel we are absolutely overwhelmed by all of our to-dos or deadlines, or when emotions are running high, is the key. Remembering to remember, so to say.

What's another great way to do this next to choosing an anchor that will remind us? Choosing a buddy or friend who is on a similar path, maybe even already a few steps ahead of us. Someone who reminds us through their actions and their behavior, and role models regularly how you too can become more present and more mindful.

This person doesn't have to be perfect, but can be someone who you feel has a good influence on you in this way.

Can you think of someone who could become your new best being present buddy? Write down their name here:

Call them up, and let them know how they support you with their behavior. Let them know what behaviors or actions they should call out when they observe you doing them. Did you do it? YES / NO (circle)

If you do not have a friend like this yet, where are these kinds of people? No rush, when the moment is right, these people will appear.

3.15 Mindful Moment Tracking

We end this chapter on mindfulness with a very practical tool that can help you be more mindful in everyday life. We don't need to discuss again how mindfulness can support your mental, emotional and physical health, but if you are still doubting this, please take on the challenge to try this tool for the next 7 days.

If you had a chance to do other practices in this toolkit, great! Use them as inspiration. If not, simply look at the index and the titles of each practice. The name is likely to give you inspiration for this tool.

In this tool, you are invited to practice fixed moments of mindfulness during the day, for seven days.

Please find a way to set yourself a reminder 2x per day. You are setting yourself a reminder to ***become mindful***. Ideally, you pick a fixed time of the

day, like a mealtime or before going to bed. You can set your reminder through an app, writing notes, calendar reminders, setting an alarm, whatever works for you. Think of a creative, engaging title for your reminder. Make this fun.

If you are looking to challenge yourself, set yourself this reminder, in times when you know you tend to get lost and taken. Like in the middle of the day, or during an afternoon low. When your reminder goes off, your challenge is to practice mindfulness no matter what you are doing. If you are eating, practice mindful eating. If you are in a meeting, practice becoming present. If you are with a friend, maybe take a moment of silence.

Mindfulness in everyday life can look like the following:

- Slowing down
- Becoming aware of where you are and what you're doing
- Inviting a moment of silence
- Noticing how you are feeling and what you are thinking
- Just being with yourself

Please write down your mindfulness reminder tool here:

For what times of the day will you set your mindfulness reminder?

What will you do when the mindfulness reminder goes off:

From when to when will you practice this? (Add the dates)

4. ACT TOOLS FOR SELF-AS-CONTEXT

This chapter will bring practical and insightful tools for another ACT Step, Self-as-context. In short, experiencing yourself as Self-as-context, not Self-as-concept. This means stepping into the observer role, which is able to see and witness all patterns and behaviors. Looking at the conceptualized self, the one that sees you in certain ways (“*I am hopeless*”, “*I am insecure*”, “*I am a bad person*”, etc.), and seeing where you can loosen the attachments to these concepts. Self-as-context *just is*, it doesn’t understand itself to be in any specific way. For many people, Self-as-context is a tough one. Why? Because it’s abstract. You can’t really describe this step in words, as you need to experience it. There really isn’t a “how-to” formula for Self-as-context. So in this chapter we are presenting different approaches and tools that will support you in developing a more flexible view of the Self, and strive to reduce attachment to language concepts that describe the “concept you”.

Russ explains in his book ACT Made Simple³¹, that this step is not absolutely crucial for people or patients to begin healing. As long as people are noticing that they are having certain thoughts, feelings, and sensations, then ACT can already work. This step is very useful however for patients with a traumatic past, with life shattering events, or severe illnesses, that “made it through the event” even if the physical body, emotions, and mind were harmed by the event or illness. We will speak in tool 4.13 in this section of how this is relevant.

The practices in this section are a bit shorter, and you will find mostly questions for reflections as well as short meditations. You won’t find too many formulas or step-by-step processes in this chapter, because Self-as-context is something you need to experience for yourself. For simplicity reasons, in this chapter we will be mostly referring to Self-as-context, often as the observer or the role of the observer. Prepare yourself for some fun and creative tools. The invitation for you is, as always, to simply bring openness. Like the Zen proverb “Empty your cup” suggests, to fill yourself with something new, sometimes you first need to empty your cup. While

this is one of the 6 steps of the ACT model, from personal experience and as a long-term meditation practitioner, this one can really be a game changer.

4.1 The Chessboard Metaphor

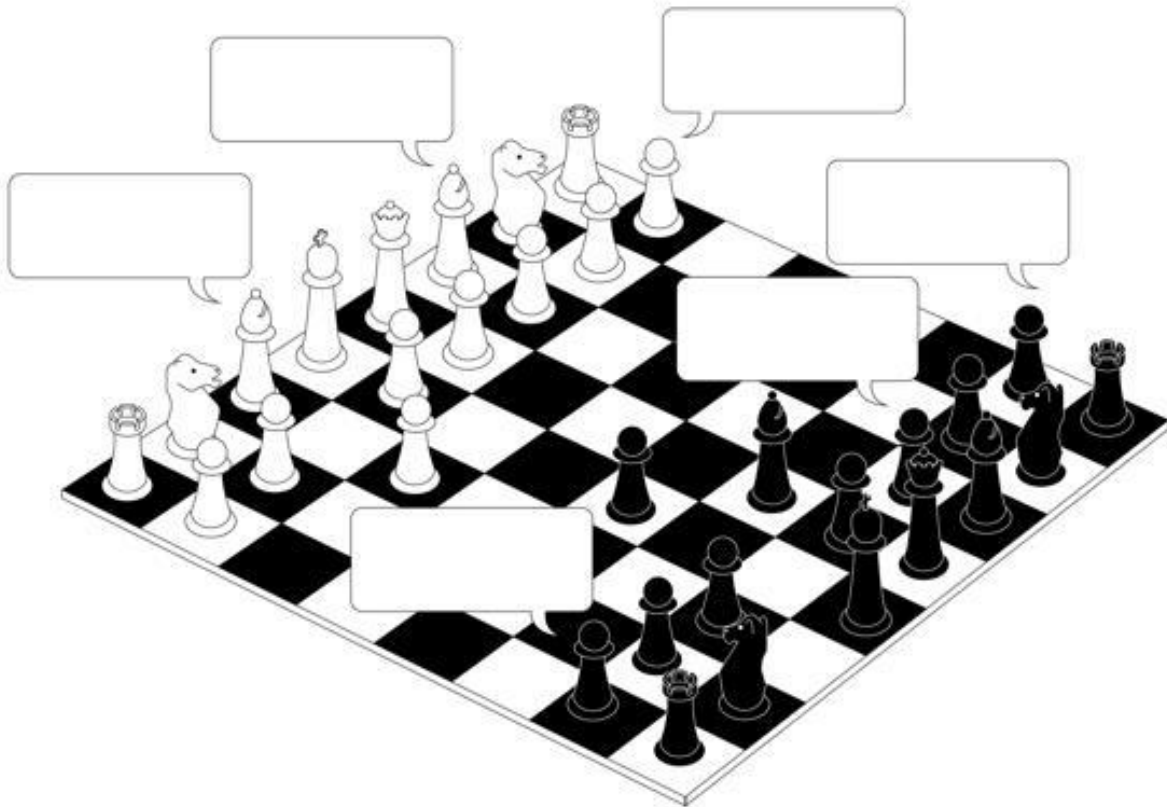
In ACT, the chessboard metaphor is often used to help people understand the relationship between their thoughts and feelings, and can support people to get in touch with the role of the observer.

Imagine your thoughts and feelings were represented by the figures of a chessboard. On one side, you have all the positive thoughts and feelings (the white pieces), and on the other side, you have all the negative ones (the black pieces). There is a constant game of chess between these two sides. The positive thoughts and feelings are moving forward to win against the negative ones. As soon as you put forth the tower representing the thought *“I can do this!”*, the opposing tower responds with: *“No you can’t, remember that last time when you messed up?”* There are an infinite number of pieces on both sides. As soon as one game is “won” by one side, another begins. The battle is never over. Plus, the positive pieces actually attract the negative ones. For every piece that supports you in living a value-based life (*“I can become free of worries and addictions”*), there is an opposing piece that will somehow attempt to hinder you (*“No you can’t, every time you try, you fail”*). We will speak more about living a value-based life in the next chapter.

What if we could learn to be like the chess board? It is in intimate contact with the pieces, but is not involved in the game or even the potential battle. What if we could learn to simply observe the game of positive and negative thoughts and feelings? What if we could observe how they move and are battling each other, while not getting completely lost and identified with either side, or even wanting to win? The chess board simply holds the space for the game to happen. It doesn't have a preference for either side. It just is.

In this tool, we invite you to fill in the chessboard below. The white pieces are your positive thoughts and feelings. The black ones are your negative ones. Imagine the game of chess between these two sides. What primary thoughts and feelings are battling each other? Fill in the speaking bubbles with the positive and negative thoughts and feelings you are currently

struggling with most. You can also write a note in your ebook device, or on a separate piece of paper. Write a list of three positive thoughts and feelings and three negative thoughts and feelings.



What are some things the white pieces are saying/thinking/feeling?

How are the black pieces responding?

Now imagine, how does the chessboard feel about all of this?

What is the role of the chessboard in all of this?

What are you learning from this tool?

4.2 You as the Scientist

Here is another metaphor aiming to describe how you can experience yourself as Self-as-context, as the observer, so to say. Say you started to connect more with the scientist, the researcher in you. Say you were a scientist, or better, a biologist studying different species in the depths of the Amazonian jungle. Every day, you go out into the jungle to explore different kinds of snakes, frogs, birds, bugs, all different kinds of animals and plants. We know there are still millions of plant and animal species to be found, so every day it is your job to go find and classify these new species. You know in your lifetime full of work, you might classify a few hundred or even a couple of thousand new species, but this task will never end, as the plant and animal kingdom is always evolving and changing.

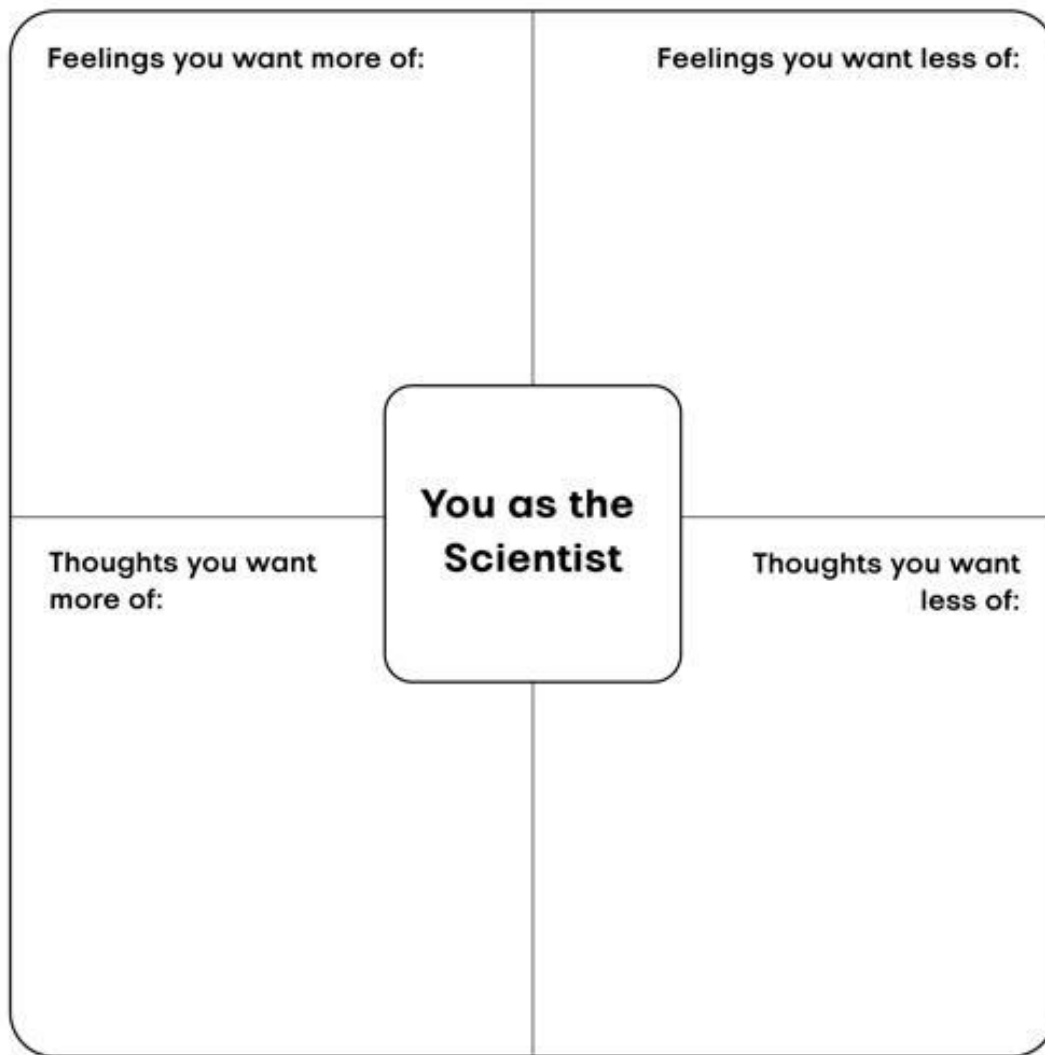
What if you approached your personal healing journey in the same way as this scientist? Every day, you go out to explore the jungle (life) for different animals (thoughts) and plants (feelings). Some days you might find new animals and plants, other days you will encounter some that you already know. For sure, you have your preferences for certain plants and animals, and might be happy as you run into exciting new species like a frog that looks like chocolate or a rainbow-colored fish. Other days might not be so exciting, as you run into animals and plants you have seen a million times and don't find very exciting.

The point is, you are a scientist. You are the one that is observing and seeing all the different species of animals (thoughts) and plants (feelings). As a scientist you remain objective, not personally involved, and do the necessary reporting of all the things you observe every day without getting pulled into what you see. While you might notice how you prefer some species over others, this does not play a role for your work. Your personal preferences and moods do not contribute to your work.

Use this metaphor in the tool as you attempt to connect deeper with your thoughts and feelings while remaining in the role of the observer. In the

diagram below, each quadrant represents either thoughts or feelings that you are wanting more or less off. See the labeling along the axes to know which one is which. In the center is “You as the Scientist” (the observer or Self-as-context) from the metaphor above.

Fill in each of the quadrants with the respective feelings and thoughts you would like more or less off.



Now look at what you wrote in each quadrant. Step back into the role of the scientist and with the objectivity of a scientist look at what you wrote.

What do you notice?

What insights do you take away from this practice?

4.3 Self-As-Content

Imagine if you would completely see yourself identified with all of the ideas that you have about yourself. Instead of seeing the Self-as-context, you see the Self-as-content. For someone who is suffering from any psychological illness, the Self is often completely identified with the content. For example, for someone who is depressed it's hard, if not impossible, to see and experience anything but the symptoms of the depression. The same goes for someone addicted to any substance. The stronger the identification with certain beliefs, habits, and patterns, the stronger the attachment to these concepts. We could argue that attachment to certain concepts is good. For example, it is good to be attached to feeling good. Or it is good to be attached to being healthy or having friends. And of course, it is “better” to be attached to the thought “I want to be healthy” vs. the thought “I want to drink alcohol every day”. We will explore this more in a later tool.

For this tool, let's do a practice in which we take the identification with the conceptualized self to the extreme.

Imagine you were completely identified with everything you thought, believed, and felt. Please only do this practice if you currently feel emotionally and mentally stable, or with supervision.

To begin, write down all the things you think, believe, and feel about yourself.

I think... _____

I think... _____

I think... _____

I believe... _____

I believe... _____

I believe... _____

I feel... _____

I feel... _____

I feel... _____

Now, imagine all the things you thought, believed, and felt about yourself were completely true. Imagine that what you think, believe, and feel is 100% true. Imagine that they would always be true. Imagine that they would be true for the rest of your life.

How do you feel when imagining this?

How would you end up, if this really was true?

Can you see that you do not fully believe in all the thoughts, beliefs, or feelings?

4.4 Who Would You Be?

Self-conceptualizations are statements that your mind makes about you that you practically take as truth about yourself. These kinds of statements decrease psychological flexibility and increase psychological rigidity. Here is another tool to better help you see and understand the conceptualized thinking that you have of yourself. The brilliant founder of ACT therapy, Steven Hayes has a similar tool in his book “Get Out of Your Mind and Into Your Life”.³² Fill in each of the statements with whatever responses come to mind. Feel free to give multiple responses.

I am someone who is:

I am someone who is not:

I like:

I do not like:

In others I like:

In others I do not like:

Something I struggle with:

Now take one of your negative responses and focus on this. Imagine that a beautiful fairy could come with a magic wand and be able to make this statement, this belief, or idea disappear forever. You probably do not believe in magical fairies, but for the purpose of this tool, why not just pretend that they do exist? So the fairy comes and releases you of the idea “that you are bad at sports” for example, or that “you are shy and reserved when meeting new people”. All of a sudden, you can practice and are good at any sport. Or maybe you completely lose any sense of shyness and reservation when meeting new people. If this could truly happen (just believe it for a second), who would you prove wrong by the disappearance of these ideas? Who would be shown to be incorrect?

This may take a moment to sink in. But most likely a part of you will come to the conclusion that you are somehow invested in the labels, stories, and beliefs you have about yourself. Even if you hate the label “shy” or “reserved”, something in you is invested in keeping this label. You might think back to the defusion tool secondary gains (2.5). This is a similar

approach. The only thing that is invested is the mind, which is conditioned through genes and experiences. You see how the mind is somehow invested in keeping things rigidly the same, even if you are suffering terribly at the moment.

Any identification we have and choose to have, consciously or unconsciously, sets us up to start seeing the world in a distorted way. It sets us up to see the world around as we would like it to be.

Anytime you say “*I am a shy*” or “*anxious person*”, or “*I am bad at sports*”, you aren’t telling the whole truth. No matter if what you say is positive or negative, surely there have been and there will be times in your life where what you say is not entirely true.

4.5 The Silent Observer

As mentioned in the intro, it is hard to mentally describe Self-as-context. You just have to experience it. So why not try a little meditation that might allow you to experience yourself as the silent observer?

See if you can find someone that is willing to guide and read this meditation for you:

Find a place where you can comfortably sit and will be undisturbed for the next 5 - 7 minutes. You are welcome to sit on a chair or on the floor using several cushions. The spine is straight, you can bring your shoulder slightly up and back, opening the chest, and feeling a sense of firmness and relaxation at the same time.

Take a deep breath through the nose, filling your lungs and chest with air. Exhale deeply through the mouth. Try to let go of tensions, expectations, and worries.

Now take a moment to turn your attention inside. What’s alive at this moment? Do you notice any sensations, like discomfort in your body posture? Or maybe you notice a sense of relaxation and how good it feels to sit for a moment? (few seconds pause)

Or maybe you are noticing activity at the level of the mind. Are there any thoughts, ideas, or memories? Any expectations? (few seconds pause)

What about emotions? Are you currently experiencing any emotions? (few seconds pause)

Just notice all the things and phenomena that are currently going on in your being. You might even begin to notice how you're getting a bit disturbed or restless by noticing all of these different things that are going on in your being. In case you do, don't worry. It is normal to notice more of these things as we sit quietly to meditate. Allow yourself to notice these things and allow them to just be. You might even notice that certain sensations you had a minute ago are already gone. Or how initial emotions, such as anticipation, have already passed. (few seconds pause)

So you might have noticed that there are quite a lot of things happening. You might have also noticed that you feel certain ways about what is happening. You might like what is happening, or you might not. And while all of these things are happening, somehow, something is noticing them. Thoughts like "What's the point of this", sensations like "The body is uncomfortable", or emotions like being annoyed or frustrated. Or maybe some other experiences that are completely different. Something is noticing all of these things. (few seconds pause)

So how is it that something or someone is seeing and witnessing all these things? How come there can be a perception of the many things happening at the same time? What is it, that is watching and observing all that is happening?

Ponder this one for a little bit. (few seconds pause)

You might have noticed that as you started to ponder on what is watching, that somehow the identification with the thoughts, sensations, and feelings may have lessened. You may have even found yourself in some moments of a quiet and spacious space, a feeling of void. While this is not the space from which the observations are made (as this cannot be physically located), it does give us a bit more of a connection with this silent observer. You are invited to rest in this observer role for a few more seconds before you slowly and gently begin to end the short meditation. (few seconds pause)

Take your time, and if possible, try not to rush off right away. Rest in the echoes of the meditation for a bit.

See if you can connect with the silent observer more often from now on.

How was this meditation for you?

What insights did you have during this meditation?

4.6 Therapy vs. Mysticism

So what if you would continue with the meditation from tool 4.5? Or, if you have meditation experience, you might not have needed the last tool. If you stay in the role of the silent observer for a sustained time period, you might have what some would call a mystical experience. Most of us, though, quickly get pulled out of this observing state by our thoughts, sensations, or emotions. Then, depending on if we like them or don't like them, we are likely to get identified, and there goes the mind off on 10 tangents only to come back when the silent observer tells it to. With practice, you can get better at this. For ACT, it is not necessary to have the mystical experiences or even remain a silent observer for very long. Ideally you can learn to go there, but as mentioned in the introduction, it is not absolutely necessary. If you do feel inclined to go explore this path, according to the Yogis (and personal experiences) there is definitely a lasting purification and detachment from the mind, body, and emotions that can happen only through meditation.

Mystical experience present or not, many of us have had such an experience in our lives. We may not have identified it as such. Any moment in our lives that completely baffled us, literally took our breaths away, or stopped everything around and inside of us for some moments, can resemble such mystical experience. How so? Because in those moments the mind stops. There is so much fascination in seeing a magnificent sunset or the birth of one of our children, that everything else just disappears for some moments. These moments usually do not last long, and the mind quickly kicks back in and then tries to explain the experience. Remember, that is its job.

So this tool is simple: Try to travel back through your life and see if you have ever had any kind of mystical, out-of-this world experience where everything around you seemed to have stopped.

What comes to mind?

This might take some time, but remember back to when you were a child. Were there moments of special connection with yourself or with nature? If we experienced these moments very young, they might have also scared us.

Or think about your last vacation, like that amazing sunset that took away your words, or when a moment of appreciation you had for yourself or someone around you overcame you.

All of these kinds of experiences that stop the thinking mind from going about business as usual can give us a sneak peek of experiencing the silent observer. Sometimes the moments of deeper connections may also be in dangerous, painful, or even traumatic memories. An example would be a near-death-experience. Just make sure to reach out for support if something comes up during these tools that is somehow still troubling you.

4.7 The Story of Your Suffering

Here is another tool to help bring more clarity to your conceptualized self. Remember that this is the sense of self that carries all the thoughts, ideas, and beliefs about yourself. When you tell your story to someone, this is usually what you would tell them, though maybe in a somewhat filtered way. If you have never done such a practice, make sure you do it under guidance, especially if you are currently struggling with depression or have experienced trauma. Please write the story of your suffering. For this tool it may be easier to write your story on paper. Forget that you have ever read any pages of this book, and write down your main problems, including the historical, situational, and personal reasons for these problems in your life. Try not to use any kind of filter.

Use the following questions as guidance:

- What brought you to the point where you are today?
- What are you struggling with? What are your symptoms?
- What is going on inside of you?
- What do you think and experience day by day?

You can be real in this, even a bit dramatic, if it feels right.

Now go back through your story, and underline all facts. All the things that happened exactly in this way and could have been captured on a video camera. Do not underline any statements that could not have been recorded by a video camera. This might be tricky as some of the memories that led you to where you are today are old, from childhood, and could be a bit blurry. The brain, especially up until a certain age, is especially susceptible to fake memories.³³ If we do not remember exactly what happened, the brain might follow the tendency to fill in the blank. It may become hard to determine what was real and what was not real. This is not to undermine any of your experiences and memories. Often we just don't really know or remember. To the mind it doesn't really matter, as even the perceived memory of a traumatic event in our childhood can have a long-lasting negative impact for our entire lives. Still, for the purpose of this practice, only underline the facts you know 100% are true.

Now here comes the even more challenging part of this practice:

Take all the facts you have underlined, and write another story only using these facts and creating a different ending or adding other little details to the story here or there. This isn't a promise, prediction, or evaluation, it is just an exercise. See if you can take the actual facts from your personal story of suffering, and create another story from this. If you do not feel ready for this second part of the exercise at this time, that is OK. Mark it and come back to it when you feel ready.

Now compare the two stories that you wrote. Simply observe them from a space of the observing self. How does it feel when you look at either one of

the stories?

4.8 What I Have Always Wanted

Here is another tool to build upon the idea of the last one. It is not necessary to do tool 4.7 to do this tool, though of course it can be helpful. If you did do tool 4.7, you might also want to reflect again on how the two stories about your life and your suffering changed. What was the outcome of the first story, and what was the outcome of the second?

These kinds of practices are not to play down or in any way ridicule what happened to you. The things that brought suffering to you are hard, unfair, and maybe even traumatic. It is rarer for people coming from a secure, safe childhood in which they were cared for and deeply loved to battle with psychological illnesses. No matter the experiences, the suffering is real and these practices are in no way meant to downplay this.

So for this tool, your task will be to write the story of how you would have dreamed it, if it had been up to you.

Just take the time and write yourself the perfect life story. How did you wish your childhood would have been? How do you wish you would have grown up? What do you wish your family would have been like? Mention any hobbies you would have liked to practice, or even what pets you would have liked to have. Feel free to go all out and be creative. The only catch is to remember to write in a way that describes your life as if it really happened this way. So you would write something along the lines of *“I grew up on a big farm in the middle of nowhere with hundreds of animals...”*.

How did this practice make you feel? Did it create any positive feelings or emotions?

You know the second story wasn't "real", and still it might have made you feel a certain way. That's what concepts do, especially those that are desirable to us. No matter the story, concept, or idea we have about ourselves, our life, our past, our future, all of these concepts are somehow limiting our psychological flexibility and are likely to lead to some form of mental, emotional, or physical suffering at some point in our lives. So the point of this practice is simple, yet also very difficult: whenever you notice you are creating and have created concepts about yourself and others, try to let them go as often as you can. The more we can free ourselves of any kind of concepts (of ourselves, others, the world), the less suffering we are likely to experience.

4.9 Self as Process of Ongoing Self-Awareness

When we have knowledge of our own experiences in the present moment, like "Now I am thinking this" or "Now I am remembering this" or "Now I am feeling this", this is the process of the conceptualized self being in a process of self-awareness. This can last a few seconds, minutes, or ideally is constantly running in the background. Evidence suggests that this sense of self is important for healthy psychological functioning.³¹ Anyone who cannot experience or grasp what they are experiencing emotionally, mentally, and physically is likely to be completely taken by the experience, or on the other hand not experience much at all. The stronger the attachment to the conceptualized self, the more difficult this ongoing process of self-awareness might be.

This is a very short practice on ongoing self-awareness.

If you did some of the previous exercises, look back for inspiration. If not, think about 3 concepts you have about yourself that you feel are very predominant. These can be "positive" or "negative" self-concepts. Choose something that has been present for a while. Maybe something others can observe in you, or something that others have often mentioned to you. Here are a few examples as orientation:

Usually perceived positive: *"You are so smart", "You're so kind", "You couldn't hurt a fly"*

Usually perceived as negative: “*You are lazy*”, “*You don’t try hard*”, “*You drink/eat too much*”

Write them here:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Now write the implications that each one of these could (and maybe does have) on your life, your relationships, your self-confidence, self-love, the raising of your kids, overall happiness, anything that comes to mind.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

How did you feel completing this tool? Did you have any insights or “aha moments”? As always, do this tool with support if you feel you may need it.

4.10 The Sense Of “I”

From a developmental perspective, we are not born with a sense of “I”. This sense develops in early childhood, after infantile amnesia (not remembering much before the age of 3) falls away. Go back to your earliest childhood memory. Remember to the best of your ability. After the sense of “I” is developed, it brings a reference point and also begins a lifelong process of creating separation between “me” and “you”.

Go back in your memory to your early childhood. Think of this memory. It can be either a happy or painful memory. Relive this memory for a few moments. Then see if you can connect with the sense of Self, this sense of “I” that was looking out at the world from behind your eyes back when you

were a child. Write down the answers to each of the questions that follow. If you are struggling to find words, just write what comes to mind.

Who was it that saw the events of this memory?

Who will be looking out from behind your eyes in 5, 10, or 20 years as you grow old and gray?

This “I” always remains the same. This “I” is our observing self.³⁴ Or, according to eastern philosophy, this sense of self is “everything” and “nothing”.

4.11 Who Am I?

There is a famous Indian sage named Ramana Maharshi who founded “the most sacred of sacred” method to inquire into the Self. While most forms of meditation use an object like the breath or the heart to focus on, Ramana Maharshi suggests turning the attention exactly toward that which is looking through the question “Who am I?”. This might not make sense right away, but let’s explore this a bit further. When you ask yourself the question “Who am I?”, it is likely that several answers immediately arise: I am John, 30 years old, I am an engineer, or whatever you name, age, profession, place of birth, parents, siblings, and all these things that we take ourselves to be.

Ramana Maharshi suggests that since this method is meant to point back at who we really are, there are no answers that the mind can potentially provide to answer the question “Who am I?”. So he suggests that we should let the answers of the mind arise, while knowing and remembering that we are none of these. Then, if the mind continues to produce “answers”, he suggests that we should ask back “Yes, but to whom do these thoughts arise?”. Likely the answer will be “Well, to me...” or “I...”. And then we return to ask the question “Who am I?”.³⁵

This process is to be done again and again and again. Every day, as much as possible, especially in difficult moments. The invitation is to ask this question in wonderment, and not go into the stories and answers of the mind. There isn't and there never will be a rational answer to this question. You persist in asking the question with the same attitude with which you would ask the question "Do you exist?" There is no doubt about your existence. With this same persistence you are invited to ask the question "Who am I?" and follow it with the conviction that these questions will lead you back to the true "I", your sense of Self (with a capitalized S).

This is getting pretty spiritual. But it might be something to explore if you are interested in these kinds of things and want to find a permanent way to live in harmony with the ever-changing nature of thoughts, emotions, and sensations.

So let's just try this for a few minutes.

Again, finding yourself a comfortable and safe space. (few seconds pause)

Closing your eyes. Relaxing as much as you can. Allowing yourself to fully breathe in and out through the nose. (few seconds pause)

Relaxing even more, letting thoughts, emotions, and feelings be there. Everything is allowed, everything is OK, everything can be embraced. (few seconds pause)

Then you just start to ask yourself the question "Who am I" from time to time. Try to ask the question in real wonderment, with curiosity, and let it arise naturally. (few seconds pause)

Who am I? (30 - 60 seconds pause)

Again, who am I? (30 - 60 seconds pause)

Who am I truly? (longer pause pause)

Then rest in the echoes of the question. When the mind produces answers, try not to go into these ideas and stories but rather ask, "To whom do these thoughts arise?" and "Who is this I?". (60 seconds pause)

Continue this for at least 5 minutes, longer if you like. Before you stop the practice, rest for some moments in the echoes of this short meditation.

How was this meditation for you?

What did you discover?

4.12 Vairagya or Detachment

From a Yogic perspective, all attachments to ideas and concepts should be let go, as sooner or later they all bring suffering. The Sanskrit term Vairagya is describing exactly this: letting go of the constant search for likes and dislikes, and in this way reducing suffering. This does not come naturally or intuitively for most people living in the modern world. Early on, we are taught certain things are good, and other things are bad. The things that are good, we should do more of, and the things that are bad, we should do less of.

Still, why not take some time to reflect on your strongest attachments? Attachments can be to certain thoughts, ideas, and patterns. They can be attached to emotions, hobbies, sensations, or people. Anything that we feel we couldn't live without is an attachment that is worth looking at, especially if it has negative consequences on our mental, emotional, and physical health.

Things I can't be without	Ideas I cannot give up	Things I have to do to feel complete	Ways I need to feel like myself	People I could never be without

Try to answer these as honestly as possible. Add new columns and categories if there is something that you regularly do or need that doesn't seem to fit into any present category.

This book and tool is not here to tell you what to do or not to do. The purpose of this book is to help you live a healthier, more purposeful life, free from psychological illnesses. If you are suffering from a psychological illness at the moment, do remember that it is the *conceptualized you* that is suffering. And that it is the ongoing observing you and you as the Observer that can free yourself from this suffering. The conceptualized you will not want to see or even admit to patterns of attachments. So if there is a lot of resistance coming as a response to doing this practice, ask yourself where this resistance is coming from.

What insights did this practice bring?

4.13 Stable Sense of Self

If it is not necessary to make the Self-as-context explicit in order to successfully treat psychological illnesses such as addiction, depression, anxiety, or eating disorders, then why spend an entire chapter and many tools explaining it, you may ask.

Good question! As mentioned, it is not necessary, but it does support the following other aspects:³¹

1. Supports defusion (changing our relationship with thoughts, ideas, patterns, emotions, or sensations)

2. Supports acceptance (of all arising phenomena)
3. Supports flexible contact with the present moment (enabling you to choose when you want to be in contact with the present moment, and when to “come back”)
4. Accesses a stable sense of self
5. Accesses a transcendent sense of self

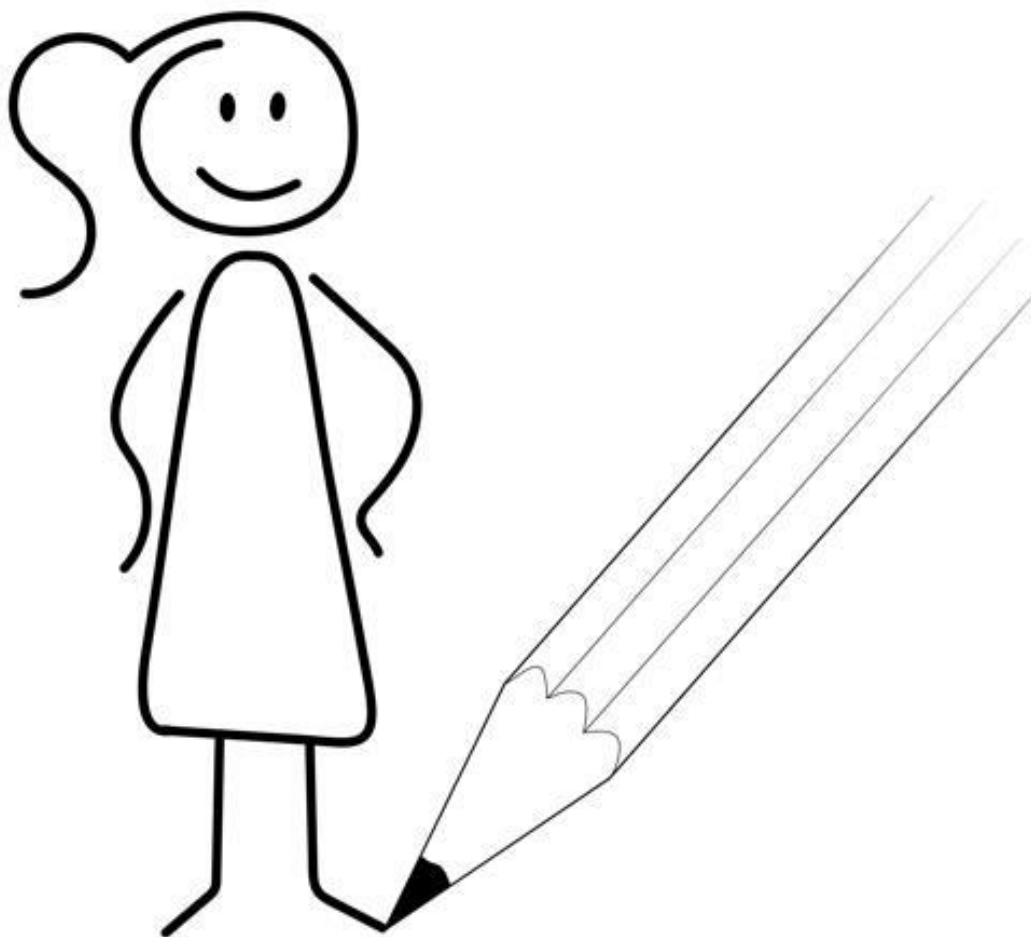
So for 4 and 5, you may ask why? Again, good question. For #5, I can tell you from personal experience that being able to access a transcendent sense of self opens your world to new and inexplicable ways of being and healing. But it's also completely fine if you are not interested in this.

For this tool, let's focus on #4: accessing a stable sense of self. Why should that have any relevance?

Well, imagine that certain conditions in your life currently do not allow you to have a stable sense of self. What if you just lost a dear family member? Or you lost your job because of the economic situation, or your family home in a flood? Or maybe you just separated from your partner of 15 years, just to name a few examples. The world around you seems to be crumbling. There is little to no stability. For people with existing or preexisting psychological conditions, a loss in the felt external stability could be a tipping point back into, or even worsen the psychological condition. Can you see how a stable sense of self could be supportive here?

Let's look at your sense of self and how much it depends on external aspects that are currently present, but do not always have to be present.

Here you are invited to get a little bit creative. Draw yourself in a very simple, stick figure way. See the example below. Of course we are not addressing every person or gender with this image.



Then start to draw some lines around your figure. Add about 5 - 10 lines.
Now write 5 - 10 things that you know you could not do or be without onto those lines.

Now look at your drawing: What makes you **you** and what makes you feel a stable sense of you?

Now begin to start crossing out one stable aspect after another. You do not have to cross out all of the aspects if you do not feel ready for this. Only go as far as what feels good, and makes you feel sufficiently supported. But try to cross out about 5 things.

Now look at the drawing again, and at the 5 remaining aspects that make you feel a certain stable sense of self. How do you feel looking at the drawing now?

Did you notice that you were selecting certain kinds of aspects, by the ones you could easily live without?

What would happen if you needed to cross out 3 more items?

Or all 5? How would you feel?

Can you feel a sense of stable connection with the Self, even when these external conditions, that ultimately have nothing to do with this stable sense of self, break away?

This might be a tough practice, so take it easy and remain in the role of the Observer to the best of your ability.

4.14 Heart Meditation

For some spiritual traditions, the way to connect with this sense of “I” is actually through the heart. Have you ever noticed that when you are referring to yourself speaking of “I”, or wondering if someone is meaning to address you, you are likely to point with your right hand towards the

chest, right by your heart. So let's see if a short heart meditation can open up the space for a connection with this sense of "I" or the "Observer".

See if you can find someone that is willing to guide and read this meditation for you.

Find a place where you can comfortably sit and will be undisturbed for the next 8-10 minutes. You are welcome to sit on a chair or on the floor using several cushions. The spine is straight, you can bring your shoulder slightly up and back, opening the chest, and feeling a sense of firmness and relaxation at the same time. (few seconds pause)

Take a deep breath through the nose, filling your lungs and chest with air. Exhale deeply through the mouth. Try to let go of tensions, expectations, and worries. (few seconds pause)

Again, take the time to really look inside to see what it is that you are currently experiencing. See what is going on at the level of the mind, the emotions, and the body. If you like, you can mentally name the different phenomena without actually speaking but saying them quietly to yourself. The moment you say what you are observing and are naming it, let go. (several seconds pause)

Then, when you feel there is more quietness beginning to arise from within, bring your attention into the space of the chest. It is like you are inviting your mind to drop to the level of the heart. Just bring your attention there and rest there for some moments. (several seconds pause)

You might perceive a sense of intimacy, a deeper connection with yourself. Maybe even a sense of coming back home. Just experience and witness any sensations, thoughts, or emotions. If you get distracted, simply come back to the space of the heart. Take as much time as you need. (several seconds pause)

It is like there is nothing but you and your heart. Become very intimate with this space of the heart. (several seconds pause)

What do you feel? Answer only to yourself, and the moment you answer, let the answer go. (several seconds pause)

What do you perceive? Answer only to yourself, and the moment you answer, let the answer go. (several seconds pause)

Remain there for a few minutes, simply marinating in any warm, welcoming sensations or emotions. If you feel nothing at all, that is also very beautiful, just remain in the space of the heart. If you feel some kind of pain or stinging, send some warm and light energy into that which is painful. (several seconds pause)

Often we are not used to bringing our energy here, so the sensations and experiences we might have range from feeling nothing at all, to feeling so full we might begin crying, or even potentially also perceive pain.

Then, after a few more minutes, simply rest in the echoes of these words and the meditation.

Just be present and observe. (several seconds pause)

What did you feel when connecting with the space of the heart?

Did you experience a state of more mental quietness than usual?

Did you have any images or insights when connecting with this space?

4.15 The Prince and the Beggar

Let us end this section on Self-as-context with one more metaphor or better story describing this underlying sense of “I”, that stable part of our being that doesn't change, no matter the circumstances. This story of “The Prince and the Beggar” is commonly used in ACT therapy.

Imagine a beggar and a prince: Both are living completely different lives, one a life of riches and surplus, the other a life of poverty and starvation. Imagine that these two, looking identical from a physical standpoint, simply swapped their clothes for one day and lived the life of the other. The beggar

puts on the expensive robe of the prince and is all of a sudden in the hands of many servants. The prince puts on the beggar's rags and gets shooed away in the streets. The richly dressed, luxuriously treated beggar is immensely grateful and shares his food and belongings with other beggars. The prince begins to steal from others, and turns his nose up at other beggars. He avoids them at all costs. They may have swapped clothes for a day, but on the inside they are still the same. Behind both of their conceptualized selves of this is how they are, there might or might not be an ongoing process of self-awareness. Both, when asked to connect with this deeper sense of “I”, the observer, Self-as-context, pure awareness, or whatever you want to call it through means of meditation, self-contemplation, different forms of self-inquiry, are likely to come to the same conclusion of somehow sensing there is a deeper, more profound sense of “I”, one that observes it all.

What does this story personally mean to you?

How can it explain the ACT process, Self-as-context?

What messages about this story would you be inspired to share with your children or your grandchildren?

5. ACT TOOLS FOR VALUES

We are now moving onto another crucial step in ACT therapy: values. Values are kind of like our inner compass. Following them is what makes life important and meaningful for us. Everyone engages in behaviors and patterns that more or less support them in living a valuable, meaningful life. It is like we set course on something bigger, like following the direction “west”. For most of our lives, we directly or indirectly follow this course, with some corrections along the way. Some corrections are pretty small and unnoticeable, other corrections or roadblocks are pretty major (like struggling with a psychological illness).

We don’t necessarily need to run into a roadblock to have difficulties with following our values. Following our values is at times just difficult because it's not always exciting. There are often no immediate results, and it might not make you happy or feel good right away. But following certain values throughout the course of your life can bring a sense of purpose. This is much more subtle and takes quite some time though. Sometimes it just seems easier to drink a few glasses of wine with your friends on a Friday night, even though you really strive to follow the value of “living healthy”. Following this value is just not as attractive as a fun night out with friends after a busy week. This is not to imply that there is something wrong with having a fun night out, or that alcohol on a Friday is a bad thing. But doing this regularly, making it into a habit, potentially even developing a slight dependency on the substance over time, is likely to be in conflict with the underlying value.

In this chapter, we will present a series of tools to help you, clients or patients, gain clarity over living a life according to their values.

5.1 Getting Started

In ACT, we use the term values for things that give our lives meaning. Values are not goals. We never achieve or accomplish our values. Instead, values lead us like an internal compass. They help us make wise choices in life, based on the directions of where we want to go. A value-based life is a

life that is authored by *you*! Only you can decide what makes your life worth living and what is important to you. Often we simply lack the exposure to this topic. Maybe no one has ever asked us what our values are. It's surely not part of general school education, so it's no wonder we often don't know or persistently follow a value-based life.

If someone inquires about our values, we might even have difficulties or resistance answering these questions. It's like we believe that it doesn't really matter that we want our lives to be a certain way. We might believe life does with us as it pleases anyhow. And it does, to an extent. Still, we have more influence than we might think. Or we might feel we are not allowed to voice what values and aspirations we have. And even if the reflections about values were worth absolutely nothing, what do we have to lose, reflecting on what we would want our core driving values to be in life? So we will start to dive into this topic softly and explore it from many different sides. Hopefully this will create inspiration and more clarity for anyone reading this book.

Let's begin with some simple questions, helping us gently approach this topic:

What is important to you?

What do you want your life to be about?

How would you want your life to unfold?

Imagine if anything were possible, in what direction would you choose to go on this journey?

On a scale from 0 - 10 how much are your personal values currently determining the course of your life (0 = not at all, 10 = completely)?

5.2 Picking Core Values

Sometimes it is not so easy to actually name our values. We might have never consciously reflected on them, or we might not even know what's out there. Even if we know values like “honesty”, “kindness”, or “compassion”, we might struggle to really pick the ones that move us most. We might also have picked values that our parents or society told us to pick, only to discover decades later that those things aren't the most important to us.

So following here we will share a list of common values as they are also presented in the book ACT Made Simple, by the founder of ACT Therapy, Steven Hayes.³¹ Here, values are described as our heart's deepest desires for how we want to live and behave as human beings. They describe how you want to treat yourself, others, and the world around you. There are no “right” or “wrong” values. It's like choosing an ice cream flavor. You might prefer strawberry, while the person behind you is crazy about chocolate. We all have different things that drive and motivate us. This list does not include all values. There are lists you can find on the internet with over 200 values. If you do not find the values that resonate with you on this list, you can add them to the very bottom. What's relevant with values is that in different areas of life they might vary. So our values in intimate relationships might be different from the values we have in friendships. Work and family life might also greatly differ. For the purpose of this tool, we invite you to look at life as a whole, meaning choosing the values that drive you most strongly in general. Sometimes it can help to see things from a different perspective when making these kinds of decisions, and we could ask: What value could I not be or live without?

Here is how you can pick your values:

1. Go through the list and highlight each value in the following way: very important (V) = green, important (I) = yellow, not important (N) = red. If you don't have colored highlighters, just put the letter V, I or N behind each value.
2. List all values you marked green or with a V, separately below. Then begin to rank them from 0 (least important) to 10 (most important). You might need a few tries for this. You might also have some with the same number. That's ok. Write your top 5

values again on a separate list. How do you feel looking at your top 5 values?

3. Go through the values marked in green (V) again, and see if there is any crucial value missing. Also, quickly go through the values marked in yellow (I) to see if any values from this list should actually be on your top 5 list.
4. Keep this list for about a week. Look at it again and see if anything changes. Defining our values is work in progress and will undergo constant evolution. That is OK, but you might recognize underlying themes or how you keep coming back to certain values.

1. Accepting: open to, allowing of, or at peace with myself, others, life, my feelings, etc.
2. Adventurous: willing to create or pursue novel, risky, or exciting experiences
3. Assertive: respectfully standing up for my rights and asking for what I want
4. Authentic: being genuine, real, and true to myself
5. Caring/self-caring: actively taking care of myself, others, the environment, etc.
6. Compassionate/self-compassionate: responding kindly to myself or others in pain
7. Cooperative: willing to assist and work with others
8. Courageous: being brave or bold; persisting in the face of fear, threat, or risk
9. Creative: being imaginative, inventive, or innovative
10. Curious: being open-minded and interested; willing to explore and discover
11. Encouraging: supporting, inspiring, and rewarding behavior I approve of
12. Expressive: conveying my thoughts and feelings through what I say and do
13. Focused: focused on and engaged in what I am doing
14. Fair/just: acting with fairness and justice—toward myself and others
15. Flexible: willing and able to adjust and adapt to changing circumstances
16. Friendly: warm, open, caring, and agreeable toward others

17. Forgiving: letting go of resentments and grudges toward myself or others
18. Grateful: being appreciative for what I have received
19. Helpful: giving, helping, contributing, assisting, or sharing
20. Honest: being honest, truthful, and sincere—with myself and others
21. Independent: choosing for myself how I live and what I do
22. Industrious: being diligent, hardworking, dedicated
23. Kind: being considerate, helpful, or caring—to myself or others
24. Loving: showing love, affection, or great care—to myself or others
25. Mindful/present: fully present and engaging in whatever I'm doing
26. Open: revealing myself, letting people know my thoughts and feelings
27. Orderly: being neat and organized
28. Persistent/committed: willing to continue, despite problems or difficulties
29. Playful: being humorous, fun-loving, light-hearted
30. Protective: looking after the safety and security of myself or others
31. Respectful/self-respectful: treating myself or others with care and consideration
32. Responsible: being trustworthy, reliable, and accountable for my actions
33. Skillful: doing things well, utilizing my knowledge, experience, and training
34. Supportive: being helpful, encouraging, and available—to myself or others
35. Trustworthy: being loyal, honest, faithful, sincere, responsible, and reliable
36. Trusting: willing to believe in the honesty, sincerity, and reliability of others
37. _____: _____
38. _____: _____
39. _____: _____
40. _____: _____

What are the values you highlighted in green (important)?

Choose your top 5 values (note that these can change over time).

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

5.3 Values vs. Goals

People are often confused about the difference between values and goals. Many people formulate certain goals in life, to give themselves a sense of direction and purpose. Goals are helpful, needed, and are stepping stones towards a meaningful, value-based life. When the value, “honesty” becomes our life direction (like going west), then goals associated with this value can be “always speaking the truth”, “admitting when I don’t speak the truth”, “always correcting wrong-actions” or simply “always sharing in honesty how I feel about things”. Linking this back to our value of “going west”, the goals or stepping stones could be smaller towns or cities to the west of where we currently are, maybe even new countries.

We can see all these actions feeding our core value “honesty” more and more over time. The value is no longer just an abstract concept or wishful thinking, instead we live it through our everyday action. It is embodied, so to say. Others might even begin to recognize us for this specific value. So, without goals, it can become quite difficult to persistently follow our values. This is especially true when we are trying to live by new values, ones that we were maybe not taught or don’t naturally follow. Setting goals to move us toward this value is crucial.

So let’s look at formulating some goals, moving you towards your specific values. If you did not do tool 5.2, go back and do it now to determine your values. If you want to continue without, you need to have an idea about what your values are. Pick your top three values. This is for practice, and you can repeat this tool with any other values in the future.

What is your #1 value?

What are specific goals that can bring you closer to living this value? Think of habits, things you do, things you don’t do, ways you think and believe.

Try to be as specific as possible here.

What is your #2 value?

What are specific goals that can bring you closer to living this value? Think of habits, things you do, things you don't do, ways you think and believe. Try to be as specific as possible here.

What is your #3 value?

What are specific goals that can bring you closer to living this value? Think of habits, things you do, things you don't do, ways you think and believe. Try to be as specific as possible here.

What insights did this tool bring?

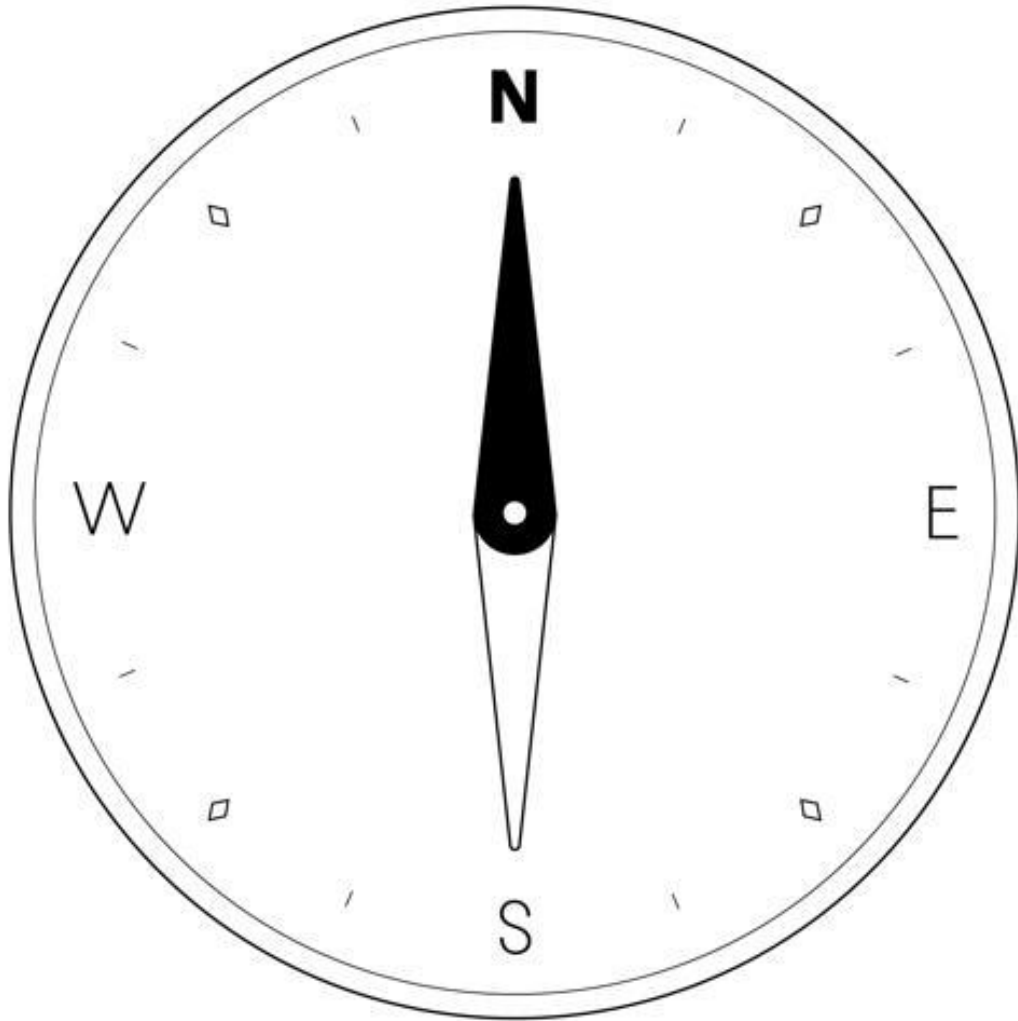
5.4 Your Inner Compass

Living by our values is like having an inner compass that orients and supports us, and shows us the way. It is so crucial to have certain values that make life worth living for us. Life is not easy. Life isn't always fair. Sometimes it does with us as it pleases. If we don't have that inner orientation, that inner compass that reminds us each and every day of the kind of person we want to be and the kind of life we want to live, things can get really tricky. If we have learned to experience ourselves as the observer (Self-as context of the ACT model), we might not struggle as much. But to most people it is not possible to just observe and witness painful events, emotions, or sensations without getting identified and taken by them.

In these cases, our values become our inner compass. Even if we find out our partner has been unfaithful for many years, living by the value of compassion can show us the way to being compassionate, even in moments of immense pain. Plus, it can show us the way forward. Someone struggling with depression who is simultaneously driven by the value “connection”, can attempt to reconnect with this inner driving force of connecting with others to support the healing. It's not that simple, of course, but knowing the values that drive us like an invisible, internal compass and that are in opposition to our psychological illness, can become a turning point and ongoing anchor.

This tool and practice is simple. Draw your personal value compass. Determine your magnetic north. In this case we mean the values, behaviors, actions, thoughts, and patterns that support you in following the direction of the kind of life you want to live. List them next to your compass.

My magnetic north is/are (my core value or values):



Interestingly, the magnetic north on a compass changes and shifts over time in response to the Earth's magnetic core. You should see your core values similarly. Yet the movement is slow and takes time.

5.5 Going West - Attuning Your Compass

In this tool, let's explore a metaphor for better understanding values and how to pursue them. Say you asked yourself what direction you want to go in. Often we don't know. But just by being asked, we feel like we have to know. So we might even create an answer without fully knowing. But when we are contemplating going north, south, east, or west, we might have an idea. Somehow an inner voice, coming from the gut, the heart, or showing up in our dreams, is telling us to "go west". And after some time, we decide "OK, great, let's go west". West becomes the direction, the value. West can and will never be achieved. Whatever we do, we continue to go west, at least as long as west is where we want to go. To continue going west, we might pick little spots along the way that are regionally to the west of us. We might pick one place that is very close, then another that is a few hundred kilometers away, and move on in this manner. All the stops along the way become different goals. We can achieve these goals, and setting them will support us in going west. To give a more practical example, someone struggling from alcohol addiction might have the values "purity", "health", or "fun". Purity, health, and fun become west. On the way toward these elements lie many little spots and checkpoints, such as: 1. One year of sobriety, 2. Learning to have fun without alcohol, 3. Finding new friends, 4. Learning to relieve emotional stress in a healthy way (just to name some examples). The list of goals will be endless, once one is complete another one can and should be defined to stay on track to go "west" and move towards "purity", "health", and a new form of "fun".

Apply this metaphor to your specific struggles. If you are struggling with a psychological illness, choose values that support the healing, but also notice which values you have and may have been following (like the value "fun") that may have actually contributed to your condition. What are 5 goals in logical order that can help you get out of your current situation?

Your Values:

Goal 1:

Goal 2:

Goal 3:

Goal 4:

Goal 5:

5.6 Your Values and the Values of Others

Some people don't like to connect with values, don't believe in values, or don't see the point. But if you find your life a little dry and lacking direction, it might be a good point and time to connect with your values. For anyone who has or is suffering from any psychological illness, a connection with our values can often bring the needed motivation, drive, and energy to begin or continue on the healing journey. For a new mother battling with postpartum depression, her value of love and connection can become a driving force in the recovery journey (even if strongly suppressed through the current psychological condition). Connecting deeply with our underlying values can really support the healing process. Of course, there needs to be the general openness and capacity to be able to go there at the time.

What's tricky with values is that sometimes we don't know whether the values we have are truly the values that motivate us, or if they are values that we might have picked up from our parents or our environment growing up. Here is a short tool that can help to discover whether the values that you have, which you may have picked in a previous tool, are really your values. Note that gaining clarity over whether certain values are really our values may take some time and reflection. So, as with all of these tools, we are starting an underlying reflection process that will bring more clarity down the road. Please answer the questions below:

What are your main values (name 3 -5)?

What values could you not do without?

What values somehow come with a sense of “should” or “need to”?

What are your parents' main values (name 3 -5 if you know them)?

Is there any similarity between your values and your parents' values?

What insights did you have during this practice? Did you notice any values that aren't your true values, that might have snuck in?

Now look at everything you wrote again. Read the words you wrote and at the same time try to connect with your heart and gut, your intuition so to say. What of which you wrote really feels true to the heart and gut?

5.7 Value Board

We continue to work with your personal values in this tool through a more creative approach. To complete this tool you will need some colored pens, pencils, highlighters, some white and some colored paper, and ideally some magazines or newspapers. Also you can print out images from Pinterest, social media, or google. Maybe you can even find an app that will help you create your vision board. If you do find an app, use it for the design only, and follow the questions below. If you have children, feel free to go all out and grab their glitter and stickers for this practice. We often stop “playing” as adults. Life becomes so serious, too serious. Adding a bit of humor,

lightness, and play to life can become a beautiful practice for yourself or for your family to ease up every day tensions.

In this tool, you are invited to create your own value board. Maybe you know this approach for another, similar topic - visions and creating a vision board.

1. Reflect on where you are currently concerning your personal values. This time you can make different categories (for example: relationship, work, sports, hobbies, travel, learning, money, sexuality and intimacy, gratitude, communication). Reflect on the values for each of the main categories and see where you feel life is somehow flowing and aligned, and where it is not.
2. Reflect on where you want to go in the future concerning your personal values. Tie this back to the things that are not going so well, not really aligned, and where you wish to create more flow, more naturalness, more alignment with your values.
3. Write these reflections and thoughts down.
4. Then begin going through the magazines and newspapers. Look for images, words, and letters that you can use for your value board. Your value board is an artwork of where *you* want to go in regard to your personal values.
5. Take a picture of your value board to always have it with you. You can even hang up your value board somewhere you can always see it.
6. Feel free to add to your value board later, if you feel there are things missing or as you encounter inspiring/fitting images.

5.8 Values vs. Needs or Desires, Virtues, or Morals

Without trying to get too technical and stuck on vocabulary, you or your clients might wonder and actually ask how values differ from the other things like needs, desires, virtues, or morals.

Remember, values describe how we want to act and behave, how we want to treat ourselves, others, and the world around us. Needs are things that we require on a regular basis to survive and thrive (like food or physical touch). To meet our needs, we might set goals for ourselves. When we meet a need, such as nourishing ourselves with food, our values will generally show in how we pursue our goals. Do we source, prepare, and eat our food with care, humbleness, and gratitude? Or are we eating in full pleasure, devouring the food with a sense of lust? Or is it something completely different? This is just an example. Goals show us what we want, actions are what we do to achieve our goals, and values are how we want to behave along the way.

Needs, wants, and desires such as love, respect, physical touch, and attention are all things we are trying to get from others. So while being respectful and attentive is a value, seeking attention and respect from others becomes a goal. There is nothing wrong with having the kinds of goals in which we seek things from others. In fact, we will explore more in the last chapter of this book, where we'll be speaking about committed action. We can desire and want a lot of things from others, but whether we receive these things is always outside of our control. So why not focus more on what we can control and how we behave along the way? Values also go beyond right, wrong, good, or bad. They are simply expressions of how we want to behave. This is where values are different from virtues, morals, and ethics.

The message from this tool is: What I expect from myself I can control, what I expect from others I cannot.

Please fill out the table below to gain a bit more insight about your personal values, goals, needs, wants, desires, morals, etc.

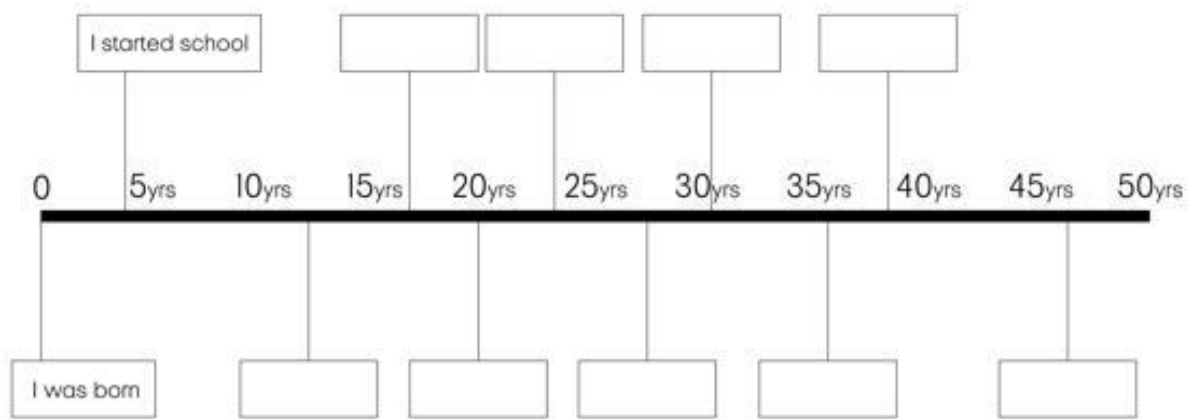
My Values Are:	My Goals Are:	My Needs, Desires & Wants Are:	My Virtues, Morals & Ethics Are:

If you are confused about what the difference between each of the different categories is, go back and read the text above the tool. Understanding the difference between our values, goals, needs, and desires can be very insightful.

5.9 Your Historical Value Map

As mentioned in 5.4 your magnetic north in regard to your values might shift over time. What you defined as a value when you were a child might be different today. You might have followed the value “reliability” because that is what you learned from your parents and your surroundings. Today, it might be more of a driving force for you to act in full authenticity rather than always being 100% reliable. It’s like when you were younger, whatever you committed to you stuck with, no matter what. Today you are still reliable, but have learned that sometimes it is an act of authenticity and self-love to cancel plans you have previously committed to. Or maybe both are strongly driving you today. Let’s take a look, in this tool, at how your personal values have developed over the course of your life.

Please draw your personal timeline like the sample image below:



Please draw one thick line across the middle. The x-axis should have 0 years on the left side, and your current age on the right side. Leave some space to the right of your current age to look ahead. Then begin filling in major life events. These are events that just happened (like being born, going to school, or even moving to a different country). Then add life events that were influenced by you (like going to college, picking your first boyfriend or girlfriend, applying for your first job). It is likely that the events that you influenced started to happen at a later age (usually after puberty). You can add positive events, but also events that were difficult for you or your family. Write what you remember and what would be part of “your story”.

Then go through your timeline again, and as you read the different events, see if you can identify certain values that were driving you around the time of these main events. For example: applying to college (value: growth), getting married (value: safety). For you this could be different of course. See if for every major event in your life you can identify the underlying value. Especially for those events that you choose, there is often an underlying value connected to these bigger historic events.

What are the main values that you identified when doing this practice?

How did your values change throughout your life?

Did you discover any surprises, like values you didn't even remember you had?

5.10 Your 80th Birthday Party

Probably the most well-known tool to support and guide in defining a valuable and worthy life for ourselves is imagining your 80th birthday. Other variations of these tools are a bit more extreme and work with your funeral. Use what feels most convincing and supportive to you or your client.

For this practice, you can invite yourself or your client to imagine it was your 80th birthday. The majority of your life is over, you have achieved and lived all the things you wanted to live. During this birthday party, 3 people will hold a speech in your honor.

1. Your long-term spouse or partner
2. A former boss
3. Your best friend

Each one of them will speak of you in the highest terms, full of gratitude, feeling honored to know and have walked this life with you. In their speeches, they mention all the things you ever aspired to achieve. They specifically mention your character, how you lived, what was important for you, how you treated yourself and others. They speak about your values. If you hear your mind going off about how this is not realistic or wouldn't happen, why not imagine that it could?

You sit there, listening to each one of them, your spouse, your former boss, and your best friend.

All of them have only the best words for you, your actions, and what you achieved.

Write below some of the things you hear each of the three say. You are invited to really imagine what these people, who know you from completely different circumstances and in completely different roles, would

say about how you acted. What would these people say your main values were?

1. Your long-term spouse or partner

2. A former boss

3. Your best friend

What new or interesting insights can you conclude from this tool?

5.11 Values in Different Areas of Life

If you did all of the other tools from this chapter, you probably have a pretty good idea of your values and what makes life meaningful for you. What we would like to look at some more, throughout these last tools, is understanding how your values differ in specific areas of life. Quite often, we have opposing values in two or more of our main areas of life. This leads to a dilemma, which we will address in a later tool. For now, let’s focus on getting a better understanding of the most common areas of life. Note that this might vary for you. If it does, please adjust this practice and the labeling accordingly!

Say your life had the main categories listed below. You can find two blank rectangles that you can label with a different category. Also, cross out any categories that do not apply.

Personal Growth	
Love / Romantic	
Family	

Work	
Fun & Hobbies	
Health	
Community / Environment	

Next to each category, write a few keywords about what is important or meaningful to you in this area of life. Use the questions below as guidance and answer them, especially for the categories that are relevant for you.

- What sort of person do you want to be?
- What sort of personal strengths and qualities do you want to cultivate?
- What do you want to stand for?
- How do you ideally want to behave?

Once you are done, fill in the boxes that are relevant for you. Mark each category title from 0 to 10 (0 = not important at all, 10 = very important). Write this number to the left of the category title.

Then look again at the values and how you are living and acting in each category. Mark each category from 0 to 10 (0 = not at all, 10 = completely). Write this number to the right of the category title.

Take a look at what you wrote, how you ranked the importance of each category, and how you feel you are currently living a value-based life in this category.

Where can you see a discrepancy between the importance of a category and a low ranking on actually living a value-driven life in this category?

Why? What can you do?

5.12 Value Dilemmas

The categories presented in 5.10 do not have to apply to everyone. Another common approach is just having 4 categories: Work/Education, Relationships, Play, and Health. Use whatever categorization works best for you or your client. As with everything, less is sometimes more. And even if we can build many different categories for the different areas of our lives, building more categories isn't always supportive. For many people, especially people on their way to healing from any psychological illness, the focus needs to be on exactly the category that will bring the strongest sense of support and direction, and that will support the person in mentally, emotionally, and physically feeling better. Everything else is nice to have. For many patients, this can mean focussing on health, and building or reactivating a strong support system of family and friends. Even if we just have a few categories, it is likely that the values in different categories might contradict each other. For example, wanting to always be present for our family and the needs of our jobs are likely to create a dilemma over time. Or, if we have to put on too many hats, and some of these hats aren't actually ours, they're borrowed.

Here is a step-by-step approach on how to resolve the value dilemma:

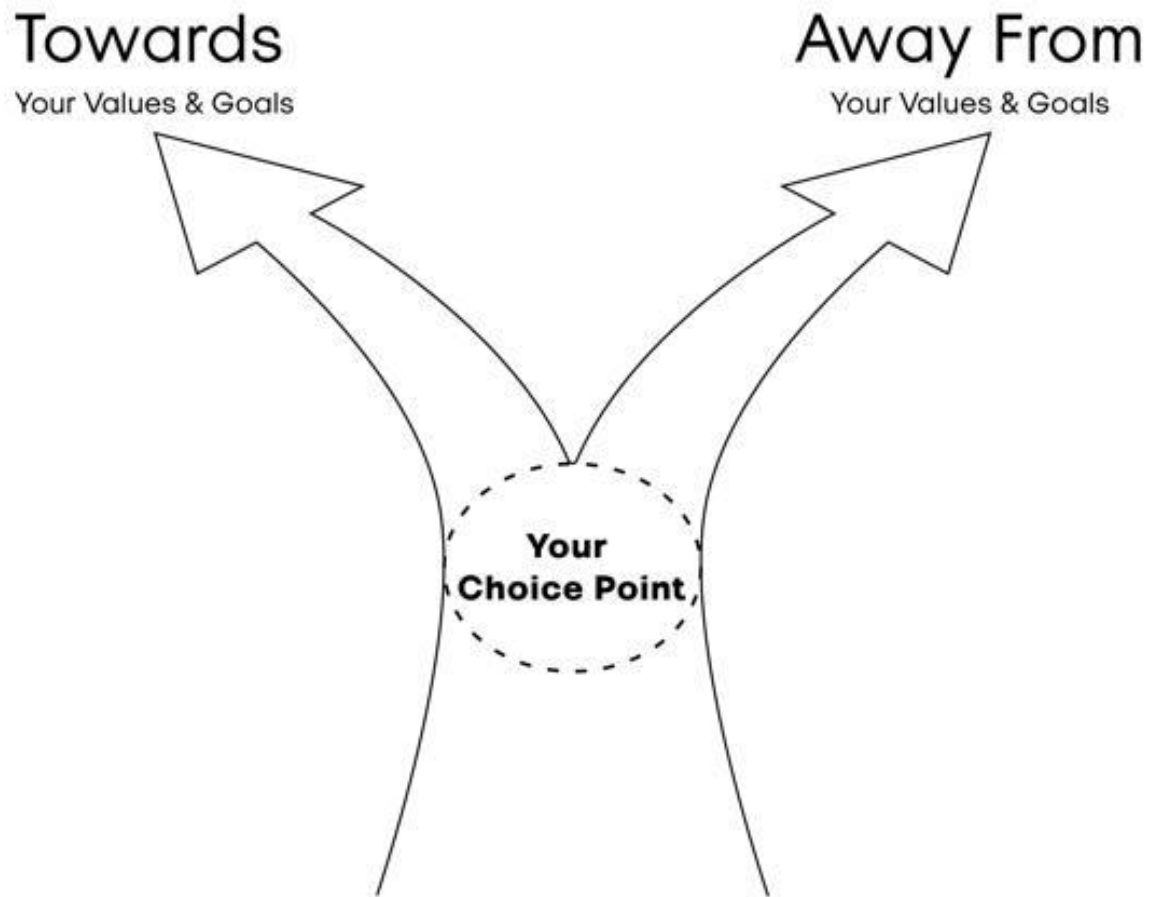
1. Find out the domains or areas of life where there are conflicting values.
2. Name the conflicting values and how they show up in everyday life.
3. Remember how these situations have conflicted in the past and how you felt in each situation.
4. Remember values are dynamic and can change.
5. Brainstorm ways to resolve this conflict and this dilemma. What if you only lived value A and no longer paid attention to value B? What if you lived both? What if you lived neither?
6. If you can't find any solutions or ways to solve this dilemma, practice self-kindness and self-compassion. Focus on the one

area of life that is most important to you (considering that if someone's health or wellbeing, especially those of minors, depend on your actions, your compassion for others needs should come before self-compassion)

5.13 The Choice Point

What to do if you (or a client) see no point in talking about values? Well it most likely won't be you, otherwise you wouldn't be reading this tool. But say your client really doesn't see the point of reflecting on values. What to do? The advice will be quite simple here. It's their choice. There is no forcing any ideas or concepts onto anyone. The choice always remains with the individual. Of course, you could ask questions such as: If you don't want to explore the things that make your life have a purpose and be meaningful, then what exactly are we doing here? Or you can be a bit more diplomatic using the choice point model created by Dr. Russ Harris.³¹

Values and goals give us our meaning, purpose, and sense of direction in life. Without these, people often feel lost. It might not always be totally clear where we want to go in life. Most people, though, can feel and know when they are going in a direction that is *not the* direction they want to go in. They somehow feel, in their guts, in their hearts, that there is a sense of dryness in life, and often a silent background dialog going on such as "Is this really it?" or "Is this what I am here for?". So our first choice is whether we want to start living and doing the things that really make our lives worthy and valuable (according to our standards). The second choice we make is through our daily actions and behaviors, and whether these are moving us *toward* our value-based living or *away*.



Let's explore this briefly with a short reflection: Choose a current main value, the one that at this very moment is most important to you. This might be the trickiest part of the tool. Remember, there is no right or wrong. If you can't decide, just choose one. If you need to, flip a coin.

Actions or Behavior Moving Me Towards My Values	Actions or Behavior Moving Me Towards My Goals	Actions or Behavior Moving Me Towards My Values	Actions or Behavior Moving Me Away From My Goals
--	---	--	---

During which behaviors or actions could you start applying the choice point model? How?

5.14 Choosing Values

If you are like many people, you might struggle with making choices around values, goals, and other things. It makes sense that it’s difficult to make a choice around these topics. They have serious implications on how we live our lives and how we feel about them. You might also know, though, that you generally struggle with making decisions, even “easy” ones like what to wear in the morning.

This is just a simple practice to help speed up the decision-making process. It can be used for any decisions you need to make where it doesn't really

make a difference whether you choose option 1 or option 2. It's simply that you can't decide, but either result would work just fine.

Pick two values that you currently cannot decide between.

VALUE A: _____

VALUE B: _____

You are going to flip a coin. If you don't have one, you can have a coin randomly flipped in a browser on a phone or computer. Decide whether heads mean value A or value B. Once you have decided, don't change this.

Take a moment, feel into both choices again, prepare to flip the coin.

Then flip the coin.

The result is: _____

So what do you do? Do you go with the result of the coin? No. Usually once the coin lands on either heads or tails, there is an initial reaction in the form of relief, disappointment, and in rare cases, indifference. But usually it's either somehow positive or negative, like you are relieved or disappointed that result x happened. Pay attention to that reaction.

You might not feel it the first time. Start using this technique for very simple choices, like going for a walk, ordering take out or dining in, all kinds of simple choices that don't really make a difference. Start to act on that gut feeling, that gut reaction to the result of you flipping the coin. If you really feel indifference and can't decide, go with what the coin says. If you do that, and then feel a sense of disappointment or regret, you know what's up.

5.15 Struggles & Challenges vs. Rich & Meaningful

We end this chapter with a tool that invites you to go and dig deep into your life: the struggles and challenges and the things that bring you purpose and meaning. There have been many tools to explore all of the different aspects of identifying, pursuing, choosing, and seeing the importance of value-

based living. In this last tool for this chapter, you are invited to look very honestly at your life right now. Try seeing your life like the sides of a medal, the struggles and the challenges that you are currently facing on one side and the potential for a rich and meaningful life on the other.

Please fill in the charts below honestly and openly. Take your time to really reflect and see what new insights and inspirations might arise.

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CURRENT
STRUGGLES & CHALLENGES

Thoughts & Feelings: Repetitive, irrational, obsessive thoughts, worries, memories, self-criticism. Thoughts, emotions, urges and sensations you get caught up in and struggle with.

Action: What are you doing that is keeping you stuck? What is wasting your time, energy, money and somehow has a negative impact on your life, your relationship and/or your health?

POTENTIAL FOR A
RICH & MEANINGFUL LIFE

Values

What truly matters to you? What do you currently stand for? What do you want to stand for? How do you want to be remembered by others? How would you like to grow?

Goals & Actions

How are you currently improving your life in the long run? What do you want to do more or less of? What new things do you want to do or learn? What are goals you currently have that will improve your life? What are specific actions you are taking to achieve these goals?

6. ACT TOOLS FOR COMMITTED ACTION

In the previous chapters, you encountered many tools and practices for the five other steps of ACT: accepting difficulties and struggles, defusing thoughts, emotions, and sensations, coming into more presence, finding a deeper connection with the self, and defining a meaningful, value-based life. ACT therapy wouldn't be complete or worth anything, if we didn't talk about actual change or committed action. Becoming clear on the kind of life we want to live, and then taking the necessary steps to move in that direction. No matter how small the step, we continue to move in the desired direction even in the presence of obstacles. We might change our direction here and there, but not because of the obstacles, but because the underlying values and what is important for us change. For most ACT therapists, committed action is seen as one of the most important steps in ACT therapy and 50% of all ACT therapists hope to see a change in this area after using ACT.³⁶

For this final step, our values need to be defined. It is possible to simply link committed action to desirable and undesirable behavior, meaning setting our goals for the things we want to do more or less. Yet setting goals and committed actions that are directly linked to our values (our inner compass, what drives us), are more likely to bring real transformation. We are more likely to follow these through with persistence and in spite of obstacles, and it is likely that we can enjoy the process of achieving our goals more. In this last chapter, you will find many practice tools helping you to make decisions and move forward with committed action, bringing a real change into your life. You will find less text and explanation, as the foundation has been laid in the other steps and tools, and now it's about moving to action.

Are you ready to explore this final step and these last 15 tools?

6.1 You Have to Start Somewhere

For many people, the biggest struggle with committed action is knowing where to start. If you have a family, kids, a job, and are looking to strengthen the value of “personal growth”, you know things will get busy and tricky before you even start. For anyone, really trying to put yourself first, in a sense of doing exactly what brings meaning and direction to your life, is not easy.

Now, if you are struggling with depression, OCD, trauma, eating disorders, and are maybe even simultaneously “treating” your symptoms through consuming any kind of substances, you probably know even less where to start. How are you supposed to commit to actions in line with your values if your mind is bombarding you with obsessive, anxious, or irrational thoughts? Of course you don’t know where to start. It’s not that straight forward, but it’s not that difficult either. The formula is quite simple: When you don’t know where to start, just start somewhere. You start with the smallest action possible that is somehow directing you in a meaningful way. We see our addiction and just want to heal from it never to drink another glass of alcohol. We see our depression and just want to heal, never to have another situation where we just can’t get out of bed. The patterns of thoughts and behaviors usually take years, even decades, to develop into what they have become. To begin to break the pattern and take baby steps towards healing, just start somewhere.

Let’s look at a few questions together, to see where you can start:

1. Imagine or remember your life, when it was not dominated by your current psychological condition. What did you do that you really enjoyed? What were things that made you feel good about yourself and the world around you? What brought you joy, motivation, laughter?

2. What of these things could you do today?

3. If you had no responsibilities, what would you do?

4. Write about someone you know who really enjoys and lives their life. What if you did the same?

5. What is the smallest baby step that you can take right now in order to live a life that is more in line with your values and dreams?

6. What is the next step? And then the next? Can you define the first 3 steps?

6.2 Making Choices

This final ACT step is all about creating, generating, moving forward, and making life bigger and better. For people struggling with serious psychological illnesses, moving in any direction or making any kind of choices may or may not be possible. In these cases it will be important to come back again and again to desired values, a desired way of living and being reminded of the power to choose. If you are supporting someone on this journey, you can only do so much. You can support, guide by asking the right questions, believe and trust in the other, motivate, be present and supportive. What you cannot do is make any kind of choice or action for them. This is where a lot of frustration, even burnouts happen on the side of the therapists. It is always up to the person longing to make a change whether they take the necessary steps and actions to make that change. One important aspect in any therapeutic approach, including ACT, is inviting clients and patients back into self-responsibility. Of course, you could help as a therapist by highlighting the potential consequences of non-action, but the choice to act always lies with the person wanting to change.

So let's look at the things that either you or the client really want to change.

1. What are current behaviors or actions that are holding you back from living your full potential?

2. What are values that you feel strongly about, but that are somehow currently not expressed in your life?

3. In what areas of your life is there an obvious discrepancy between values you would like to live, and values that you actually live.

Fill out the chart below

What is holding you back?	What values are you not living?	Where are you not living your full truth?

For each column, mark the row that is having the biggest impact on you at the moment.

These are the three things you will begin working with today.

1.

2.

3.

Because sometimes 3 things are already too much, the last step of this tool is to pick one of the three. If you can't decide, go back to tool 5.14, and flip

a coin to help you decide. Remember, it's not about the result of flipping the coin. Rather, it's about how you feel about this result.

Or you can just pick randomly, as all three areas can help you live a more meaningful life. There is no right or wrong. Just begin walking.

6.3 Action Plan

We will provide you with an action plan template in this tool. If this seems a bit technical, it's because it is. Planning goals and committed actions requires the planning of actions, systematically and in a structured way. It might not be as exciting as heart meditation or becoming very intimate with your thoughts and feelings, but it's the way to move forward.

ACT generally suggests contemplating things from a positive perspective like

- What do you want to do more off?
- Where do you want to spend your time?
- What actions and behavior will support your healing and growth most?

Of course, if you are struggling with addiction to substances, you will have goals such as using this substance less, or not at all. Still in ACT therapy, the focus is always more on building and strengthening those things that make life meaningful and valuable to us. The stronger this foundation is, the less likely people will need to look for ways to escape their thoughts, feelings, and emotions. It is much harder to work with negative goals than it is to work with positive ones.

Here is one action plan template you can begin working with:

Here is one action plan template you can begin working with:

VALUE: _____			
Goal	Actions	Barriers	Strategies

			 — — —
Goal	Actions	Barriers	Strategies
			 — — —
Goal	Actions	Barriers	Strategies
			 — — —
Goals	Actions	Barriers	Strategies
			 —

can find the link to the values in there. Do you see it? It is in the R - relevant.

See if you can pick 1 goal from the previous tool, or anything you are currently trying to achieve, and formulate a SMART goal.

MY GOAL IS	
S (specific)	
M (measurable)	
A (achievable)	
R (relevant)	
T (time-bound)	

6.5 Potential Barriers

If you are working in project management in some way or have had a corporate job, some of these tools and methods might sound familiar. It seems strange to bring tools from project management into therapy, but these approaches have shown to work for decades or more, and in many different contexts. When we want to achieve something new, we need a systematic, structured approach to get there. It can be this simple. We have our values. We know where we want to go. Next, we write down our goals, our strategies and actions on how to get there, and then we start walking. It almost seems robotic to function in this way, and as we know from previous commitments we might have made with ourselves, the theory always sounds nice. Practically, things look a bit different. So what happens when we start to walk in the direction of our values, stopping at predefined goals, and continuing on our way? You guessed right. At some point we run into problems. If it's a roadblock or major car accident, or just having taken the wrong exit, reasons for getting off track are different, but it happens.

If you set yourself healthy activity goals, to get you back on track and out of bed, you might stick with this for a week. What if, after a week, you sprain your ankle? You just started to feel better emotionally, less

depressed, more open, more joyful. The physical injury is likely to set you back. You might end up right back in bed, with no energy, and low mood. It's a barrier you have come across. Remember that committed action is moving in the direction of your desired life, and continuing despite any obstacles. So here is a critical point in your healing journey.

1. The first step is to acknowledge that you are coming across a critical point. You analyze what is happening or what has happened and see if you can do anything about this. Are there any short-term interventions you can do? Is there any support you can ask for?
2. The second step is to make a decision on how to deal with this obstacle in a way that supports your committed action and continues to lead you towards your values.

It sounds simpler than it is. Obviously, the bigger the obstacle, the longer the phase of needing to gather and sort yourself, the more external help you might need, and the more persistence and perseverance you might need to bring to stick to your goals. Look back at some of the goals you formulated in earlier tools. Take a moment to reflect on some of the barriers that could potentially happen on the way to achieving the different goals.

My Goals	Potential Barriers	Likelihood to Happen	What You Can Do / How You Can Intervene

--	--	--	--

6.6 Daily Stand Up

Here is another tool and technique from project management. Specifically, this tool is from a more modern approach, agile project management. This approach emphasizes a much less rigid and classical approach to achieving goals, highlighting team effort and regular meeting and immediate interventions, as ways to achieve goals quicker.

The daily stand-up is a 15-minute meeting a project team would have every day at the same time. Usually it follows this structure:

- Meeting length no more than 15 minutes
- Every day, same time, same place
- Meet exactly where the work happens
- All team members should attend

Maybe not all of these aspects are relevant for you or for working with your client. It is unlikely that you will start to have daily stand-ups with clients, to check in on their emotional, physical, and mental well-being. Some elements are quite useful though, and the team concept can be something that you can suggest to clients or try yourself.

Say you set yourself the goal to get out of bed every day at 7 AM for two weeks. That goal is pretty SMART. You could schedule a daily stand-up (in this case literally a stand-up), every day at 7:15. This way, you get out of bed and give yourself 15 minutes to wake up. You meet every day at 7:15 in front of your bathroom mirror. If you have a partner that can support you in this, ask them to attend the daily meeting. There, you take 5 minutes just to check in how you are feeling this morning. You either just tell yourself, or you tell yourself and your partner.

After the 5 minutes stand-up meeting, take 1 minute of just looking in your eyes or the eyes of your partner. Tell yourself you are doing a great job (or

ask your partner to tell you). Close the meeting by smiling at yourself in the mirror or smiling at your partner.

What is my general feeling?

What's going on at the level of the mind?

What's going on in the body?

What's going on with the emotions?

How was this practice for you?

There are hundreds of different variations you could create to design a short stand-up meeting addressing your specific goal (your project so to say). As you can see from this, following our goals with committed action can be quite fun, even playful if we'd like. We sometimes need to remember that we humans get bored, just like children do. If we continue to put ourselves through things that bore us again and again, we lose interest. Adding a little play and fun to our lives goes a long way in the healing journey and in overall life satisfaction.

6.7 Rewarding Yourself

So what do we do once we have achieved a goal? If you are like most people, you check it off your list, and set a new goal. There is little or no moment of recognition, and you might even silently criticize yourself for not having achieved the goal sooner, or take it for granted. We humans are hard on ourselves. We sometimes treat ourselves worse than our enemies.

So let's introduce simple tools that will help you track your progress and define points for celebrating your success. Not only does it make you feel

good to take this moment of acknowledgement and appreciation, but it is also healthy to take a breath, pause for a moment, connect with the present moment, feel the emotion and sensations associated with the achievement, and notice the thoughts. Marinate in that feeling of having achieved what you set yourself to do. We spoke at the very beginning of this book about the reinforcing of patterns, habits, emotions, and beliefs just by doing or thinking them over and over again. The good news is that this also works with positive reinforcement. The happy emotions, warm and tingling sensations, thoughts of pride and accomplishment, feed your neural systems and network. The more often you have these moments, the more natural they will become, and the more natural it will become for you to achieve your goals. You begin to set your goals not with having the thought “*I can’t reach this anyway*” but with having the thought “***I can do this***”.

Let’s take a moment to think of a nice and creative way to reward yourself.

What was something that you loved to receive as a child?

What makes you happy/smile/feel good?

What are creative ways that you can reward yourself?

How can you be rewarded by your family and friends who are supporting you in your goals?

For children, we are so creative in thinking of ways to celebrate and reward them. Stickers for potty training, awards in school, receiving extra allowance, etc. What are some ways we can reward ourselves?

This tool is mostly working with external rewards. It is sometimes nice to receive a little something when we achieve our goals. What’s important here is to NOT reward us with activities or substances that we are attempting to avoid in the long-run (like certain food, alcohol, drugs,

cigarettes). This would defeat the purpose of this tool and reinforce the behavior or actions we are attempting to stop.

6.8 The Smallest Thing You Could Do

What if you or your client just don't know where to start? What if there are so many things to work on in different areas of life? Whether you are struggling with a psychological illness or not, everyone faces this point of being overwhelmed and not knowing where to start at some point in their lives, whether it's because of moving houses, a new job, a newborn baby, or too many projects at work. Things can easily get to being too much, especially when we lack the experience of being in these kinds of situations, or if we are also struggling from a mental illness or are physically sick. You might find yourself so frustrated that you become angry, passive, or even inclined to do exactly the opposite of the kind of life you generally aspire to.

In these moments, it's good to take a break. It's good to take a breath. Ideally, you do both by just going for a walk or going to sit somewhere outside in nature. Step away from the situation and the frustration, close your eyes, and simply feel inside. You can feel inside your heart and see if anything arises. Sometimes what can happen is that this overwhelms and just brings a wave of emotions. These waves of emotions (energies in motion), just need to pass. Usually their last station is "sadness". Then, after some tears are dropped, things often feel somehow easier and less intense. It is like the emotion moved through and out of us. Then you might find yourself ready to go again.

This might not always work, and it might not work right away. Many people are not so connected with their emotions that they can go from overwhelm, to frustration, then anger, and eventually sadness. And of course it doesn't always happen in this order. When we feel ready again, it is important not to overwhelm ourselves again right away, but rather to start with the following:

What is the smallest step or action that you can take towards your goal?

This step can be as tiny as committing to getting up 1 day this week at 7 AM and doing the stand-up meeting with yourself in the bathroom (Tool 6.6). Or it can be even smaller, like agreeing to get up this morning to open the window and let fresh air in (and then going back to bed should you like to).

6.9 Growing Your Commitment Muscle

What happens over time with this approach of persisting to follow your goals, tracking your progress, expecting and navigating barriers, taking a moment in times of overwhelm, celebrating success, etc., is that you train your commitment muscle. Every time you make a tiny little bit of progress, the neural connections in your brain are linked to this behavior and the committed action towards this behavior. You can train your brain to learn anything. Now you can focus on the addictive, dependent, obsessive, and doubtful behavior, or your focus on something that you actually want to achieve. Again, the choice point of moving toward or away from a desired way of living.

Let's get a little creative in this tool: Your task will be to draw your current commitment muscle.

What does your current commitment muscle look like? How big is it? What shape does it have?

Now, what if you grew your commitment muscle a little bit, what would it look like? How would it change?

What could you do to just grow your commitment muscle by a little bit?

6.10 Consequences of Non-Action

Before we move into more practical, daily aspects of how you can support committed actions towards your goals, let's explore one more idea a bit theoretically. Often people think: "*If I just wait and sit out this depression, things will get better.*" Or maybe it's: "*Surely I will learn to stop drinking too much at some point in my life.*" Often there is this belief around certain actions and problematic behavior that they will just go away by themselves. Unfortunately, they usually don't. While we might get a little calmer, less compulsive or obsessive, and certain personality accentuations go away throughout our lives, serious mental illness usually does not get better on its own. On the contrary, we might actually begin to attempt treating our own symptoms unconsciously through overeating, alcohol or drug consumption, or otherwise dissociating or numbing. So the consequence of non-action can actually be more severe. Rarely do we commit actions that further harm us. We don't set ourselves the goal to drink even more this week, or to totally isolate ourselves because of our anxiety. So whatever we set ourselves in the form of committed action, whatever we decide to actually do, is generally good.

Non-action is not the solution.

Tracking Your Progress on Your Fridge:

To motivate yourself, start to keep track of every action you take toward your goals. Keep it simple. Write 1 goal using the SMART formula (6.4) on your fridge. Start keeping count of every action (no matter how small) that you take going in the direction of your goal. It could look like a list of progress you keep for your kids regarding their behavior. If different family members are pursuing different goals, why not track them all on the fridge and make progress and celebration a family thing?

What goals are you tracking?

How are you involving friends and family in the tracking? What creative ways are you including?

6.11 Understanding Our Cyclical Nature

Here is an unconventional tool that can potentially support you quite a bit. Have you ever noticed how your motivation, your drive, your efficiency and capacity to do certain things changes regularly? You might notice how it fluctuates throughout the week, noticing that by Friday you feel drained, and not as productive as the days before. Or even on a Monday, you might not find yourself working at full speed until around lunchtime? And even *during* the day, you might have your highs and lows. You might experience sleepiness and laziness after meals and in the afternoon, while having a super strong focus in the morning hours. We might also notice significant changes throughout the different seasons. For some people the short and cold winter days are perfect to really get projects moving, while other people are finding themselves with extra energy in the summer. We are all cyclical beings (not just women). Learning about and understanding our personal cycles of motivation, efficiency, productivity, stress, anxiety, hormones, etc. is absolutely crucial when following these important endeavors, like changing our lives into a more meaningful and purposeful direction. Without knowing this, we might want to change how we think and do certain things, without noticing that we constantly have our bodies acting against us.

So let's reflect on your personal cycles and rhythms in this tool.

1. During what hours do you find you have the most energy throughout the day (you can mention multiple times)?

2. How do you feel after you eat? How do you help yourself recover quicker after a meal?

3. How do different foods influence how much energy you have and how you feel?

4. What days of the week do you usually have the most energy?

5. What days of the week do you usually have the least energy?

6. How do you feel throughout the different seasons of the year? How do you feel, especially during winter or summer?

7. If you are a woman, how does your menstrual cycle affect your productivity? Your mood? Your overall well-being?

The last one especially can be very important and insightful for women to explore, and to start living more in harmony with their natural cycle.

If we start to understand when our energy and productivity is naturally low, we'll know when it might be better to just have a day or some hours of rest, instead of setting ourselves goals we won't be able to meet. Setting goals around the times we don't feel good or have no energy is like setting yourself up for failure and potentially weakening the commitment muscle. This does not apply if you are suffering from depression and are always finding yourself with no energy, motivation, or drive. In that case, you need to start doing little things to get the body moving, and bit by bit learn to go past the negative and depressive thought patterns of the mind.

6.12 If Only I Was Already Healed

Often clients or patients cannot actually focus on smaller goals because they're completely consumed by the end goal. For most, the end goal and *only* goal, is the healing from the psychological illness. Patients will often say things like "If I were healed from my depression, then I could exercise again" or "If I no longer struggled with anxiety, I could meet my friends again". You might see how this doesn't work. In these cases there are no fairies coming with their magical wands to relieve someone of all of their suffering overnight. It requires understanding and compassion for yourself and your clients/patients in order to support them through this. Of course

they want to be relieved of their suffering, we all do, but maybe it is exactly this misconception and irrational thinking that is causing the illness. So what can you do?

You can support yourself or someone else with some guiding questions, such as:

Since we do not know when “the healing” will be achieved, and if it will take 2, 4, 5, or 10 years, what can you do in the next weeks to live a life that has a purpose and a meaning?

We want to increase the chances of “healing”, so let’s take a look at the different steps you can take to get there. What could these be?

How can you increase the chances of recovery or maybe even expedite the healing?

This tool might be more applicable for patients, but is also something that you can work through yourself, especially if you find yourself often having an excessive focus on the outcome.

6.13 Creating a Supportive Environment

We can create plans over plans. We can do different types of therapies at the same time and come with our very best intention. If we are an alcoholic trying to get sober, yet are surrounding ourselves with the same friends we used to binge-drink with, we might not stay sober. It's the same if we are suffering from general anxiety and just accepted another speech in front of several hundred people, so it might be a hard month to focus on reducing our symptoms of anxiety. Of course there is confrontational therapy and other approaches, bringing us to expose ourselves to a situation, substance, or behavior. Yet in most cases, this isn't the best approach. In order to really be able to follow and stick to our goals, we need to create an environment that supports that. This might seem simple, yet is often underestimated,

especially for people struggling with addiction. What does a supportive environment look like?

- Light and Positive
- People who love and stand behind us
- Alternative, healthy, and fun activities
- Distractions and emergency support (in case of temptations, distracting thoughts, emotions, or sensations)

How can you create the best possible environment for your current top goal?

What do you need to create more or less off?

6.14 Finding an Accountability Partner

Almost coming to an end in this chapter of committed actions, and therefore also to the end of this book, we wanted to give you one more tool that can greatly help you with any endeavor in life. Whether you believe it or not, we humans are pack animals. We are not meant to be alone. As a pack of wolves would care for an injured member, we humans care for those around us who are somehow injured, sick, or weak. It is a modern-day phenomenon that people are feeling isolated, lonely, and left to be sick on their own. When humans were still living in bigger families, even clans, everyone would somehow be involved in the difficulties and lives of the others. Today, we think we have to do it all alone. No matter if we are trying to achieve something, or are suffering from burnout, we think we need to handle and keep the situation to ourselves. A supportive community can actually have quite an impact on an individual's mental and overall health.³⁷

Also, whatever you are trying to achieve, whatever you are trying to overcome and heal, someone will have probably walked this path before you. There is support out there from someone who knows and is already

where you aspire to be. Plus hundreds of thousands of other people in this world are struggling, potentially suffering just like you right now. One of the most effective, simple ways of support can be joining a community of like-minded people. Think of AA, or support groups in your community for new mothers, those struggling with depression, or anxiety. Most likely, whatever it is that you are struggling with, there is a support group near you.

For this tool, we ask you to do two things:

1. Research a support group or person near you. This can also be an individual who has suffered from the same condition or a therapist, psychologist, or counselor.
2. Find and approach an accountability partner.

What is an accountability partner?

This person needs to agree to support you for a certain time frame and for a certain number of goals. Tell this person about your goals and what values are driving them. Tell them why this is important for you. Then let them know exactly what you plan to achieve and how you want to achieve it. Ask them if you can call them if things get tough. Usually it is best to pick a close friend or sometimes also your partner as an accountability partner. Make sure the person feels comfortable and is willing to do this. They don't really have to do anything, unless you ask them specifically, "Could you please call me out the next time you see me drinking?" Not everyone will feel comfortable doing this, and that is OK, too. Most likely if someone is really interested in your healing and has the psychological, mental, and emotional resources they will support you. Make sure you remember that you are the one responsible, not them. At the end of the day, you determine whether you achieve your goals.

Who is your accountability partner? _____

6.15 The Three Options

In any given situation (no matter how difficult or challenging) you have three options:

1. Leave
2. Stay and live by your values (change whatever you can to improve the situation and make room for the pain that might come with the situation)
3. Stay and give up acting effectively (do things that make no difference or make it worse)

Option 1, leaving, is not always available. Say you are in prison. Most likely, you can't just leave. But if leaving is an option, seriously consider it. This is especially the case if you are in a high-conflict relationship, a meaningless job, or in a war-torn country. Your life is likely to be richer and fuller if you leave the situation than if you stay.

Option 3, unfortunately, seems to come quite naturally to us in difficult situations. We get hooked on difficult thoughts, behaviors, or feelings and get pulled into self-defeating patterns and behaviors, keeping us stuck or making things worse.

So the most likely might be option 2. Do what you can to improve the situation. And since you can't always be happy when you are in difficult situations, you need to learn to make room for the pain and the emotions that might come with the situation.

What we need to remember, at all times, is to be gentle with ourselves and to address what we feel ready to address. We cannot solve and change all patterns and difficulties at once. We move in smaller steps, bit by bit, in the direction driven by our values. It may be that our psychological conditions, our difficulties and challenges, remain with us for the long-term, potentially forever. An alcohol or drug addict will always run the risk of falling back into the patterns of abuse and dependence. Someone with several depressive episodes in their life, may have another one at some point, when other life events may cause the glass to spill. We learn to accept and embrace these tendencies and behaviors as part of our personality structure, part of our tendencies. If we heal from them forever, wonderful, if we don't, that's OK, too.

For this case, anyone who has struggled with a mental illness before should have a warning checklist that they regularly consult, just to make sure

things are on track. It is so easy to begin fooling ourselves again, even after years of living a value-based and purpose driven life without mental illness.

Here are some things you could write on the checklist. Make sure you adjust this checklist to your specific situation. If you are in therapy or know a therapist, maybe you can create this list together. If you are asking what this has to do with committed actions, the answer is everything. When we are on our way toward our values, and following our goals, obstacles and difficulties can lie ahead. The nature of most mental illnesses is not being in full transparency and honesty with yourself when you find yourself sliding down the slippery slope again. You might see it, or you might not. But most likely you will not or cannot admit this. Being able to catch yourself before falling requires experience and openness. For many people, it needs an absolute low point, to make a shift.

Through all of the tools in this book and through this last tool following you are invited to live in this absolute honesty and transparency with yourself, and seeing things as they are but from a greater distance.

Your checklist:

- I feel good about myself and my life.
- I accept and love myself.
- I feel that I live a value-based, purposeful life.
- I often feel connected with the present moment.
- I know that even though my thoughts, emotions, and sensations can sometimes be intense, I am not fully identified with them. I feel that something bigger is in control.
- Life might be difficult sometimes, but I am grateful for what life brings me.
- I know the potential barriers, obstacles, and temptations that keep me from reaching my goals.
- I know that even if I have a bad day, that this does not define me.
- I can stand back up, even after I did something I said I didn't want to do anymore.
- I trust in and honor life.

Go through this checklist regularly, and see how many statements you can check off. The more boxes that aren't checked off, the more challenging your current situation might be, and this may be an indicator that a psychological illness is making its comeback. Discuss these questions with a licensed therapist and seek out help should you notice you aren't ticking off too many boxes anymore.

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